

OPERATION CHIMERA

Collected Stories

coffeebyte.dev

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About Operation Chimera

Osyra Renaya is my original character, and the face I use online - the VTuber model I show up as instead of a camera. Operation Chimera is where her story actually gets written down.

She was sixteen when a lab took her apart and put her back together as something part wolf, part human. She lived. Most of the other kids didn't. Now she works for the Agency that cleans up after things like the ones that made her - a Chimeran Operator, callsign Chimera One, sent after the anomalies nobody else comes back from.

The Agency is not the good guys, the company that funded the lab is still in business, and Osyra spends most of her life deciding how much of herself she's willing to spend on a job that was never going to love her back. She saves people because it's the work. That's usually the only reason on offer.

Each book stands on its own and covers a different stretch of her life.

Content Warning

Operation Chimera contains mature and potentially disturbing material across all revisions, including:

-  Mental Health & Trauma - self-harm, suicidal ideation, childhood neglect and abuse, psychological distress, identity crises, substance use
-  Sexual Content - mature sexual themes and suggestive material
-  Medical Experimentation & Bodily Autonomy - non-consensual modification, experiments on minors, captivity, interrogation, torture
-  Violence & Body Horror - graphic violence, mutilation, death, references to human remains, harm to animals and animal-coded characters
-  Cosmic & Eldritch Horror - existential dread, eldritch abominations, anomalous phenomena, cult and occult elements
-  Noir Tone - morally gray protagonists, coercive institutions, surveillance, corporate corruption, strong language
-  Reader discretion is advised. If any of the above could be harmful to you, please skip this series.

Out of the Fray

Out of the Fray

Not written yet. This book has its place in the reading order, but no chapters so far.

Borne Weapon

Chapter 1 - The Application

"Hey. My name is Osyra. This is my video application."

I held up the piece of paper. It bleached the screen - a stark white rectangle in the dark of my room, and the monitor threw it back at me off the inside of my glasses, a bright bar sitting across everything I looked at. The polish on the lenses catches everything in a room this dark. I'd noticed it while setting up and left it. Let the light do what it wants. My hood was up. Between the hood and the glare there was nearly nothing of my face left to see, which was the arrangement I'd landed on after an hour of trying arrangements.

"I'm told someone put my name forward," I said. "That you already know the broad strokes, and you'd rather hear the rest from me. Fine."

"My parents had nothing-I was one mouth too many. They kept me anyway until I was six, and then a school nurse wrote down what that had cost me, and the state took it from there. Foster care, one house after another. Until I was sixteen. Then the man who was supposed to be keeping me sold me to a facility."

I stopped there. Longer than I meant to. I'd written that sentence down and said it out loud maybe forty times in the two hours before I hit record, sanding it flat, taking the feeling out of it word by word until it was just a series of events that had happened to a person. It still cost something to say into a lens. I looked down, and my hair swept past my glasses, and I put my eyes back into the camera and made my face do nothing.

"They ran illegal experiments. Hybridization-splicing animal into human and seeing what lived. I was a line item. A body nobody who mattered would come looking for."

"They had charts of my development, my reflexes, my cellular response. Most of the others didn't survive what they were given. I did. When the place burned down I walked out, and I lived like an animal for the better part of two years-started in the woods, ended up on the street-taking what I needed, answering to no one. Long enough to learn I could."

I took a breath and held it a second before I let it go.

Here was the problem I'd been working the whole time, and I want to be honest that I never solved it, I only ran out of night. They already knew. Somebody in the smoking circle had put my name in and that name came with the rest of it attached, so the ears were not information. They were theater. The only question on the table was who got to do the reveal - them, in a file, in an office, with my photograph on a table between two people who'd never met me. Or me. Once. On my own terms, in my own room, with my own hands.

That's the entire reason I made the video. Not to tell them anything. To be the one holding the hood.

My hands came up off the desk and took the sides of it.

"This is what they made."

I pulled it back in one motion. My hair came down. My ears came up into the cool air of the room and twitched once, on their own, the way they do when they get the temperature of a place.

"Their serum. Chimera 9."

I smiled. There wasn't anything in it.

"I believe this covers the 'unique biological modifications' bullet point from your email."

Then I stopped recording, and watched the whole thing back, because I wasn't going to send a thing I hadn't inspected.

The final frame held on the screen a moment before it let go: red eyes staring out of the dark, black fur stark against black hair, a face I have spent two years making sure nobody sees. It looked exactly like what it was. I made myself sit through it twice.

Then: UPLOAD COMPLETE. Two words on a black background.

I sat back in my chair. The room was quiet except for the hum of the computer. The monitor was the only light in it, laying a soft edge along my hood, the desk, the empty mug.

Five minutes. I didn't move. I'd like to report I was thinking. I wasn't. I was sitting in a dark room having handed strangers the one thing I've never handed anybody, and my body was doing what it does when there's nothing to fight - which is nothing at all, very tightly.

Then a chime. A notification slid into the corner of the screen.

I clicked it, and the dark of the room went out under the white of a new email.

FROM: Miranda Vasquez, MD <m.vasquez@titanreach.com>

SUBJECT: RE: Video Application - Verification Required

SENT: Tonight, 21:17

Applicant Osyra,

Your submission has been received and reviewed.

The nature of the presented physiological claims necessitates a preliminary verification to rule out digital or practical artifice before formal consideration can proceed.

You are required to attend a brief, live video conference at 09:00 tomorrow (your local time). You must present yourself exactly as you appeared in your submitted recording-same environment, same attire. You will be asked to perform simple visual confirmations at my direction.

Confirmation of your attendance is required within the hour.

If verification is satisfactory, you will be scheduled for a comprehensive clinical evaluation at our facility. This on-site evaluation serves as the final stage of the interview process.

This is a procedural necessity.

Miranda Vasquez, MD

Medical Screening Director

Titan Reach Consulting

Below the signature: a secured link and an alphanumeric passcode. The characters looked sharp. Final. A set of keys to a door I had just asked someone to open.

I read *procedural necessity* twice. My tail was curled around the chair leg and it gave one slow twitch, which is the only part of me that has never learned to lie.

No greeting. No reaction. I'd taken the hood off in front of them and they had come back with a scheduling requirement. Somewhere in that building a woman had watched a Chimeran pull her hood back and had thought: *rule out practical artifice*. I'd braced for revulsion. I'd rehearsed for it - I had answers ready for disgust, for fear, for the polite version of both. I had nothing ready for a form letter.

I turned it over and found, underneath, that I preferred it. Nobody had ever looked at what I am and been *bored* before. Bored means the room isn't about my face. Bored means there's a job.

My fingers were over the keyboard. The cursor blinked in the reply field. Out the window the city lights were doing what they always do, which is not care.

I could have not answered. That was still available. Close the laptop, be in the woods by morning, and nothing in my life would have to change, and I sat there long enough to know I was going to say yes and was just charging myself a minute for it first.

I hit reply. Typed one word.

Confirmed.

Sent it.

The screen dimmed to black, and there was only the green pulse of the power light, slow and steady in the dark, like something with a heartbeat waiting in the room with me.

Chapter 2 - The Verification

I didn't sleep much. The kind of tired that sits behind the eyes and hums in the bones. My ears kept tuning to the wrong things - the drip of a tap, something scuttling in the walls, the low thrum of a city that never stops. When I did drift, it wasn't dreams. It was a replay of sensations: the cold press of a stethoscope, the bite of a needle, a scientist's voice noting observations in a flat, delighted tone.

That's what the delight does. It stays. A man can hurt you and the hurt will fade on schedule, but a man who is *pleased* while he does it puts something in the recording that doesn't come out.

I woke before my alarm, grey dawn seeping around the edges of the blinds. My hood was still up.

At 08:55 I was back in the chair. Dark room. The computer's glow. I'd cleared the desk, leaving only the monitor and the camera.

I clicked the link.

The window opened. Just me in a small square, and a larger, empty black one labeled *Dr. Vasquez - Titan Reach*. No picture. No voice. A full minute of nothing, which I understood was not an accident. You don't keep a person waiting by accident at 08:55 when you sent the invitation.

Then her square lit up.

She wasn't what I expected. Younger. Sharp features, dark hair in a severe bun, glasses reflecting her own screen so her eyes were invisible. White lab coat over a black turtleneck. Her background a blur of sleek grey office.

"Osyra," she said. Same voice as the email. Cool. Precise. A diagnostic tool. "Confirm your environment is identical to that of your submission."

I panned the camera slowly - dark walls, empty desk. "It is."

"Good. Posture, please. Sit up straight. Remove your hood."

My hand stopped for a fraction of a second at the edge of the fabric.

Then I pulled it back. My hair fell loose. My ears came up and pivoted forward, tensing toward the laptop speaker, because that's where the voice was and they do that without consulting me. In my own square in the corner of the screen I watched them do it. I watched her gaze lock onto them.

She didn't comment.

"Shoulders," she said. "I need to observe the integration at the trapezius and cervical spine. Rotate them. Forward, then back in a full, slow circle."

It felt absurd. Like a warm-up for a workout video. I did it - rolled them forward, feeling the muscle move under the skin, then back in a wide circle. My tail, out of frame, flicked once.

"Again. Slower."

I complied. Total silence on her end except the faint tap of a keyboard.

"Now, touch your right ear. The outer cartilage. Pinch it gently and pull it forward. Hold it."

Something went hot in my chest.

This was worse than the shoulders, and it took me until my hand was already moving to work out why, because the shoulders were also nonsense and the shoulders hadn't done this. It's that a shoulder is a shoulder. Everyone has one. She was asking me to reach up and take hold of the part of me that is *not human* and present it to a camera with my own hand. Not to be examined. To do the examining to myself, on command, while she watched.

The fur was soft. The cartilage springy under my fingers. I pulled it forward. It felt like holding open a wound so someone can see in.

"Hold for five seconds. Release. Now the left."

I did it. My ears flattened back against my skull the moment I let go, on their own, and I let them, because I had run out of things I was willing to override for her.

"Eyes. Look directly into the camera. Without moving your head, track my finger."

A slender finger entered her frame, moving slowly left, then right, then up, then diagonal. My eyes followed. In my own square the red was blazing out of a dark room, which is what it does, which is the entire reason I don't own a front-facing camera.

"Pupillary response appears normal. Non-standard pigmentation confirmed," she murmured, more to herself than to me. "Final check. Bare your teeth for the camera. Canines specifically."

I pulled my lips back. A snarl I didn't feel. The points caught the light.

A pause. More typing.

"Satisfactory," she said. The word wasn't praise. It was a stamp. "The preliminary verification is complete. We are authorizing the in-person clinical."

She leaned slightly closer to her camera. "Report to the Titan Reach biomedical facility on 12th Avenue. Can you be there for a full-body physical evaluation at 14:00 today?"

Two o'clock. Today. No time to think. No time to back out.

Which was the design. I'd worked that out by then. You don't schedule a person five hours out because five hours is convenient; you do it because five hours is not enough time for the animal to talk itself down off the ledge it just climbed onto. She'd had my file since last night. She knew exactly what she was buying and exactly how long I'd hold still for it.

"It's a comprehensive panel. Blood work, advanced imaging, stress-testing of the modified physiognomy. Consider it a freshening up of your baseline data before field consideration."

Baseline data. There is a filing cabinet somewhere with my baseline data in it, taken when I was sixteen, by men who used that exact phrase.

Field consideration. My ticket out. My leash. Both of those words were sitting on the table and she'd put them there in the same sentence, and I had to decide right then which one I was going to look at.

"Is 14:00 acceptable?" A hint of steel under the calm.

My throat was dry. I managed one stiff nod.

"Verbal confirmation, please."

Of course. Of course verbal. A nod isn't a record.

"Yes," I said, and it scraped on the way out. "Two is fine."

"Good. An appointment confirmation and pass for the front desk will be sent to this email. Do not be late."

Her square went black. The meeting ended.

I sat there looking at my own reflection in the dark monitor. Ears still pinned. Shoulders aching from the pointless rotations.

The rotations were not pointless. That's the thing I keep coming back to. There's no clinical value in a shoulder circle over a video call; she couldn't have measured anything from that feed and she isn't the kind of person who does work with no value in it. She wanted to see whether I'd do it. Whether the thing on the other end of the line would take an absurd instruction from a voice in a box and comply, twice, and then reach up and hold its own ear out for inspection when told.

I passed.

That's what I keep coming back to. I passed, and the test was obedience, and the reward for passing is a building on 12th Avenue at two o'clock.

The clock read 09:07. Less than five hours until I reported to my next examination.

Chapter 3 - The Clinical

The lobby was all muted steel and frosted glass. It smelled of industrial cleaner and recycled air. The woman at the desk scanned my pass with a bored expression, handed me a stack of forms and a clear plastic cup, and pointed down a hall. "First door on the left. Fill the cup halfway, leave it in the wall cabinet. Then change into the gown in the waiting area. Open in back."

The first room was small and brutally functional. A toilet, a sink, a metal cabinet with a numbered slot. The instructions were laminated.

I did as I was told. The whole ritual humiliating in its banality, which I noted at the time and have thought about since - that they'd found a way to make it worse by making it *boring*. The lab at least had the decency to be a horror. This was a Tuesday.

In the alcove, a thin cotton gown. I shed my clothes, ears flattening at the exposure. The gown did nothing for my tail, which I had to thread through the special opening.

The special opening. Someone designed that. Someone at this company sat down and drew a gown with a hole in it, on a Tuesday, and sent it to a manufacturer.

The main waiting room had a few others in gowns. Two guys, maybe early twenties, slouched in plastic chairs - close-cropped hair, the wary stillness of military recruits.

"...they say it's just depth perception," one muttered, not looking at the other. "But my cousin went through, he said they're checking for latent psychic resonance. The 'third eye' test, he called it."

"Bull," the other grunted, picking at his thumbnail. "It's micro-expressions. They're weeding out sociopaths. Friend of a friend failed it, got flagged for 'empathy deficiency.'"

I sat as far from them as I could and pulled the gown tighter.

Nervous chatter. Nothing more. But I'll say this for them: they were both certain the test was secretly about something else, and they were both wrong about what, and they were closer than they knew. Whatever they were afraid of finding, they were afraid of finding it *in themselves*. Nobody in this building was going to look at either of them and write down *fully functional mechanism*.

I kept my head down. My hair made a poor curtain.

A nurse with a tablet called my name. She didn't blink at the ears. "Osyra. This way."

A long, bright hallway with multiple doors. The processing line. First a tiny booth where a technician took my blood pressure, then drew vial after vial, glass filling with dark liquid. "Hydration scan next," she said, handing me a towel for the crook of my arm.

The scan room was cold. I stood on a platform while a ring of light passed over me. "Arms out, please. Hold still." A digital hum, a flicker on a monitor showing a wireframe of my body. The technician's eyes went from the screen to my head, my tail, back to the screen.

He said nothing. He was very careful to say nothing. That's training - somebody taught this man not to react, and he was working at it, and I could see him working at it, which is worse than staring.

Then the coordination room. A different nurse, younger, with Vasquez observing from the corner, arms crossed. "Please walk heel-to-toe along this line." I did. "Now, on your toes only." I rose, tail extending for balance without being asked. "Now your heels." A shuffle. "Good. Now, touch your finger to your nose. Eyes closed." My finger found its mark. My hearing tracked the shift of Vasquez's weight on the floor behind me, because it does that, because it never stops doing that.

"Now," Vasquez said. "Jump. From a standing start. As high as you can."

I bent my knees and pushed. The ceiling tiles came at my face. I came down heavy, knees folding to take the load - a solid, audible *thud* you felt through the platform. Not graceful. A big frame coming back to earth and the floor knowing about it.

"Ground reaction force must be exceptional," the young nurse breathed.

"Proceed," Vasquez snapped.

A blur of small rooms and specific, bizarre commands. A hearing booth where I raised a hand at tones so high the technician kept checking his equipment. A vision test - lines of letters, then shapes on a depth-perception panel. "Now track the light without moving your head." The penlight moved. My eyes followed. My ears angled toward it on their own.

I heard Vasquez make a note.

Then a larger examination room. An exam table, an ultrasound machine, a tray of instruments. Vasquez came in, followed by a younger doctor, Chen, who couldn't stop staring.

"Ms. Osyra," Vasquez said. "We'll begin the musculoskeletal and specific integument assessment."

An hour of directed movement. "Full spinal extension. Hold." I arched back. "Plantar flexion to maximum." I rose onto my toes. "Now, rapid directional changes. Follow the laser." Ten minutes of lunging and pivoting after a red dot, the paper on the floor shredding under my bare feet.

My body performed with a cruel efficiency.

Here's the thing I'd been trying not to arrive at all day, and it arrived anyway, somewhere around minute six of chasing a dot across a floor for strangers.

I know this cadence. *Subject demonstrates exceptional lumbar pliability.* Page forty-two. I have read the sentence. I read all of them, later, when I was in a position to, and I can tell you the rhythm of it the way you'd know a song.

Vasquez was writing the same sentences.

Not similar ones. The same ones, in the same order, for the same reasons, because there is only one way to write down what a body can do and everyone who does it converges on it eventually. The men who did this to me at sixteen and the woman doing it to me at eighteen were not different kinds of people having different kinds of thoughts. They were the same profession.

The difference is the lab strapped me down. Titan Reach mailed me a pass and I drove myself here and I parked.

I chased the dot. I'm aware of what that means. I chased it well.

Chen approached with a handheld scanner. "May I?" he asked, hovering near my ears. I nodded stiffly. He scanned. "Dense cartilage, fully integrated." He produced a clicker. *Click.* Behind me. My left ear swiveled back instantly. *Click.* To the side. Both ears pinned the location.

That is not something I can stop. Understand that, because it's the only part of the afternoon I'd take back. Everything else I did on command. That one I did because a man clicked a clicker in a room and my body answered him.

"Auditory range is significantly extended," Chen reported.

"Eyes," Vasquez said. The ophthalmoscope light hit me. I stared into it and let the red burn. "Pigmentation is structural. Probable superior low-light vision."

"Tail mobility and strength."

This was the worst. Lift a small weight with it. Swish it through specific arcs. Demonstrate its counterbalance during a one-legged stance. The muscle at the base of my spine burned, and under that a shame I've never found the bottom of.

"Fascinating. A fully functional mechanism," Chen murmured to Vasquez.

Mechanism. He said it to her. Not to me. I was six feet away holding a weight off the ground with my spine.

After an eternity of pokes and scans and measurements, Vasquez gave a curt nod. "The physical is concluded. We will now move to the final portion of the evaluation." A glance at Chen. "Doctor, you may go. Send in Dr. Ellen."

Chen left. A moment later, a woman in her forties entered - calm, competent, carrying a new tablet. "Hello, Osyra. I'm Dr. Ellen. This part is standard for all applicants, but given your unique physiology, we need to establish a complete reproductive baseline."

The dread came in cold and immediate.

This is the part their notes were most feverish about. *Cyclical stability. Hormonal integration.* Whatever else the lab wanted, it wanted this, and it wanted it in a way that came off the page.

She started standard - heart rate, palpation of the abdomen. Her hands were professional. When she pressed near my ovaries a jolt went through me, deep, resonant, and she paused, gaze sharpening. "Interesting."

The internal ultrasound was next. Cold gel, intrusive probe. I stared at a crack in the ceiling tile. On the screen, grey shapes swirled. My own insides, looking alien.

"Uterine structure appears normal," she said quietly. "Ovarian activity is... significant. Follicular development is advanced."

She removed the probe and sat on a stool, facing me. Expression neutral, open. "Osyra, I need you to describe your reproductive cycle for me. In your own words. What do you experience?"

The question was a blade.

I had never said it out loud. Not once, to anyone, in two years of living with it. I had said nothing about it to anyone at all, ever, and here was a stranger with a tablet asking me to narrate it in a cold room with gel drying on my stomach, and the terrible part - the part I have never gotten past - is that she was the first person to *ask*. The lab measured it. She asked me what it was like.

"It's not a period," I started, the distinction clawing out of me. "It runs on a different clock. Once a year, in the fall - same stretch every time. I can mark it on a calendar. And it comes in stages."

"Walk me through them."

I kept my voice flat. Read it off like a report. "First I can't settle. Don't sleep. Everything gets too loud, too bright, too much - my own skin feels like it's listening. I get short with people. There's some bleeding, early on, a few days of it." A muscle moved in my jaw. "Then it sharpens into a pull. Toward-" I stopped. Made myself finish. "Toward closeness. Contact. For a few days I want it badly enough that I don't trust myself with it. Then it breaks and I crash - wrung out for a week. After that it's gone for another year."

She nodded, typing. "A seasonal estrous cycle. Photoperiod-triggered - your body reads the shortening daylight and runs the program on schedule. Textbook canid, grafted onto a human frame. The serum rewired your hypothalamic-pituitary axis." She leaned forward slightly.

"Predictable, at least. That helps. But that drive window is a profound liability in the field if it isn't managed."

She wasn't judging. That's what she was doing instead: assessing a flawed asset.

"Given Titan Reach's operational parameters, we will provide a regimen of hormonal regulators. Non-negotiable for field readiness. The prescription and a monitoring kit will be couriered to you."

A chemical leash for the biological one.

And I sat there and turned it over and could not find the objection. That's what I want on the record. It is a liability. She's right. There are three days a year I would not trust myself with a weapon and a door, and I have known that since the first fall, and I have never had a solution for it, and a stranger solved it in ninety seconds with a courier.

The help and the leash were the same object. There was no version where I got one without the other. There has never been a version where I got one without the other - that's the whole architecture of my life, and Titan Reach didn't build it, they just read the schematic and priced it out.

"Understood," I said. The word was ash.

She stood. "Your body is operating on their schedule, Osyra. We're just helping you keep time."

A professional nod, and she left. I don't think she knew what she'd said. I think she meant it kindly.

Vasquez came back in, looking from her clipboard to me. The clinical detachment had hardened into something else. Verification. Conquest. "The Chimera 9 expression is valid and fully integrated. You have passed the final interview."

I dressed in the empty alcove, yanking my hoodie on, hood up the second it cleared my head. The clinic's smell was in my nose and on my skin. No relief. Just a hollow echo where relief should have been.

Passed.

I'd graduated from the lab to a bigger, better-funded cage. The tests were over. Somebody had looked at every part of me and written *valid* next to it.

Somehow that was the worst possible outcome, and it took me a long time to be able to say why: because I wanted it. Because when she said *you have passed* something in me sat up. Twelve years of being a line item - foster paperwork, then lab charts - and I still went warm at a stranger telling me I'd measured up.

They didn't have to break me. They just had to grade me.

Chapter 4 - The Rooftop

A week passed. The couriered package arrived: a blister pack of pills and a clinical-grade basal thermometer.

I left it on the kitchen counter. Untouched. A tiny rebellion, and I knew exactly how tiny while I was having it. Every itch, every sharpened smell, I monitored with a dread that curdled into something like defiance.

This is still mine.

That's the whole argument. That's all I had. It isn't much of one - I was defending my ownership of a thing that was installed in me by men I never consented to meet, which makes it about as mine as a bullet is mine once it's in me. But there's a difference between a thing being done to you and a thing you decide to carry, and the difference is the only property I've ever actually held title to.

The drive window came two weeks after the exam, right on the calendar I've never needed to write down.

Not a surprise. An ambush I chose.

The restlessness I'd carried for days sharpened, by dusk, into something with claws. A wire pulled taut. My apartment turned into a torture chamber of amplified sensation - the fridge motor a jackhammer, the smell of my own skin sour and overwhelming. The pills gleamed on the counter.

Taking them felt like letting them win. Not taking them felt like insanity. I want to note that I could see, even then, that "letting them win" is not a medical consideration. I could see it and it did not move me one inch.

I couldn't be contained. I went to the only place left. The roof.

* * *

The night air was cool on skin that ran too hot and too aware. The city sprawled below, a map of smells and distant sounds. I paced the gravel, tail lashing, ears swiveling at every siren, every shout off the streets. The need was a physical pressure, a hollow pulling throb.

That was when I caught his scent.

It cut through the chemical haze of the city - clean soap, fresh linen, and under it something warm and vital. Human. But distinct. Compelling.

My head snapped up.

He was at the far end of the roof, leaning on the parapet, looking at the skyline. A silhouette.

I was across the roof without deciding to go. My body moved and my mind came along behind it, and I'd like to state plainly that this is the thing I fear most in the world and I did it in under four seconds for a man I could smell.

He turned as I came. Tall. Kind eyes that widened in surprise, then went to careful curiosity as he took me in - the hood, the ears in the moonlight, the agitated tail.

Most people run. Or scream. He watched.

His eyes went from my pinned ears to my too-bright gaze, and his expression shifted from curiosity to a dawning, careful comprehension. He didn't look at my ears like they were costumes. He looked at them like they were symptoms.

"You're... in some kind of trouble," he said softly. Not a question about what I was. A question about the state I was in.

"You shouldn't be up here alone," I said, and it came out a rough scrape. It wasn't a warning. It was a confession.

"Neither should you." Calm. A deep, steady sound that vibrated in my chest. "I'm Leo. I live downstairs."

I stopped a few feet off, close enough that his scent washed over me. The animal screamed to press closer, to rub my cheek against his jacket, to taste the salt on his skin.

I locked my knees to stay still.

"Osyra," I managed.

He nodded, gaze dropping to my twitching ears, then back to my eyes. He didn't flinch from the red. He glanced from my face to the city far below, and something in his expression settled with decision, not fear.

"What do you need?" he asked.

The question was simple and it took me apart.

I didn't have an answer that wasn't primal. *Contact. Pressure. You.*

So I reached out instead. Slowly. Giving him every chance to pull back. My fingertips brushed the back of his hand where it rested on the ledge.

The contact was electric. A jolt that straightened my spine. His skin was cool. My whole world narrowed to that point.

He turned his hand over. Palm up. An invitation, or a surrender.

I slid my fingers into his. His grip was firm. Steadying.

And the floodgate opened - all the frantic scattered energy in me coalesced and ran toward that anchor. The painful edge of it blunted. Not gone. Channeled.

We stood there in the dark, hand in hand, not speaking. The city noise went to a murmur. My breathing slowed to match his. My ears, which had been flicking at everything, relaxed and rotated gently toward the rhythm of his heartbeat. My tail stilled and curled around my own ankle.

It wasn't passion. Not yet. It was something more fundamental. A quieting. A recognition.

The thing in my blood, frantic and howling, saw him and settled.

He lifted our joined hands, thumb stroking a slow line across my knuckles. Unbearably gentle. Human.

"Is this okay?" he whispered.

I leaned my forehead against his shoulder and hid my face in the clean linen smell of his shirt. I nodded.

For the first time since it started, the cage wasn't pressing in. The door wasn't open, but the lock felt less heavy.

He held my hand in the dark, and for a little while I wasn't a subject, or an applicant, or a monster.

I was a girl on a rooftop holding onto something warm, waiting for the heat to break.

* * *

I went inside.

The ghost of his touch felt different under a ceiling. Not like a connection. Like a smudge.

The pill kit sat on the counter. A stark, clinical answer to the mess I'd just made. *Non-negotiable for field readiness*. What a joke. I couldn't manage a hand on a roof.

I punched a pill through the foil.

A small white admission of failure. I'd gone up there to escape the frenzy and what had I done - dragged a stranger into it. Practically glued myself to some poor guy trying to get some air. He'd been kind, which made it worse. He saw a woman in obvious distress and he was decent about it, and he had no idea the distress was an engineered biological command, that I'd honed in on his scent like a predator picks a line.

My skin crawled with it.

The pill wasn't about control going forward. It was an eraser for tonight.

I swallowed it dry. The bitter chalk was a fitting punishment.

* * *

That night the heat didn't vanish, but its meaning changed. The need was still a thrum in my blood; the frantic compulsive story around it was gone. And the memory of leaning on him, of twining my fingers with his, replayed in my head not as solace but as a cringing lapse in judgment.

What was I thinking?

I hadn't been. That was the whole problem.

I fell asleep wrapped in a cold blanket of regret, the arousal reduced to a dull physiological echo, stripped of its dangerous illusion.

* * *

Morning brought a brutal clarity. The fog was gone, burned off by the regulator. With it went the last of the heat's romantic lie.

In the crisp quiet light I saw the rooftop for what it was: a vulnerable, potentially catastrophic mistake. Leo wasn't a point of quiet humanity. He was a variable. An unknown. A random man who now had a very strange story to tell, if he chose to.

My ears flattened as I replayed it. The neediness. The trembling. Offering my name like a gift, when it was just another piece of data I'd handed over for free.

A cold sharp peace cut through me. This was the clarity I needed. No more messing with strangers. No more letting the animal dictate my interactions. The pill gave me the silence to hear my own priorities and they were singular: survive, get control, get out. Anything else was a liability.

I've had a long time to look at that morning, and I want to set down what I've since worked out about it, because I couldn't see it then and it was the whole thing.

Consider what the pill actually did.

It did not make me see the night correctly. It made me see the night *coldly*, and I have spent my entire life treating those as the same word. Cold is my instrument. Cold is how I know something's true. So when I woke up and the memory had gone from *a quieting* to *a lapse*, I didn't experience that as a chemical rewriting my testimony. I experienced it as waking up.

But the man on the roof asked me what I needed and then gave it to me and did not ask for one thing back. That happened. It happened whether or not there was a drug in my blood when I remembered it. The pill did not add any information. It only changed the verdict, and it changed the verdict in exactly the direction the company that couriered it would prefer - toward *variable*, toward *liability*, toward a closed system that doesn't reach for anybody and can be deployed anywhere.

They didn't have to tell me to think that. They just had to make thinking it feel like sobriety.

I never took a second one. I want that on the record, because it matters to what comes after and because I have never told anyone.

One pill. That's all it took. The pack sat on that counter for two weeks and I didn't touch it again - I didn't need to. The heat broke on its own schedule, the way it always does, and by then the thing the pill had done to my memory of the roof was permanent. You don't have to keep taking something that only had to work once.

The placid, emotionless days that followed were a relief, and they were mine. No chemistry in them. That's the part I couldn't see: I'd swallowed one tablet as an eraser and then spent a fortnight doing the erasing myself, for free, and calling it clarity.

Then the phone rang.

Chapter 5 - The Offer

The manufactured quiet was broken by a single phone call. It didn't come from a blocked number. It came with a title.

"This is Lieutenant Colonel Daniel Thorne, Joint Special Operations Personnel Division." A voice carved out of granite, with the ghost of a southern drawl smoothing the edges. No warmth in it. Only authority. "I am contacting you on behalf of our private-sector liaison, Titan Reach Consulting."

My grip tightened on the phone. I was sitting on the fire escape, which was two floors and one week from the rooftop and felt like another country. My tail lay inert.

"They've forwarded your clinical evaluation package, Ms. Osyra. It's... thorough. Dr. Vasquez's notes indicate you possess a... unique aptitude profile."

I heard the subtext. *A controlled asset. Or a loose cannon.*

Both of those are things you buy. Nobody makes a phone call about a third option.

"Titan Reach has a proposal. They field operatives. You've passed the medical. Now you face the practical."

The sun felt interrogative.

"They have a dedicated training curriculum at a secure facility. A final evaluation under simulated high-stress conditions. Think of it as a combine for people who hunt things that shouldn't exist. If you pass, a formal job offer is guaranteed. Full benefits, structured pay, a defined role. A purpose."

A purpose. A structure. Walls to replace the cage. Rules to prevent rooftop mistakes.

"And if I fail?" Flat.

A pause. "Failure in this line of work has permanent consequences. But in the context of the evaluation, it means you walk away. No offer. Your file is closed. Titan Reach considers the matter concluded."

Concluded. Either they'd forget me, or they'd make certain I stopped being a variable. He left the gap on purpose and let me furnish it myself, which is cheaper than a threat and does the same work.

"What does it involve?"

"Need-to-know, delivered on-site. It will assess tactical acumen, threat response, team interoperability, and stress resilience under controlled exposures. All necessary equipment provided. You need only bring yourself."

And the discipline not to compromise yourself. A stranger's hand, sharp in my mind.

"You have forty-eight hours to decide. An NDA will be transmitted. Sign it, and coordinates for transport will follow. Do not sign it, and this conversation never happened."

The line died.

* * *

I sat in the fading light and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was clean, and I want to walk through it exactly as I had it then, because I have never been able to find the error and I have looked.

The pills on my counter were proof I couldn't trust my own biology.

The rooftop was proof I couldn't trust my own judgment once the biology had hold of it.

That's two of the three legs gone. You cannot stand on one. So the only move left was to stop trying to be my own authority and hand the job to something bigger with clearer rules - outsource the trust. Titan Reach doesn't care what I regret. It cares what I can do. There's a kind of mercy in a system that only grades your output, and I had been looking for that mercy my whole life without a name for it.

The recruiter's call was a lifeline thrown off the same ship that designed my storm. It was the only play on the board.

Here's what I couldn't see, sitting on that fire escape with the phone going cold in my hand.

Every piece of evidence in that proof was manufactured by the people making the offer. The clinical established the liability. The courier delivered the fix. The fix wrote the verdict on the roof. And forty-eight hours later a colonel called to tell me the solution to my unreliability was to become theirs.

I had one data point that didn't come from them - a man asking what I needed and then just giving it, on a roof, for free, at no profit to anyone. That one point disproved the whole model. I had already thrown it out. I'd thrown it out the morning after, in a bathroom, and called the throwing-out *clarity*.

I went inside. The NDA glowed on the screen.

I didn't hesitate. The shame of what I'd been with a stranger was a sharper spur than any ambition. It moved me faster than money would have. That's worth noticing, if anyone's keeping score: they didn't have to offer me enough. They only had to make me ashamed of the one hour of my life that hadn't cost anybody anything.

I typed my name.

The screen refreshed. Coordinates. A time: 04:30. **Pack Light.**

I looked at the pills on the counter. Two weeks they'd sat there. I hadn't needed a second one and I wasn't going to - whatever that tablet was for, it had done its work in a single night and the work had held.

I left them where they were and went to find a bag.

The only thing I really needed to pack was the resolve not to be a mistake again.

Chapter 6 - The Combine

Transport was a black SUV with tinted windows and a driver who didn't speak. It felt less like a ride and more like an extradition.

The coordinates led to a private airstrip where a twin-prop, unmarked and utilitarian, swallowed me and two other recruits - a wiry man who kept cracking his knuckles and a woman with a thousand-yard stare who looked at nothing at all. We flew in silence, the drone of the engines a physical pressure in my ears.

We landed on a dusty strip carved into dense evergreen forest. The air was thin and cold and smelled of pine resin and damp earth. A concrete bunker squatted at the tree line. A sign over the heavy double doors: **TITAN REACH - ASSESSMENT & ACCLIMATIZATION FACILITY.**

Inside was harsh fluorescence and echoing linoleum. A bored sergeant at a kiosk took my name, scanned my retina, slapped a plastic wristband on me. "Welcome to the Combine, cadet. Follow the green line. Don't wander. Don't touch anything."

The green line was a literal strip of luminous tape on the floor. It led through a maze of corridors. The place hummed - sterile, purposeful. Clatter of gear. Murmur of voices behind closed doors. The distant thump of something heavy being dropped on a mat.

And everywhere, the stares.

The first cluster saw me as I was funneled into a holding area - a gymnasium converted into a processing hub, rows of temporary cots and locker bays. Maybe two dozen people in various stages of intake, all hard-looking, all sizing each other up.

My hood was up. My tail was visible. The tips of my ears came through my hair.

The murmurs started like a rustle of dry leaves.

"...the hell is that?"

"Check out the tail. No way."

"Costume party's that way, freak."

A big guy with a shaved head and a neck like a tree stump nudged his friend, a lanky redhead. "Look, a Fido. You lose your master, puppy?"

The redhead grinned. "Maybe she's here for the K-9 unit. Wrong door, Furry."

Heat came up my neck. The old kind. The shameful kind, not the biological one.

They're different. I'd never had cause to notice before, and I noticed then, standing on a green line with a duffel: the thing in the fall that makes me want is machinery. It's chimeran. It runs on daylight and it has a courier and a dosage.

This isn't that. This is older than the serum. Nobody engineered the part of me that goes hot when a man calls me a dog - that was installed the ordinary way, by people, in rooms, over years, and there is no tablet for it and there never will be.

I kept my eyes on the green line and my face blank. *Don't react. Don't give them the satisfaction.* Same rule as every lab, every school hallway, every crowded street. I've been running that rule so long it isn't a decision anymore, it's a reflex, and the tragedy of a good reflex is you stop noticing what it costs to fire.

A staff member in grey fatigues appeared with a clipboard. "Osyra. With me. Custom fitting."

I broke from the line and felt every eye bore into my back as I followed him out a side door.

That became the rhythm of the day. Brief periods in the common areas, punctuated by constant solitary summons.

I understood the pattern by the third one and I have never decided whether it was designed. Every time the room started to get used to me, they took me out of it. Every time I came back I was new again, and a new thing in a room full of frightened people is a target. If someone drew that up on a whiteboard, it's the most elegant cruelty I've ever been on the receiving end of. If nobody did - if it's just what happens when a bureaucracy processes an exception - that's worse, because then there's nobody to be angry at.

The gear fitting was in a small armory. A taciturn technician measured me with laser calipers, brow furrowed. "Cranial circumference accounting for auricular structures... cervical spine to lumbar, note the caudal integration point... we'll need a custom helmet, modified body armor for range of motion and tail articulation." He muttered into a headset. "Yeah, send up the prototyping putty. It's the chimera candidate."

It's the chimera candidate. Not *she's here*. Not even a name. I was standing close enough to touch him.

Back in the gym, a new group had arrived. The whispers were louder now. More confident.

"Ugly as sin. What kind of sick mod is that?"

"Bet it smells like wet dog."

I found a vacant cot in a corner and sat with my knees pulled up, making myself small. Six foot four and making myself small. The stares had weight.

Then a different summons. "Osyra. Medical Bay 3. Vaccine protocol."

In a stark white room a doctor with a nervous smile consulted a thick digital file. "Ah, yes. Subject presents with a recombinant retro-viral integration. Standard immunoboosters are contraindicated. We'll be administering a tailored series to avoid triggering an autoimmune response against the non-human cellular lines."

The non-human cellular lines. Mine. He meant mine. He said it to the file.

The shots burned - a deep aching cold spreading out from the sites.

Each time I came back to the gym the hostility had crystallized a degree further. I wasn't a curiosity anymore. I was a target, and I understood exactly what for, because it's the same everywhere and I've watched it work my whole life.

Two dozen people in that room were terrified. Every one of them had signed something they didn't fully read to come to a bunker in a forest to be tested at something they might fail. That fear has to go somewhere. It cannot go up the chain - the chain is what they're afraid of. So it goes sideways, and it lands on whatever's furthest from the middle, and in that gymnasium the furthest thing from the middle was six foot four with ears.

I was doing them a service. That's what sits badly. Every joke about the dog was a man moving his fear off his own back and onto mine, and it worked - I could see it working, I could see the shoulders come down after - and none of them will ever know they used me for it.

"Hey, Mutant," the big one - Stumps - called as I came back from medical with my arm throbbing. "They giving you your rabies shot? Should be mandatory."

A few chuckles rippled around him.

I kept walking. Tail rigid. Ears flat inside my hood.

Chapter 7 - The Prototype

That was when a new voice cut through. Quiet, but carrying a strange deliberate intensity.

"Shut up, Evers."

It came from a recruit leaning against the lockers. Tall, leanly built, sharp watchful features, dark hair cropped close. His eyes - a pale crystalline grey - were fixed not on me but on Stumps. No anger in his face. Just cool assessment.

Stumps puffed up. "What'd you say, pretty boy?"

The lean one pushed off the lockers. He didn't move aggressively. He moved with a relaxed economy that was somehow worse. He glanced at me, gaze sweeping from my hidden ears to my posture and back to Stumps, and his eyes widened a fraction, like he was connecting dots only he could see.

"I said, shut up. You have no idea what you're looking at."

"I'm looking at a circus act," Stumps sneered.

The lean one shook his head slowly, a faint almost awed smile touching his mouth. He looked back at me, and this time the stare wasn't disgust or mockery.

It was fascination. Unvarnished. Awe.

"No," he said, loud enough for the others. A hush fell, eager for new drama. "You're looking at a prototype. I've heard whispers about this. Deep-bio black ops stuff. They don't mod for looks. They mod for function."

He took a step closer, eyes locked on me like I was a fascinating blueprint.

"Look at the base of the spine. Perfect for balance and kinetic transfer. The auricular mobility? 360-degree audio surveillance, no tech required. The ocular pigmentation? That's for low-light and thermal tracking."

He was making it up. I could hear him making it up - the cadence of a man assembling a theory out loud and falling in love with it as it comes. His conviction was magnetic and there was not one sourced fact in it.

He was also right. That's the joke. Everything he invented, they did on purpose. Not for the reasons he said and not for the war he imagined, but a room full of men did sit down and decide what my spine was going to be for. He got the answer right off a wrong proof, which is the most common way anyone has ever been right about me.

"They didn't make a pet. They built a super-soldier. And you're calling it names."

The silence in our corner was absolute. Stumps's bluster deflated into a dawning uncertain fear. The others stared at me with new eyes - not a monster now. A weapon. The mockery gone, replaced by wary calculating distance.

The lean one held my gaze a moment longer.

No pity in it. No kindness either. Just the cool approving gleam of a fanatic recognizing a superior piece of engineering. He gave me a slight, almost imperceptible nod.

Then he turned and walked away, leaving a void of tense quiet behind him.

* * *

I sat back down on my cot with his words going around in my head. *Super-soldier. Prototype. Built.*

He hadn't defended me. I want to be precise, because for about four seconds I thought he had, and those four seconds were embarrassing. He didn't say *she's a person, leave her alone*. He said *you're too stupid to see what that is*. He moved me from one shelf to another. Both shelves are in a display case.

But the stares had changed, and that was worth something. Not mocking now. Wary. Calculating. Stumps wouldn't meet my eyes at all.

Fear is a cleaner barrier than contempt. It's simpler. It gives you room.

I pulled my hood tighter. And somewhere under the flat surface I keep over everything, something pragmatic came together.

Here's the trade, laid out honestly, the way I laid it out then.

They will never let me be a person in this building. That option is not on the table and I did not put it there and I cannot put it there. What's on the table is *pet* or *weapon*. Those are the two shelves. Fido, or prototype.

Pet costs me everything and buys nothing. Weapon costs me the same thing - it costs being seen, it costs any chance that one of these two dozen people ever looks at me and thinks *her* - and it buys distance. Distance is the only currency in a room like that. I have spent my life shopping in stores that only carry two items and I have gotten very good at knowing which one is cheaper.

So: let them have the weapon. Lean into the rumor. Wear their awed fear like a cloak. They want to see a thing that was built? Fine. It's better than being a pet, a freak, a Fido. Inside these walls, performance is everything. I could get respect out of this, or at least a safe radius, by pretending to

be exactly the monster they'd already decided I was.

It's a good trade. It's the best available trade. I made it in about thirty seconds on a cot in a gymnasium and I'd make it again.

I noticed, distantly, the way you notice weather through a window, that I was agreeing to be the thing the lab built. That the men who put their hands on me at sixteen would have found this outcome entirely satisfactory. That somewhere there's a file with my name on it and a column marked *disposition*, and I had just, voluntarily, at no cost to anybody, filled it in.

I noticed it and nothing moved. That's mine. Nobody drugged me into that. I have been doing it to myself for years and I am better at it than any chemist.

Boot camp hadn't officially started, and I was already alone in a room full of people. But now, at least, I had a role to play.

Chapter 8 - Shark Attack

The tension in the gymnasium settled into a fragile watchful stalemate over the week. The mockery died, choked off by the super-soldier rumor and by my own deliberate silence.

I perfected the stare. A flat unblinking look that makes red eyes read less like a flaw and more like a targeting laser. I'd aim it at anyone who lingered and they'd find something else to look at.

It works. That's what I'd underestimated. I'd spent my whole life trying to be smaller and it turns out the whole time there was a lever right there marked *be worse* and it works instantly and costs nothing up front.

Processing was a blur of custom fittings, psych evals, endless waiting. On the second day they issued the uniform: standard Titan Reach fatigues, digital grey-green, but mine had been subtly altered. Collar widened. Trousers reinforced with a gusset of tougher material at the base of the spine.

Wearing it felt strange. Less like clothes. More like being fitted for a new and official kind of skin.

The message was clear, and it was two messages at once, which I think is the most honest thing that building ever said to me: *you are standardized* and *you are apart*. Same garment. They had to build a special version of the uniform that makes everyone the same.

The helmet came the same day, in its own hard case, because it couldn't go in a duffel with the standard kit - wrong shape, wrong shell, two channels moulded into the crown that no other helmet on the manifest has. The technician handed it to me like it was ordinary.

Everyone else's helmet went in the bag. Mine came with luggage.

* * *

The day of transport to the main barracks, the distinction went public.

Pre-dawn formation in the yard outside the bunker. Fifty of us, a ragged shivering line in identical fatigues, clutching duffels of standard-issue gear. No discipline yet. Just a jostling anxious crowd.

A staff sergeant with a face like a hatchet stood on a crate. "Listen up, maggots! You are no longer civilians. You are names on a manifest. You will be addressed by your last names, and you will respond with 'Yes, Sergeant!' or 'No, Sergeant!' Is that understood?"

A mumbled uneven chorus came back.

"Pathetic! Now, first row, move! And keep your traps shut!"

As the first recruits shuffled toward the idling bus, his eyes found me at the back. He pointed a rigid finger.

"You. Renaya. The special project. You're separate. You do not board until I say. You will take the last seat, the one marked with red tape. You will not speak to anyone. You follow all instructions given to the group, but you do it alone. You are not part of this platoon. You are an attachment. Do you comprehend?"

Every head in uniform turned.

Renaya. He used my name. It was the first time in that building anybody had, and he used it to explain to fifty people that I wasn't one of them.

"Yes, Sergeant," I said. Clear and toneless.

"Good. Remember it."

One by one the last names were barked and recruits filed on. I watched them go with my duffel at my feet. Finally: "Renaya! Forward!"

I walked the gauntlet of faces in the bus windows. Curious. Hostile. Afraid. I climbed the steps. The interior was silent, the air thick.

And there at the very back was a single seat, its cracked vinyl marked with a glaring X of red duct tape.

An island. Somebody had gone out there with a roll of tape, before dawn, and marked it. That's a work order. Somewhere there's a line item for the tape.

"Sit!" the sergeant yelled from outside.

I slid in and stowed my gear. The space around me felt electrically charged. A buffer zone of pure isolation. The driver closed the door and the bus lurched forward, winding deeper into the forest.

* * *

For the first hour, tense exhausted quiet.

Then, thirty minutes out, it began.

A single brutal shout from the front. A drill instructor I hadn't seen board was suddenly on his feet, face contorted with fury.

"WHAT IS THIS, A GIRL SCOUT TOUR? THIS BUS IS NOW A WARZONE! HEADS! BETWEEN! YOUR! KNEES! NOW! ALL OF YOU! DO IT!"

Chaos. Recruits fumbled, diving forward, caps tumbling. "I CAN'T HEAR YOUR FOREHEADS HITTING THE SEATS! HARDER! YOU THINK THE ENEMY GIVES YOU NECK PILLOWS?"

The Shark Attack. The deliberate overwhelming verbal assault built to erase individuality and install instant blind obedience. He paced the aisle, voice a constant deafening percussion against the metal shell.

"NO LOOKING! EYES ON YOUR BOOTS OR THE DECK! YOU LOOK AT ME, I'LL PERSONALLY PEEL YOUR EYELIDS BACK! SHUT UP! THE ONLY SOUND I WANT IS YOUR WEAK LITTLE HEARTS TRYING NOT TO GIVE OUT!"

I followed the order, forehead against the hard shell of the helmet case in my hands, the stiff brim of my cap digging into my wrist. My ears, pinned flat under it, rang with the volume. Every shout a physical slap.

He did not single me out.

His boots crunched past the red-taped seat without pause. I was just another recruit in fatigues with my head down, obeying.

"YOU ARE NOTHING! YOU ARE WORTHLESS! YOU WILL DO WHAT YOU ARE TOLD, WHEN YOU ARE TOLD, HOW YOU ARE TOLD! YOUR GEAR IS YOUR ONLY FRIEND! GET IT BETWEEN YOUR LEGS! HUG IT! LOVE IT! IT'S THE ONLY THING THAT MIGHT SAVE YOUR MISERABLE LIFE!"

The bus echoed with scrambling, with duffels wrestled into position, with panicked held breaths.

And I want to put down what happened in me during that half hour, because I have not been able to explain it to anybody since and I am not sure it reflects well on me.

It was the best I had felt in two years.

You are nothing. He screamed it at fifty people and he meant every one of them and he did not look at me when he said it. Nobody in that bus was a chimera candidate. Nobody was an auricular structure or a caudal integration point or a non-human cellular line. We were all worthless, identically, at the top of a man's lungs, and for thirty minutes I was not the exception to anything.

That's all it took. That's the entire price of admission to the human race, as far as I can tell: find someone who hates everyone equally.

I hugged a duffel between my knees with my forehead on a helmet case and my ears bleeding sound, and I was so grateful I could have laughed.

The Shark Attack ran the whole final half hour. By the time the bus crunched onto gravel, the silence that replaced the shouting was hollow and ringing. My neck ached. My hands were numb from gripping the case.

"OFF MY BUS! NOW! MOVE, MOVE, MOVE! FORM A LINE ON THE YARD! DUFFELS AT YOUR FEET! EYES FRONT! MOVE LIKE YOUR LIVES DEPEND ON IT, BECAUSE STARTING TODAY, THEY DO!"

Recruits stumbled into the aisle, uniforms rumpled, movements jerky with residual fear.

I waited, as instructed, until the bus was nearly empty. Then I stood, adjusted my cap, slung my duffel, took up the case.

Last one down the steps.

* * *

The yard was shell-shocked recruits trying to form lines under the blistering shouts of three drill instructors. One of them - a mountain of a man with a shaved scalp and the same voice that had run the bus - saw me. His eyes took in the uniform, the case, my position. No personal malice in them. Just the flat assessing glare he'd give any piece of irregular equipment on his manifest.

"RENAYA!" he bellowed. Not a taunt. A designation. "The attachment! You don't get in line! You stand there!" He pointed to a spot ten feet left of the ragged formation, the gesture as precise as a surveyor's. "You are a shadow! You follow all training, but you are not of this platoon! Understood?"

"Understood, Drill Sergeant!" I shouted. Raw in my throat.

I marched to the spot, dropped my duffel, snapped to attention, the case rigid at my side.

Thirty minutes. That's how long it lasted. Off the bus and back onto my own square of gravel, ten feet from everybody, measured out by a man with a pointing finger.

He gave me one final impersonal glance - a commander confirming a logistical detail - then turned his full terrifying focus back to the platoon. "WHAT ARE YOU STARING AT, MAGGOTS? YOUR JOB IS TO LEARN, NOT GAPE! EYES FRONT!"

I stared straight ahead, over the heads of the identically dressed recruits, at the stark grey wall of the nearest barracks.

The case bit into my palm through the glove. The Shark Attack's adrenaline was still going in my veins with nowhere to put itself.

Ten feet. It's not far. You could hand somebody a cup of coffee across ten feet.

Chapter 9 - Broken Down

The first week wasn't about being different. It was about being broken down.

The humiliation was total and it was democratic. It wasn't personal, because nothing there was personal. You were a body in uniform and your body was weak, slow, and stupid. One recruit fumbled a drill step and the whole platoon paid in push-ups on the gravel, the DI's voice shredding the air above us. Somebody's footlocker sat a millimeter out of alignment at inspection and we all stood at attention for an hour in the biting cold while he methodically dumped every locker in the bay onto the floor.

The lesson was a blunt instrument: you are a cell in an organism. One cell fails, the whole body suffers.

I understood the architecture of it within about two days, and I want to be fair to them - it's good work. It is the most efficient machine for making a group out of strangers that I have ever been inside of. You don't build loyalty by asking for it. You build it by charging everyone for one person's mistake until the arithmetic makes them each other's problem.

I could see it working. I watched it work on fifty people.

It did not work on me, and not because I resisted it. Because you can't be made into a cell of an organism from ten feet outside the organism.

My status as *the attachment* meant I stood apart during formations but suffered alongside them for the consequences. I did the push-ups. I stood in the cold. I scrubbed. And I did all of it a full head taller than almost everyone.

At six-four my height had always been a fact. In ranks of recruits averaging five-ten it became a permanent feature of the landscape. I had to consciously slump during some drills to not break the line - a habit the DIs beat out of me fast.

"STAND AT YOUR GOD-GIVEN ATTENTION, RENAYA! DON'T APOLOGIZE FOR THE BLUEPRINT!"

God-given. That's the joke, and he'll never know he made it.

There was so much cleaning. Floors had to gleam like obsidian. Latrines had to smell of nothing but bleach. We scrubbed with toothbrushes, with rags, with our own fingernails. Industrial cleaner became a permanent note in the back of my throat. My height was an advantage there - no shelf out of reach, so I got the high dusting and the light fixtures while the others grumbled at baseboards.

Physical training was a relentless grind. Calisthenics at 0400 in the dark. Long grueling runs in formation, the pack's rhythm a punishing collective heartbeat. My physiology handled the cardio better than most - my lungs burned but they didn't scream - and my legs gave me a stride that made the runs feel almost natural, though I had to check my pace constantly to keep from overtaking the file.

Constantly. Every run. That's the detail I'd give anyone who asked what that month was actually like: I spent it running slower than I can run, so that a line of men could stay in front of me.

The volume of it wore on everyone. My muscles ached with a new deep fatigue and my tail often felt like dead weight, a clumsy appendage I had to consciously tuck and control.

By the third day a plague of respiratory illness swept the bay. Wet hacking coughs and congested sniffing, a constant chorus. Sinus pain made faces puffy and eyes watery. The DIs showed no mercy. "I DON'T CARE IF YOU'RE COUGHING UP A LUNG, MAGGOT! YOU MOVE!"

I watched recruits stumble through drills shivering with fever and collapse afterward.

I stayed healthy. Another side-effect - the lab's logs called it a *robust adaptive immune response*, and there's a man somewhere who was proud of that sentence.

So I moved through a bay full of sick people at full strength, looking down at them from a height nobody asked me to have, and there is no version of that where you come out clean. I couldn't be sick with them. It's the only thing they all had in common that week and I couldn't have it. Every morning I was fine and fifty people weren't, and the fine was doing more damage to my standing in that room than the ears ever did.

* * *

Then came the weapons.

The armory was a temple of oil and cold metal. We filed past and the armorer, a grizzled specialist with sergeant's stripes, called assignments. "Smith, M4. Gonzalez, M4. Carter, M4."

He reached me. His eyes flicked from the manifest up to my face - a longer journey than for most - then to a different, heavier rack.

"Renaya. Mk 13 Mod 7. .300 Winchester Magnum. Bolt-action precision rifle. With this."

He handed it over.

It was a beast. Over four feet long, thick fluted barrel, massive muzzle brake, chunky telescopic sight. The weight settled into my hands - a dense profound thirteen pounds of steel and polymer and glass. Less a weapon than a piece of industrial machinery meant to be mounted on something.

Compared to the M4s the others cradled like toys, it was from another world.

In my hands, its scale made sense. It didn't look oversized. It looked correct.

I stood there in a cold room holding the first object I have ever been handed that was the right size, and I want to say I felt nothing about that, and I did feel something about it, and I have never liked what.

A stunned silence, then a sharp collective intake of breath. Heads turned. A recruit named Finch, two people ahead, craned his neck, eyes wide as saucers.

Before he could blink, the armorer's voice cracked like a whip. "FINCH! YOU SEE SOMETHING PRETTY? YOU ON A TOUR? YOUR WEAPON IS IN YOUR HANDS! EYES ON YOUR OWN GEAR UNLESS YOU WANT TO CLEAN EVERY WEAPON IN THIS ARMORY WITH A TOOTHBRUSH!"

Finch's head snapped forward so fast I heard his neck pop.

The lesson was immediate: staring at the anomaly is a failure of focus.

It became a pattern. Zeroing on the range, settling in behind the rifle, I'd feel eyes. A flicker in my peripheral vision.

"HILL! YOU TRYING TO LEARN BY OSMOSIS? WISHING WON'T MAKE YOUR GROUPING TIGHTER! FOCUS ON YOUR FRONT SIGHT POST OR I'LL HAVE YOU WEARING IT AS AN EARRING!"

On a march, someone stumbling behind me would gawk at the rifle on my shoulder or the tip of my tail keeping time with the walk.

"VALDEZ! THE ROAD IS IN FRONT OF YOU, NOT ON HER BACK! YOU LOST? NEED A MAP? PICK UP THE PACE AND WATCH YOUR SECTOR!"

The DIs never mocked me for being looked at. They mocked the others for looking.

It took me a while to see it whole, and when I did I had to admire it, the way you admire a trap that's already closed on you. They never had to say *don't call her a dog*. They never issued a rule about it. They simply made looking at me expensive, and the men stopped looking, and the discipline they were building got built out of the material I was standing there being.

My difference wasn't a source of personal humiliation anymore. It was a test for everyone else. A distraction to be overcome. A temptation to fail. Every head that turned my way was an excuse for a DI to pounce, punish, reinforce the only thing that mattered: the task.

My presence became a metric of their discipline. I was equipment they were being graded on ignoring.

I couldn't decide then whether that was kindness. I've had years and I still can't. It worked. It got me quiet. It cost them nothing and it cost me the last thing I had, which was the possibility that one of those fifty people might have looked at me on purpose, for a reason of his own.

* * *

The drawback of the Mk 13 was constant and grinding. So was the advantage, and it showed up during a tactical drill.

We were simulating perimeter guard. The DI pointed at me. "Renaya! That cannon is a liability inside ten meters. Simulate a security hand-off. Briggs! Secure her primary!"

Briggs had muscles on his muscles and stood a good eight inches shorter. He stepped forward. His eyes darted from my face to the rifle - that same flicker of awe and apprehension.

"BRIGGS! YOU TAKING A CENSUS OF HER FEATURES OR SECURING A WEAPON? MOVE!"

He snapped to, but the damage was done. He was already off-balance.

I unslung the Mk 13 and passed it over. The moment the full weight transferred his body jerked, eyes widening as his posture sank, arms tightening instinctively to wrestle the unexpected heft.

"Looks like a struggle, Briggs! You admiring the craftsmanship or fighting a bear? Renaya, you're weaponless! Demonstrate a hostile take-down. Non-lethal. Go."

Unburdened by thirteen pounds of anchor, my body became pure potential.

I was across the gap in one long stride before he could reset. I used his rooted unbalanced posture against him, my longer arms bypassing his guard, swept his legs, drove him to the mat with a controlled thud.

Controlled. I want that word to stand, because I put it there deliberately and it is doing a lot of work.

I did not decide any of that. Not one piece of it. The word *go* left the man's mouth and something in me that is faster than I am read Briggs's stance, found the weight on his heels, and took him down, and by the time I arrived the job was finished and my hands were empty and a man was on his back looking up at me.

The *controlled* was the only part I contributed. Somewhere in the middle of it, whatever runs that machinery let me put a hand on the throttle, and I have thought about that a great deal since. It let me. It could have not.

I stood there on a mat in a forest with fifty people watching and understood, in a way the clinical never managed, what they actually put in me.

The DI didn't praise. He narrated, voice cutting through the damp air while the platoon stood rigid with their eyes fixed on nothing.

"Observe. The hammer is heavy. The arm is built to carry it. A tool for every task." He let the silence hang. "Briggs, firewatch. The rest of you, look alive - at your own damn jobs."

The arm is built to carry it.

It was a visceral, undeniable lesson. My *different* was a tactical specification, and noticing it was a punishable lapse.

The recruits learned. The stares didn't stop; they went covert, fleeting, followed by an immediate paranoid snap back to whatever they were supposed to be doing.

I wasn't a spectacle anymore. I was a hazard. A distraction hazard.

It was the most anonymity I'd had since I got there. I'll take it. That's the sentence I keep arriving at and I've stopped fighting it: they turned me into a piece of equipment that fifty men were punished for perceiving, and I'll take it, because the alternative was Fido.

* * *

The only respite was food.

The chow hall was a haven of shocking greasy abundance. The food was, against all odds, awesome. Giant portions of pasta, real eggs, mountains of potatoes. Calories as fuel, and we were furnaces. My metabolism and my size demanded a shocking amount of it. I ate with mechanical focus, often going back for seconds while others picked at their plates. Even the MREs were acceptable in their weird vacuum-sealed way.

At the table, for fifteen minutes at a time, we weren't maggots. We were hungry animals refueling in silence.

We. Fifteen minutes a day, three times, and it's the only place in this account where I get to use that word about a room with other people in it.

I sat alone, as always, at the end of a table. But the space around me had stopped feeling like exile and started feeling like a cleared range. Nobody looked too long. Nobody sat too close. I could eat in peace, the monstrous rifle leaning against the table like a silent guardian.

I was the one who carried the thirteen-pound answer, and I was built on a scale that made it look logical. And if you were smart, you kept your eyes on your own tray.

I took a bite of gravy-soaked meatloaf. It was fuel. For now that was enough.

The rest was just physics, and I was finally starting to feel like I was built for the equation - which is a sentence I would have found horrifying two months earlier, and which I thought that evening with something I'd have to call contentment.

The silence of their averted eyes was the closest thing to respect I was likely to get. I did the arithmetic on that too, at that table, with my mouth full.

It came out yes.

Chapter 10 - The Trials

The gas chamber was a small concrete-block building that smelled, even from outside, like dread and old chemicals.

We lined up in our protective masks, the tight rubber seals alien against my face, pressing my ears flat. Sergeant Hale stood by the door, his own mask making him look like a giant unfeeling insect.

"This is CS gas. Tear gas. It will not kill you. It will make you wish you were dead. The point is to trust your gear, and to learn how to clear and seal your mask under stress. You will enter, form a line, and on my command, you will break the seal, remove your mask, state your name and rank, then reseal. Anyone who runs for the door before I say 'go' repeats. Anyone who doesn't complete the exercise repeats. Understood?"

"YES, SERGEANT!"

One by one we filed into the thick hazy air. Even masked, my eyes started to water. The air had a sharp metallic taste that seeped through.

Then my turn.

"RENAYA! BREAK SEAL AND REMOVE!"

I pulled the mask off my face.

The world dissolved into instant agonizing fire. Like inhaling crushed glass and hornets. My lungs seized, a raw scraping cough tearing out of me. My eyes flooded, vision smearing into grey walls and green uniforms.

And it was exactly as bad as it was for everyone else in that room.

No worse. No special weakness the lab had built in. Just the same chemical hell, democratically applied. It sat in my sinuses and the back of my throat a little longer - sharper senses, slower to stop screaming - but that's a rounding error.

The great equalizer. In there I was one more body drowning in its own mucus.

"NAME AND RANK!" Hale bellowed from somewhere in the burning fog.

I tried to suck air to speak and got a mouthful of fire. "RENAYA-!" A strangled rasp before a coughing fit doubled me over. Snot pouring from my nose, thick and uncontrollable.

All around me the sounds were the same. Retching, gagging, the wet desperate hacking of fifty people drowning in their own mucus. The respiratory plague that had haunted the bay for a week was instantly, violently cured. Nobody was congested anymore. Every passage ruthlessly, painfully

clear.

I'd spent a week being the only healthy body in a sick room. It took a concrete shed full of poison gas to get me admitted.

"SEAL YOUR MASK!"

I fumbled the rubber back over my face, fingers slick with tears and snot, and sucked in the sweet filtered air. Instantaneous relief, though the burning lingered another hour, the way it did for everyone.

We stumbled out into the clean cold daylight, faces raw and shining, all of us united in a new profound understanding of misery.

For a few minutes, nobody looked at me. They were too busy trying to remember how to breathe.

* * *

Night ops came a week later.

They issued night-vision goggles - heavy bulky units that turned the world into a ghostly green landscape of vague shapes and halos. We practiced moving in squads, communicating in whispers, the gear hissing and whining in our ears.

I tried to use them. I did try.

The amplified light was overwhelming, washing out detail, and the limited field of view was like looking through two foggy soda bottles. It was harder to see with them than without.

During a navigation exercise, moving through dense woods, I finally lifted them onto my forehead.

The world didn't just brighten. It clarified.

The darkness wasn't an obstacle. It was a different palette. Deep shadows held texture and depth. I could tell the grey of a rock from the grey of a root, see the path of crushed leaves, track the heat-shimmer of a recruit ten yards off as a faint rippling disturbance in the cool air. My pupils gathered every stray photon. I could hear the lieutenant's whispered commands from two squads over with perfect clarity.

I read the real night like a cloudy twilight, and fifty people around me stumbled through an electronic haze.

"Renaya, why are your NODs stowed?" A hiss. Corporal Vance, training cadre.

"They degrade my natural sight, Corporal. My night vision is sufficient."

A long pause. I could feel his stare in the dark, and he couldn't see my face at all, and there was something in that worth having.

"Noted. Keep up. And don't make me regret this."

I didn't make him regret it.

By the end of the exercise I was quietly directing my squad around obstacles I could see and they couldn't, my whispers keeping them out of ditches and off low branches. Nobody thanked me. But when we reassembled, ours was the only squad without a sprained ankle or a face full of spiderwebs.

The looks weren't fear or disgust anymore. They were grim practical acknowledgment.

I'll take that trade too. I was starting to notice how many trades I'd taken.

* * *

The PT tests were where it shifted, almost imperceptibly.

Straightforward: two-mile run, max push-ups in two minutes, max sit-ups in two, pull-ups. For me they were laughable. My body performed with a cold efficiency that unsettled even me.

But standing there panting lightly after the run, watching others stagger across the line with faces purple from strain, something strange happened.

I didn't feel smug. I felt impatient.

"Come on, Miller! You've got fifty yards! Dig! It's just pain, leave it on the road!"

The words were out of my mouth before I thought about them. A full sentence, at volume, in a yard, at a man who'd called me Fido.

Miller shot me a look of pure shock. Then he grimaced and found a last desperate sprint.

On the pull-up bar I watched Carter fail his seventh rep, arms shaking. "Don't let your knees drift, Carter! Lock your core! You've got three more in you, I know you do!"

He grunted, heaved, got an eighth.

It wasn't kindness. I checked. I checked immediately, standing right there, because if it was kindness then something in me had come unlatched without permission and I needed to know.

It wasn't. It was pragmatism, and brutal. We were cells in an organism. If the cell next to me is weak, the whole body is weaker. My own performance is irrelevant if the platoon fails. The DIs had beaten that into us for weeks.

For the first time I internalized it - not as a threat. As a mechanic of survival.

That's what I told myself in the yard and I was satisfied with it, and I would like to now point out the flaw, since nobody else was going to.

I wasn't part of the organism. I never had been. That was the whole design - red tape on a seat, ten feet off the formation, *you are not of this platoon*. If the platoon failed, the attachment did not fail with it. I had checked that months ago, the way I check everything.

So the pragmatic argument for shouting at Miller was worth exactly nothing. It was a false proof I built at speed to cover the fact that I wanted him to make it.

I didn't see that for years.

* * *

Slowly, tentatively, I became able to lead. Not by appointment. By default.

On ruck marches, when somebody's pack strap was digging in, I'd bark the adjustment drill Hale taught us. During the endless mind-numbing parade drills, when the rank lost its dressing, my height and voice from the flank called the alignment back. "Dress right, DRESS! Hold your interval, Garcia!"

And the most profound comfort in that entire forest was the silence from the DIs.

They never blamed me for being different. Not once, in a month. They only ever blamed the others for noticing.

"YOU STARING AT HER FEET TO LEARN THE CADENCE, JENKINS? EYES FRONT!"

That simple consistent reinforcement was a balm I hadn't known I needed. My existence was not the problem. Their lack of focus was.

Twelve years. That's how long I'd waited for someone in authority to look at a room and locate the problem somewhere other than my body. It took a defense contractor with a training schedule to do it, and they did it for the wrong reasons, and it worked anyway. I don't know what to do with that. I still don't.

We did ruck marches that felt like they'd never end, the Mk 13 an old familiar enemy on my shoulder. Hand-to-hand in the gritty pits, where my reach and speed became assets I learned to control instead of flail. Parade drills until the movements were autonomic, tail held in a tight still curl against my leg. A form of camping they called bivouacking, which was mostly lying in a cold damp hole trying not to shiver, listening to a forest with ears that catch every rustle and snap.

I was not becoming one of them. That was never the goal. The red-taped seat still existed.

But the space around me had stopped being a vacuum of hostility. It had become a space of function. I was a unique tool in the kit and the other tools were slowly, grudgingly, learning to work alongside me.

And I was starting to care whether they could do their jobs, which surprised me more than anything that happened in that forest.

The withering internal narration - *freak, monster, mistake* - was getting drowned out by the immediate demands of the task. *Move faster. Shoot straighter. Carry more. Help them.*

The thing in my blood, the one that drove me across a rooftop to a stranger, was being channeled. Given a direction. Given a pack, however dysfunctional.

I noticed the shape of that at the time and let it go by, and I'd like to pick it up now.

On the roof, that thing wanted a person, and I called it a malfunction and swallowed something to make it stop. Here it wanted fifty people, and they gave it a rifle and a rank and told me it was leadership.

It isn't that they cured me. Nobody cured anything, and nobody medicated me either - I'd taken exactly one tablet in my life and that was two months and two hundred miles ago. They found the appetite the lab installed and pointed it at a mission, and that was all it took. And it *worked*. That's the part I can't get around even now. I was less alone in that hole in the ground than I'd been since I was six, and every bit of it was issued to me.

A different kind of cage. But for the first time in my life the walls weren't only there to contain me.

They were there to shape me into something that could, perhaps, eventually break out.

I believed that. I want it in the record that I believed it, standing in a forest at twenty, holding a rifle that fit.

Blood Relation

Chapter 1 - The Hunting Lodge

The lodge smelled like cedar and old smoke. The agency picked it for me on purpose - a hunting lodge at the dead end of a logging road, the kind of place where a tall woman who comes and goes at strange hours and brings back strange cargo is just a hunter. Nothing more. A hunter living in a hunting lodge. Nobody looks twice. That is the entire point of it, and I have never decided whether I resent how well it works.

The walls are cedar gone honey-dark with age. Taxidermy everywhere - a whitetail buck over the cold fireplace, a brace of pheasants frozen mid-flush, a bobcat on a shelf with glass eyes that catch the light better than the real ones ever did. An antler chandelier hangs over the main room, a dozen sheds wired together into something meant to read as rustic luxury, which mostly reads as a lot of dead animals over your head while you eat. I didn't choose a single piece of it. The agency dressed the set before I moved in. I've only added to it, here and there, when a job left me something worth keeping.

My equipment fits the lie without trying. The charge rifle stands in the rack by the door, between a hunting bow and a lever-action that has never been fired. The lead-lined containment boxes stacked in the mudroom look like gun cases. The breaching tool hangs on a pegboard of axes and saws and looks like family. A stranger walking through would see a hunter's home and nothing underneath it.

The disguise is the house. The house is good. I live inside a costume that is also a building.

I got back near dawn. The job was done and bagged - routine, contained, nothing I'd lose sleep over. The thing I pulled out of it sat by the door in a vault box, sealed, quiet now that the lid was shut. I'd run it to headquarters in the morning and not think about it again.

I put a can in the fridge and took the cold one already in there. Four left on the shelf. I have never once been surprised by that number.

So I told myself.

It wasn't the box I kept circling back to.

It was the photograph on my nightstand.

I found it months ago, on another job - a house at the edge of a town that had thinned out around it, empty for decades, behind cracked glass in a hallway nobody had walked in twenty years. I took it off the wall without deciding to. That should have told me something. I do not do things without deciding to; the whole architecture of me is built to prevent exactly that. I took it anyway, and I

haven't been able to put it down since. It travels from coat pocket to table to the nightstand by my bed, where I set it most nights before I sleep, the way some people set down a watch. I've told myself a dozen times to log it and let it go.

I picked it up and stood over it in my coat, contacts already in, looking at it the way I look at everything I don't understand yet - which is to say, too long, and from too many angles, as though the answer is a matter of finding the correct approach.

The colors have gone bad with the years. Reds drained, blues turned green, the whole thing sitting behind its cracked glass like it gave up trying to be a photograph. The face didn't go with the colors. A young woman, hair parted in the middle, smiling at someone off-frame. The eyes aren't red. The ears are ordinary.

But the bones underneath are a face I have been looking at in my own mirror my whole life without knowing whose it was.

I don't have a name for the feeling. I have names for very few of them; it's a gap in the instrument I've never bothered to close, because for most of my life nothing has come up that required the distinction. This did. And somewhere in the night I'd decided: today I take it to Vanity, and stop pretending I don't need to know.

Headlights swept the front windows. Gravel under tires. Korval, on time, the way he is always on time.

I slid the photograph into the inside pocket of my coat, against my chest, and picked up the box.

Outside, the cold met my face and my ears flattened back under the hat by themselves. I let them. Korval's SUV idled in the turnaround, exhaust ghosting white in the dark.

"Morning," he said as I set the box on the back seat.

"Headquarters." I got in. "I have something to report. And something that isn't a report."

He didn't ask. He never asks until I want him to, and I have never worked out whether that's discipline or disinterest, and I have never asked either, which probably answers it.

He pulled out onto the logging road. The lodge shrank in the side mirror - cedar and dark glass, the antler chandelier a faint warm smudge through the front window where I'd left one lamp burning.

Then the trees took it, and there was only the road, and the box, and the photograph against my chest like a second heartbeat I hadn't asked for.

Chapter 2 - The Address

The containment lounge sits between the vault corridor and the rest of the building. Long tables. Padded chairs. Coffee that's always on. Low-light displays along one wall showing the current inventory of the vaults, color-coded by threat tier. A ficus in the corner that has been alive longer than I've been with the agency, which I find obscurely reassuring and have never examined too closely.

I came in through the rear door with the box.

The desk officer took it without comment. Weighed it. Scanned it. Logged it. The box went through the slot in the wall and was gone. I would not think about it again.

So I told myself.

Vanity was in the lounge.

She stood near the long table, hands clasped behind her back, looking at one of the wall displays. She didn't turn when I came in. She didn't need to. The corner of her mouth had moved before I was fully through the door - she'd had me on some sensor since the parking level, and the mouth was a courtesy, staged for my benefit at the correct moment. She does that. I've never decided whether it's kindness or theater. Probably it doesn't have to be one.

"Operator."

"Vanity."

She's the only one in the building who can make a rank sound like a greeting instead of an order. She's also the only one I answer with a first name instead of a surname. Neither arrangement was ever negotiated out loud, which is how I know it's real. The things I've agreed to in words have mostly been things done to me.

"Sit. You smell like cedar and animal furs."

"I smell like home."

"You smell like a hunting lodge that hasn't been aired out in twenty years."

I sat. She moved to the chair opposite, deliberately a half-beat slow - the android courtesy of pretending to be a person who needs a moment. A small folder sat on the table between us. She slid it across.

"That's the woman in your photograph."

I hadn't given her a name to work with. I didn't have one. I'd handed her a cracked frame off a wall in a dead house and she'd given me back a person, and I knew how - she'd have run the face, the same as she'd run a plate - but knowing the method doesn't do much for you when the output is a stranger who has your bones.

I opened it.

A color photograph paper-clipped to the corner: an older woman in a sun hat, in a garden, smiling at someone off-camera.

It was the face from the photograph in my coat, forty years later.

It was my own face, forty years older.

I handled it well, which I mention because nobody was there to see. I sat there and did arithmetic on a stranger's cheekbones, and the arithmetic kept coming out the same, and I made no sound at all.

"Dr. Rosalyn Renaya," Vanity said.

She let the surname sit there. Didn't lean on it. Didn't pause for me to catch up, which she could have, and which I'd have hated.

Renaya is mine off my father, and my father is a man I have never met and never wondered about out loud, because a name on foster paperwork isn't a person, it's a field. I've carried his name the way you carry a coat somebody left in your car. It had never occurred to me it came from anywhere - that there was a woman it came *through*, who was alive, and had a garden.

"Sixty-eight. Lives alone, two hours from here. Kindergarten teacher 1985 through 1995, a few towns from where you were born. Went back to medical school in her late thirties. Pediatrician now. Doesn't lead with the title. Widowed. No other children of record. Her son and daughter-in-law - your biological parents, per the foster paperwork on you - left the area when you were small. Their records thin out after that and don't come back. Her record on you ends at the foster system."

"The house you took it out of," I said. "The one on the job."

"Four miles from the school she taught at." She said it the way she says everything, which is without any weight on it at all. "The town had people in it once. Whoever lived in that hallway knew her well enough to hang her on a wall. A cousin. A colleague. A friend from church. I can find out. It'll take a week and it will not be interesting."

Somebody in that hallway had known a young schoolteacher well enough to put her behind glass. Then they'd died, or left, and the glass went on hanging in the dark for twenty years.

"It's not a coincidence," Vanity said, reading me the way she does. "It's a small county. You were born in it. Everything in that county is four miles from everything else. The coincidence is that you were the one who took it off the wall, and I can't run a file on that."

I read the address. It's a normal address. That's what I couldn't get past - that it had been a normal address this whole time, printable, two hours away, sitting in a file that took Vanity an afternoon.

"She's alive."

"She's alive."

"And she's been alone."

"For a while."

I closed the folder. Put both hands flat on it.

"I want to go see her."

"I assumed."

"How."

"You take it as leave. Real leave, not a job with a family on the end of it. Korval drives you. I clear the paperwork. The agency calls her ahead of time so a stranger doesn't pull up to her door and shorten her life by ten years."

"Have you called her."

"Not yet. I wanted to ask you first."

I looked at her. She could have called. She had the number before she had the folder, and she'd sat on it, because there is a difference between having a thing done to you and choosing it, and she is the only person alive who has never needed that explained.

"Call her."

"Today?"

"Today."

She inclined her head - a small mechanical motion that meant *acknowledged*, and also meant *I'm proud of you*, and also meant *don't make me say it*. She could produce a warmer gesture. She has the hardware. She uses the small one because she knows I can read it and knows I'd leave the room if she used the other.

"Take the week. More if you need it. The queue will hold."

"And you'll log it as what."

"Personal. You're not on a clock and you're not reporting in. Call me when you feel like it - once a day, so I know you're alive. That's all I want." A half-beat. "Just your voice down the line. That'll do."

"I can do that."

I stood. The folder went into my bag with the photograph from the house. Two pieces of Rosalyn - one from 1985, one from an agency record - and soon a third one that breathed.

"Operator."

"Yeah."

"Wear the dress. Wear the hat. Wear the contacts. Until you don't have to."

"I know."

"And then take them off."

"I know."

Chapter 3 - The Visit

I was nervous, which took me most of an hour to identify.

That sounds absurd. I have been shot at. I know what fear does in my body down to the second - the drop, the narrowing, the way sound goes flat and useful. This wasn't that. This was diffuse and pointless and had no object I could name, and I sat in it a long time before I got a word onto it, because there was nothing to fight and nothing to leave and so the instrument had nothing to point at.

I looked out the window while Korval drove. He follows me everywhere. Not that I need it. I am usually the dangerous one in any room, and both of us know it, and neither of us has ever said so.

The agency had turned up word of a biological family member and given me the opportunity to visit. I'd taken it. My grandmother. Rosalyn Renaya.

"How much further until we get there?" The words came out before I'd decided to say them, which was the second bad sign in an hour.

"About thirty minutes," Korval said, the accent thick as ever. Then: "Why are you so impatient? You're always calm."

I had no reply. I'd never wanted to be close to family before - there'd been nobody to want it at, so the wanting had never had anywhere to go. Now there was somewhere, and it turned out the wanting had been sitting there the whole time, fully assembled, waiting for an address.

I stared out the window as the metropolis turned into rural neighborhoods.

"Okay, we're just about there," Korval said. "Make sure you dress appropriately."

I had nearly forgotten that my grandmother didn't know about my altered form.

I climbed into the back seat and changed my jeans for a dress. Put a hat on. Put the contacts in.

I felt like a completely different person. I could not tell which version was the real one. I have never been able to, and I have stopped expecting the question to resolve itself on a drive.

* * *

It was a warm day. The sun was out. In the window glass I looked like somebody's daughter on her way to lunch, and that was the point of the exercise, and I did not enjoy how well it worked.

* * *

The house was covered in ivy and looked a little overgrown, in the way of a place tended by someone who has decided which battles are worth it. A small stone path led to the front door. When we parked, an old lady walked out.

"I'm Osyra, and you're Rosalyn, right? My grandmother?"

"Ah yes, I got a phone call saying that you would be around soon."

"That must have been my boss."

"Lieutenant something. I can't remember his name."

"He worries too much."

"Well, that means he cares about you, honey. We can talk about it inside. Does your driver want to come in too?"

I gave Korval a subconscious side eye. "No. He prefers the quiet."

Korval said nothing. He just nodded slightly, then walked to the front of the car and sat on the hood. His sunglasses reflecting.

"He'll head to a hotel when it gets dark. Back in the morning," I said.

"All right then, sweetheart." Rosalyn turned around and walked inside.

I looked back at Korval for a second, nodded, and followed my grandmother in.

Once inside I took a seat close to the door.

I told myself it was manners - that I didn't want to wander into a stranger's home uninvited. That held up for about four seconds. It was the door. It's always the door. I do not sit down in a room without knowing the count of exits, and I was doing it here, in an ivy-covered house belonging to a sixty-eight-year-old pediatrician, against the possibility that I would need to leave her living room at speed. I considered getting up and moving to the couch, just to prove I could.

I didn't. I stayed where I was and let myself have the door, and told myself I'd move later, which is what I always tell myself.

The seat was almost too comfortable. Age had let it relax into the exact shape of a body. The light wasn't blinding and wasn't dull. The wood trim, the furniture - all of it a snapshot back in time. The place smelled like newspaper and sunshine.

It felt like a memory, which was not possible. I have never been in that house. But something in the back of my head kept insisting it recognized the room, and I couldn't make it stop, and after a while I stopped trying and just sat in the chair that knew what a person was shaped like.

The plan was simple: stay the night, see what the morning looked like. There was no job at the end of this one. Korval would be back after breakfast, and after that the days were mine - the first time in years that sentence had been true.

"What do you do for work, dear?"

"Can't say much. It's military."

"Oh, I understand. I don't want to get you in any trouble," Rosalyn said softly.

"Combat unit. Mostly eliminating dangerous animals."

"What a world we live in. They come up with new jobs every day, don't they?" She smiled. "As long as they're paying you well and treating you right."

"They are," I said.

"How about some pictures? So I can remember you once this day's over." She'd been wandering the whole time we talked. She reached onto a counter and came up with a Polaroid.

My face went red.

I don't take pictures. There's an operational reason and I reached for it first, because it's clean and it's true and it isn't the reason. Then I got to the actual problem, which was this: she wanted a picture of her granddaughter, and the thing sitting in her chair was a woman in a hat with brown contacts over red eyes. If I said yes she'd get a photograph of somebody who doesn't exist. She'd put it on the shelf with her mother in the high collar. Forty years from now somebody would find it and never know they were looking at a costume.

I could take the hat off. The thought arrived fully formed and I looked at it the way you look at a live wire on wet ground. Right there, in the good chair, in the light, two hours from the lodge and thirty seconds from finding out whether the whole day had been a mistake. She'd have flinched or she wouldn't. That's all it would have cost. One second of information.

I have made harder decisions in worse rooms with people shooting at me.

"Later," I said.

"Of course, honey. You must be tired."

She drifted toward the kitchen, murmuring about the kettle. I stayed in the chair and let her go, and sat with the fact that I'd just declined to find out something I'd driven two hours to learn. I told myself it was pacing. Give her the afternoon first. Ease into it. That's a strategy, and it is also what a coward says, and both were true at once and I couldn't get a blade between them.

I'd call Vanity tonight, the way I'd been told. Once a day, so somebody at headquarters knew I was still breathing. Just my voice down the line, and Vanity on the other end taking down whatever I felt like saying, patient, keeping it for the record.

She brought in tea eventually. I had trouble paying attention. The chair was pulling me under, my body slowing the way it never slows, and I kept waiting for the tea to fix it and it didn't. I'd been running so long I hadn't noticed I was tired. I mean that plainly. I had no idea. The instrument doesn't point inward, and it had been reading *fine* for years while the answer was *no*.

I took the cup almost greedily. Anything to stay awake for this.

Chamomile.

I got about half of it down before the joke landed on me. She hadn't brought me anything to stay awake on. There was nothing in that cup but hot water and a flower, and I'd been drinking it like a stimulant and waiting to be fixed by it.

Which was fine. There were two cans in the truck and I knew exactly where, and I'd have got up for one at any point in the last hour and hadn't, because getting up meant leaving the room. I sat there and went without and said nothing about it.

She hadn't asked. I want to be careful here, because I have watched people be kind at me for twenty-nine years and I know what it looks like when someone has done their homework and wants credit for it. That wasn't this. There was no glance to see if I'd noticed. She'd looked at a woman who'd driven two hours and hadn't slept and was sitting in her front room with her hands wrong, and she'd gone and boiled the thing you give somebody who needs to come down.

Forty years of small frightened people, and it comes out of her hands automatically, and she doesn't know she's doing it.

She watched me drink for a moment. Then she set her own cup down on the side table and went to the bookshelf at the far end of the room. Her fingers ran along the spines until they stopped on something thick and softbound. She pulled it out with both hands.

"I dug this out before you came," she said. "Thought you might want to see."

She brought it back over and lowered herself into the chair across from me. The album opened with a soft creak of old leather. Pages thick as cardboard. The kind with little black corners stuck on to hold each photo in place. She turned to the first page and angled it toward me.

"This is your great-grandmother. My mother. She was a tough old thing."

I leaned forward enough to see. A black-and-white photograph of a woman in a high-collared dress, hair pulled back so tight it looked painful. She wasn't smiling. None of them did, in those days.

"She looks strict," I said.

"Oh, she was. But she'd give you the last bite off her plate if she thought you needed it more." She smiled and turned the page. A few more faces. Names I didn't catch. People who had lived and died long before I ever drew a breath.

I let her go. It was easier than answering. The chair was pulling at me and her voice had a rhythm, like wind through a screen door.

She turned another page, and the rhythm changed.

"And this," she said, more carefully now, "is your mother."

I looked.

A young woman, sitting on the steps of a porch. Thin. Tired in a way that didn't belong on a face that young. She was holding something in her lap - a bundle. A baby. She wasn't looking at the camera. She was looking down at the bundle.

I knew the porch.

That's what got me. Not the woman. The porch - the paint coming off the third step in a shape like a bird. I have put my hand on that step. I couldn't tell you when or why, but the knowing came up out of my body without asking permission, the way a smell does, and it was certain, and it was worth nothing.

I looked at the face and got nothing back. Six years of a person and all I kept was a step.

I've been told this is normal, at various points, by various people paid to tell me things. That nobody keeps much from before seven. That the mind is still deciding what it is. It has not once helped to be told, and it doesn't now, and I have never understood why people offer the explanation as though it were the same thing as the memory.

"How old was she?" I asked.

"Just barely an adult." Rosalyn touched the edge of the photograph with one finger. "She and your father - they didn't have anything, sweetheart. Not really. Not enough for a child. They tried, for a while. But there's a kind of poor that doesn't bend, and they were in it."

I nodded. There wasn't anything to say to that.

I took another sip of the tea.

She didn't turn the page. She sat with her hand flat on it, the way you hold a door you haven't decided to open.

"They wouldn't let me near you," she said. "That's the bit I've never gotten all the way around. I knew you were born. I knew where. She'd answer the phone maybe one time in five, and she was always about to call me back." Her thumb moved once against the paper. "I think she couldn't stand for me to see it. The state of things. She'd have rather starved than had her mother-in-law standing in that kitchen counting what wasn't in it. And I let her have that. Six years, I let her have her pride, because I kept telling myself I'd get one more chance to ask."

She said it evenly, which was worse than if she hadn't.

"Then a school nurse filled out a form," Rosalyn said. "Some woman who'd never met any of us, doing her job, writing down what she saw. And that was enough to take you. But not one person in that whole process thought to ask whether the child had anybody." She looked at her hands. "They had the name. It's the same name. It was in the phone book."

I looked at the woman on the porch steps instead of at her. It seemed easier for both of us.

"You couldn't have known they'd take me," I said.

"No," Rosalyn agreed. "But I could have driven down. Any Tuesday of those six years, I could have driven down and knocked, and I didn't, because she'd have been embarrassed." She let out a breath and it shook coming out, and she got it back under control the way a person does when they've had years of practice. "That's the whole of it, sweetheart. I was being polite. I'm sorry. You didn't come here to hold this for me."

Then, quieter, not really to me at all: "There's no picture of you after that one. I've looked. Not one anywhere in this house, because nobody was taking any."

The album stayed open on the porch steps a moment longer than it needed to. Then she turned the page.

The next photo stopped me for a different reason.

A man - middle-aged, broad-shouldered - standing in a clearing somewhere wooded. A rifle propped against his shoulder. A deer at his feet, freshly taken. He was smiling, but it was a tight kind of smile, like he wasn't comfortable with the camera.

"My husband," she said. "He's been gone a long time now. He'd have liked you, I think. He used to do something a bit like what you do - tracked nuisance animals, mostly. Bears that got into the trash. The occasional cat that started taking livestock."

Something went tight in my chest. Of course he did.

"He'd ask you a thousand questions about it," she went on. "What kind of rifle, what range you work at, how often you have to take a shot at running game. He always wanted to know more than he let on."

"It's mostly close work," I said. Carefully. "Tracking. Containment. The shooting part isn't the hard part."

"That's what he used to say." She laughed once. "Said anyone could pull a trigger. Hard part was being sure you should."

I made myself smile. Not enough to show teeth. "Yeah."

She watched me for a half-second longer than felt natural. Then she turned the page.

A few more photos. A house she used to live in. A garden that was no longer there. Then she closed the album in her lap and rested both hands flat on the cover.

"I've been hoping someone would call for years," she said. She said it like she was admitting to a small thing, not a heavy one. "I knew about you, you know. Always knew there was a granddaughter out there somewhere. Just couldn't ever find the thread to pull."

I didn't know what to do with that. I sat with the cup in my lap and stared at it.

"This place gets quiet," she said. "Quieter than I thought it would. The phone doesn't ring much. My hands aren't what they were. Some mornings I open jars with the back of a butter knife." She laughed, soft. "Don't tell anyone."

"I won't."

She looked at me a moment longer, then patted the album once, gently, like saying goodnight to it.

"You look tired, honey."

I was tired.

"Why don't you take the back room. The one at the end of the hall. The bed's made up. I'd been hoping you might."

I nodded. I didn't trust my voice.

I set the cup down, stood up, and let her show me the way.

Chapter 4 - The Reveal

The back room was small. Wood paneling, a single bed made up with a hand-stitched quilt, a low dresser, a window looking out into the dark of the yard. A second door on the right opened onto a bathroom - I could see a strip of tile through the gap.

"Towels are under the sink," she said. "Hot water takes a minute. Give it a minute."

"Thank you."

"There's a nightshirt in the top drawer if it fits. Was mine, a long time ago. You're a fair bit taller than I ever was, but it might do." She paused at the doorway. "I'll be in the kitchen. Tea if you want it. Otherwise - sleep well, sweetheart."

She closed the door behind her.

I stood in the middle of the room and listened. Her footsteps moved off down the hall. A cabinet opened. A faucet ran. Then the slow shuffling sound of a woman who's walked the same floorboards long enough to do it without looking.

I let out a breath I hadn't known I was holding.

* * *

I undressed in pieces.

The hat first. I set it on the dresser the way you set down something fragile. My ears came up and gave a slow twitch - they'd been flat for hours and the muscle at the base of them was aching. I rubbed at it with both hands. A small, embarrassing relief.

Then the dress. The hem caught on my tail where it always catches. I shook it loose and folded it on the chair, and my tail uncurled from against my leg where I'd kept it tucked all day, and the circulation came back in that familiar prickle.

I sat on the edge of the bed and worked the contacts out, one at a time, blinking them into the case. The world went crisper. Reds went redder.

I looked in the dresser mirror. Really looked, for the first time all day.

Long ears. Long tail. Red eyes catching the lamplight in a way no human eye does.

I looked like myself.

There's a version of this where I say I hated how much I'd missed it, and that would be tidy, and it isn't accurate. What I hated was the arithmetic. Twelve hours in the costume and I come out of it feeling like a person - which means the thirteen years I've spent calling the costume *practical* were thirteen years of paying a bill I told myself I wasn't paying. I'd rather have not known the number.

* * *

The shower helped.

I stood under it longer than I needed to. Hot water on the back of my neck, down the muscles along my spine, on the place between my shoulder blades that always carries something I can't name. The fur on my ears and tail flattened out and went darker. I washed my hair twice. No reason. It felt good.

When I stepped out I wrapped one of her towels around me. Too small for my frame, but it covered what mattered. I rubbed my hair down with a second one.

And then I did the thing I only do when nobody can see me.

I shook. Head, ears, the whole frame of me - one hard sharp shake, the way a dog does coming out of a lake. Water went everywhere. The mirror got it. The wall got it. A spray hit the ceiling and came back down in slow fat drops.

I didn't have to do that. That's the part. I could have stood perfectly still; there is not one twitch in my body I can't override, and I have spent my life proving it in rooms where the proving mattered. The shake isn't a thing I can't help. It's a thing I pick. Every time. Because it feels good every time, and in thirteen years of running the numbers on what I let myself have, this is what survived the cut - eleven seconds of being an animal on a bathroom floor with the door shut.

I shook again. Smaller. Just to feel the ears whip.

The floor was a wet mess. I did not care.

The nightshirt was in the top drawer like she'd said. Soft cotton, faded blue, embroidered along the collar in a pattern I didn't recognize. On her it had probably come past the knees. On me it landed a few inches above. The sleeves were short. I pulled it on and worked the fabric over my tail and let it hang free behind me.

It would do. I wasn't planning on standing up.

* * *

I opened the bathroom door and stepped out into the bedroom.

She was standing in the doorway to the hall with a folded blanket in her hands.

For a long second neither of us moved.

I'd left the bedroom door unlocked. That was mine. I'd assumed she would knock, and I want to be clear that assuming is not a thing I do - I had gotten comfortable, in a house, in one afternoon, at the age of twenty-nine, and this is what it cost.

Her eyes went to my ears first. Then the tail. Then back up to my face, to the eyes I hadn't put the contacts back in for.

The blanket was still folded in her hands.

I stood there in the borrowed nightshirt and tried to make myself smaller. Tail still. Ears down. Hands at my sides. Tried to take up less of the room than I do.

It didn't work. There's no version of standing in a doorway under a lamp that isn't intimidating when you're built like this. The ears. The tail. The eyes. The edge of a canine wherever my mouth isn't all the way shut. Holding still only gave her longer to land on each piece in turn, which I know, and I did it anyway, because the alternative was moving and moving is worse.

I watched her see it. Her hand tightened on the blanket. Her chin came up an inch. That stillness a person goes into when their eyes are still catching up to what's in front of them.

Here it was. This part I know.

Not from her - from receptionists, landlords, a doctor or two. The face going polite like a curtain coming down. The excuse to step into another room. The phone call to my driver ten minutes later: *something's come up, I'm so sorry*. The goodbye that means *please don't come back*, dressed up nice. I know every beat of it. I've gotten good at making the leaving easy on the person doing it, which is a skill I acquired on purpose and have not been thanked for.

I just hadn't expected to need the practice on my grandmother.

Then her shoulders came down. The flicker passed. She let out a breath, and when she looked at me again she wasn't looking at a predator. She wasn't even looking at a stranger.

She was looking at me the way you look at a kid who's come in from the yard with something scraped up that wants seeing to before bed.

"Oh, sweetheart," she said. Very softly. "Come into the light. Let me look at you properly."

I didn't move.

The catalogue had an answer ready, and the answer was that this was a different kind of goodbye - the careful one, where she looks me over thoroughly so that later she can tell herself she tried. I've been told to leave kindly before. The kindness doesn't stop the leaving; it just makes it take longer and hurt in a different place. So I watched her hands. That's where it shows first. The hands find something to do that happens to be in another room.

Her hands didn't do that. She was moving toward me.

And the whole frame I had built for what was happening slid sideways and stopped fitting. I'd been furious - viciously, in the half-second after the door opened, at her for not knocking and at myself for the lock and at the entire arrangement of my life. Most of that drained out. Not all. I didn't trust the rest of it yet. I've had this feeling before. It usually breaks.

She didn't come in the way you'd come into a barn with a wary horse in it. She just came in. Set the blanket on the bed and held a hand out to me, palm up, the way you'd ask a child to come closer so you could check something.

I went over. My body did it before my head caught up, and I'd like to know what that says, because I've never done that in my life.

"Before I do this," she said. Quiet. "You should know what you're letting close to you. I'm a doctor, well, a Pediatrician now. General practice before that. I want to look at the modifications. May I?"

Something in my chest went loose a half-turn.

The look on her face had a name now. That was all it was. I'd read clinical worry as revulsion because I have never once in thirteen years had cause to build a category for a person who looks at me that way and wants to *help*. Not a stranger reaching. Not morbid curiosity. A doctor finding where it hurts.

I nodded.

She brought her other hand up - slow, asking with her face. I tilted my head down so she could reach. She touched the outside of one ear. Gentle. The touch you'd use checking the edges of a scab.

"Does this hurt?"

"No."

I was still half-waiting. The hand on my ear, that close, is where the recoil comes. The little involuntary pull-back. The face you make when you've touched a thing and only then registered what it was.

It didn't come.

"Pressure here?" Her thumb pressed lightly at the base of the ear. "Or here?"

"No. The base used to ache after a long day in the hat. Doesn't anymore."

"Mm." She palpated the cartilage along the rim. Slow. Cataloguing. "Has it ever - when it was happening. Did you get sick? Fevers? Skin trouble where the fur came in?"

"For about a year. Itched mostly. Not after that."

"Mm-hm." Something soft under the clinical. She turned my head a fraction to see the other ear, thumb tracing just behind the base where the fur meets skin. Worried in the small specific way you're worried about a thing you might still be able to fix. "Can you move them?"

I flicked one forward. Then the other. Then both.

"Oh, that's clever."

I nearly lost it there.

Clever. That's the wrong word. That's the word you use when a kid shows you a small thing they're proud of. Nobody has ever applied it to my body. My body is a security problem, an operational advantage, a thing people have written *specimen* next to on a chart. It is not clever. There was no slot for it and I stood there with the word sitting on top of my head like a bird that had landed on me, waiting for her next sentence to take it back.

"And the tail?" she said.

I moved it once, slow, side to side. Then stopped it dead.

"All right." She let go of my ear and stepped back to take stock of the whole of me, the way you take stock of a kid's full report once they've finished crying.

And then her face did a thing.

Not the recoil. Something else, and I had no read on it, because I have never gotten this far with anyone. Her mouth went thin. Her eyes went bright in a way that wasn't softness.

I went very still.

"And you walked into my house," she said, "in a hat. And a dress. And those contacts that hurt your eyes."

"Yeah."

"All afternoon."

"Yeah."

"Sitting in my chair and drinking my tea and not smiling at me because you didn't want me to see your teeth."

"Yes."

There it is. Different shape, same animal. Not disgust. Disappointment. I'd taken her hospitality under false pretenses and let her haul out a photo album for somebody who wasn't in the room. That's a fair thing to be angry about. I'd have been angry about it. I started getting my body ready to hand back the half-step she'd let me have, without making it her problem, because that is the one courtesy I can still offer at the end of these.

Then she spoke again, and I understood that I had the vector wrong.

The bright thing in her eyes wasn't pointed at me. It was pointed past my shoulder. At the world I'd had to cross to get to her front door. At the version of me she'd had to meet first.

"Sweetheart." The edge was still on it. "You don't ever do that in this house. Do you understand me? Not in this house. I don't care what you look like under there. I'd have wanted to know you straight off."

I didn't answer right away. I was checking the sentence for a hook. I went over it twice. That's not a figure of speech either - I have been handed sentences like that before and they always have something in them, some small clause that comes due later, and I have learned to find it before I accept delivery.

There wasn't one.

"All right," I said. Small.

"Sit down, honey. Tell me what happened to you. Slow if you need to."

I sat.

The bed creaked. My tail came around across my lap and I put a hand on it without thinking, which is a tell, and I know it's a tell, and I did it anyway.

"It was a lab," I said. "When I was sixteen."

She nodded once. Waited.

I waited too. I wanted to give her more. My body wouldn't do it. Every version of this conversation I've ever rehearsed ends with a door closing politely behind me, and the rehearsals are load-bearing; I could not get out from under them just because the room was different. I have told the long version to nobody who didn't already have the file open in front of them.

"That's all I can do tonight," I said. Small.

"Then that's all you need to do tonight."

She meant it. I waited for the look that says otherwise - the kindness with a clock on it. It didn't come. Her hand stayed loose in her lap. Her eyes stayed where they were.

"I'd have loved you exactly like this," Rosalyn said. "At sixteen. At six. Whatever came off that table. I want that on the record, since nobody ever gave me the chance to say it out loud."

I had to look at the floor for a minute.

Chapter 5 - The Letting Go

She didn't leave right away.

She sat down in the little chair by the dresser instead, and it took me a minute to work out that it was a decision. If she'd stood up and gone, I'd have started crying. She knew that before I did. I read rooms for a living and I had missed it in my own.

She asked me about the small things.

Did the ears hurt under the hat. Did my tail get cold in winter. Could I eat normal food.

I answered most of them. The contacts were the worst - twelve hours and they felt like sand.

"Then take them out, honey. In this house. Always. And the hat."

I nodded.

Her mouth went a little quirky on one side. "Now. I'll only say this once. The state of that bathroom floor isn't from the shower, is it."

My face went hot all at once.

"No."

"Mm-hm."

"I was drying off."

"You were drying off?"

"In a particular way."

"Sweetheart, I lived with a man who used to come home from the woods wearing half the mud. Just maybe put a towel down next time."

I made a noise into the back of my hand - half a laugh, half a wince. The first uncalculated sound out of me all day.

"There it is," she said, pleased with herself.

The laugh had done something. It took me a while to work out what.

She had made a joke about my body - the water, the mess, the animal fact of me - and the joke wasn't about whether I should exist. Every one I'd been on the end of since I was sixteen had that in it somewhere, underneath, holding the thing up. Hers didn't, and the whole structure stayed standing anyway.

The catalogue went quiet. I hadn't known it could.

I didn't know how long the window would stay open. Windows don't, in my experience. So I was already deciding to use it - which is not the same as trusting her. I was spending something before it expired.

"It was a virus," I said. Quiet.

She settled back into the chair instead of standing.

"They had a whole shelf of versions of it. Numbered. The one they gave me was Chimera 9. They are all different methods of splicing DNA. The other kids got other numbers."

I rubbed at my eye with the back of my wrist.

"Mine took. Most of them didn't. The ones that did sometimes came out worse than I did. Things that stopped looking like people on the way through. I don't know what was done with those ones after."

She didn't say anything.

"After the place came down, the agency found me. Put me to work. The dangerous-animals part is half the truth. The other half is - rich people lose things they'd rather nobody else find. A phone in a forest. A ring that went over the side of a boat. Strange jobs, weird hours, more money than the work is worth. The kind of money people pay you to forget about the job once it's done. The rest of it I can't really talk about."

She was quiet a long moment. She was looking at me the same way she'd looked at me when I came out of the bathroom - like somebody who'd come in from the yard with something scraped up. Except this time the scrapes were under the skin. She could see them. She wasn't going to mention it.

"The biggest hurdle is I can't go outside without a disguise," I said. "People see me and they get scared. Or they get violent. Or they get scared and call somebody who'll get violent. The hat and the dress and the contacts - that's how I buy groceries. That's how I get on a bus. That's how I knock on a front door without somebody phoning it in."

"Mm." She didn't disagree.

She moved closer and tilted my chin up under the lamp. "Let me look at the eyes properly."

I looked. Red into a face that did not flinch.

"Mm-hm. Pupils respond fine. Whole-iris color, not just a ring around the edge - that's a clean conversion. Any blurriness through the day? Halos around lights?"

"No."

"And the dryness when the contacts come out. Five seconds of saline rinse, next time. Cuts the recovery."

"Mm."

"Night vision better than mine?"

"Yes." I nodded.

"I'd hope so." A small quick smile. She let go of my chin and stepped back half a step.

"The teeth are more of a challenge. The rest you can hide if you're careful. Can't hide when I bite food."

"May I see, sweetheart? You don't have to."

I opened my mouth a little. Canines longer than they had any business being, sharp where they ought to have been rounded.

She looked. She tilted my chin up gently to catch the lamplight. Looked at the gum line. The cusps. The way the canines sat in the socket. "Do they cut your lip when you talk?"

"No, not really. My mouth seems to have adjusted to the shape of the bite."

"And the rest - open wider for me."

I opened. She looked along the back of the bite.

"All right. The bite's even. That's good news. You'd have known by now if it wasn't - jaw, headaches, the whole catalogue. The fact that you don't says the rest of your jaw came along with them."

She didn't look away.

After a long moment she nodded, like she was filing the picture somewhere safe. Then she stood. Picked the blanket up from the foot of the bed and laid it neater across. Paused at the door.

"Osyra."

"Yeah."

"I'm glad you came. Even as you are."

She closed the door softly behind her.

I lay down. My tail curled around against the small of my back, finding the sleeping curl on its own. My ears flattened against the pillow.

I had not, in fact, fallen apart.

Nothing in me was bracing. I went looking for it the way your tongue goes to a tooth that's gone, and it wasn't there, and I was still here.

I'd always assumed the bracing was load-bearing. That it was the thing holding the rest up. It had come off and nothing had fallen down, and I lay in the dark with that, not liking it as much as I should have. It's a specific feeling, finding an error in your own work. If I was wrong about that, I'd been wrong about it every day, in every room, since I was six years old.

The house creaked. Settled. Somewhere down the hall, a kettle clicked off.

I reached over to the dresser, found the comms pin where I'd set it next to the hat, and clipped it to the base of my ear. Keyed it once.

"Chimera One to Wiki. Checking in."

A pause that wasn't really a pause. "Wiki receiving. You're a day early on sounding human."

"Don't get used to it."

"I won't. Still in one piece?"

"Still in one piece. Staying the night. Maybe longer."

"Noted." A small sound on the line - Vanity, logging it, the way she logged everything. A line in a record only she kept. "Sleep, Operator. Call me tomorrow."

"Roger."

I unclipped the pin and set it back by the hat.

I closed my eyes.

Chapter 6 - The Morning

I woke before the sun.

The house had that early quiet - the kind where you can hear the floor settling and the refrigerator cycling on and off down the hall and nothing else. My ears caught the click of pipes somewhere on the far side of a wall. I lay there a minute. Tail flat against the small of my back. Ears flat on the pillow.

I'd slept hard. I can't tell you the last time I slept hard.

I got up the way I move on jobs. Quiet. That one isn't a choice anymore and I've stopped pretending it is.

* * *

The hall floor was cold. The kitchen was darker than the bedroom - heavy curtains, a north-facing window. I felt my way to the lamp on the counter and clicked it on low.

The Polaroid was where she'd left it the day before, on the counter next to a ceramic jar of pens.

I looked at it for a while.

She'd offered. I'd put her off. I'd told myself she meant a picture of the version of me she'd been allowed to meet - the hat, the dress, the careful unsmiling mouth - and I hadn't wanted to hand her that.

That wasn't the version she meant. I know that now. I knew it the second she said *come into the light*, and I'd spent the whole night not looking directly at the fact that I'd been wrong about her before I'd even met her. I'd had her sorted into a category before the car stopped. Same as everyone. It's efficient and it's fast and it has never once been wrong in a way that cost me anything.

It was wrong here. That's the first time. I don't know what to do with a first time.

I picked the camera up. Tested the weight. Checked the cartridge - half a pack of film left. Pulled a chair out from the table and sat under the lamp.

* * *

The first one was for the record.

I sat straight. Held the camera at arm's length, angled down, framed for head and shoulders. Ears up. Eyes open. The kind of picture you take when you're documenting something. Shutter. The camera whirred and spat the film into my hand.

I set it face-down to develop.

The second was a profile. Turned my head left, held the camera further out. The long shape of one ear from the side, the line of my jaw, the edge of a canine where my mouth wasn't quite closed.

The third - I bit down lightly on the side of one finger and lifted my lip on the other side. Showed the tooth clean. Like a horse trader. The kind of picture you'd send a doctor who asked.

Three records. Three small pieces of evidence: *this is what I am. This is what she accepted.*

I set them face-down and let the camera rest in my lap.

Then, without really planning to, I lifted it again.

* * *

The fourth one I almost laughed at while I was taking it.

Two fingers up beside my face. A peace sign. The thing kids do into phones now. Camera up high, overhead, the way teenagers hold them at bus stops, head tilted a little. Ears asymmetric. One up, one back.

Shutter. Whir.

The fifth, I blew a kiss at the lens. Pursed mouth. Eyes half-closed. I felt absurd. I kept going.

The sixth was every tooth at once. Full canine display. The smile I have never given anyone in my life. It came out looking less like a snarl and more like an animal that had just been told a very good joke.

I looked at that one a long time after it developed.

* * *

I spread them across the table. Six. Three for the record, three for no reason except that I'd wanted to.

I've been trying since to work out what the last three were, because they weren't documentation and they weren't for her - she wasn't awake and I hadn't decided to show her. I took them in an empty kitchen for nobody. There's a word for taking pictures of yourself pulling faces at four in the

morning because it's funny and you're the only one home, and the word is not one that has ever applied to me.

The peace-sign one was the best. I knew it immediately. Ears uneven. Eyes a little bright. A half-smile with nothing serious behind it.

It looked like a person. Not an exhibit.

I got up and stuck it to the fridge under a magnet shaped like a pear.

The other five I shuffled into a stack and slid under the body of the camera, face-down. She'd find them next time she used it. I could see her at this table working through them one at a time, and I knew which one she'd pick up first and which one she'd put down last, and I was right about both, which I'll get to.

I left the camera where it had been. Reset. Like nothing happened.

* * *

The coffee maker was the kind with a glass carafe and a metal basket. The bag in the freezer was a dark roast I didn't recognize. I scooped a generous amount and started a pot.

Eggs in the fridge. A loaf on the counter, half wrapped. Butter left out from the night before. A cast iron pan on a peg over the stove.

I know how to do this. Hadn't in a long time. Still knew how. Four eggs into a bowl, scrambled with the back of a fork. Four slices cut and set aside. Burner lit. Pan on. A knob of butter went in and started to foam.

Six years, maybe seven, since I made breakfast for anyone but myself. Korval doesn't count - Korval eats when he's told to and not when he isn't. There was a colleague who came by the safehouse on Saturdays for a while, and once or twice I made him a bacon and egg on toast. Not the same.

This was the same.

The coffee finished. I poured hers and set it at the far end of the counter, near the doorway from the hall. The kitchen filled up with butter and eggs and dark roast.

That'd do it, I figured. The coffee, at least.

The chamomile was in the cupboard over the sink, second shelf, in a tin with a hinged lid. I'd found it while I was looking for the pan and I'd stood there with the lid open longer than a person needs to.

I made myself a cup. There was a whole pot of the real thing four feet away and a can in my bag besides, and I made myself a cup of hot water and a flower, because she'd handed me one two nights ago and I'd been thinking about it since. Nobody has ever once handed it to me. Not in my own kitchen, not anywhere.

Somewhere down the hall, floorboards.

* * *

I lowered the heat on the pan.

She came in wearing a long flannel robe, slippers, hair tied back loose at the nape of her neck. Blinked at the lamp. Then at me.

Then at the fridge.

Her hand came up slow and rested on the doorframe. She looked at the photo a long second. Looked back at me. The corner of her mouth did something.

"Well," she said. "Look at that."

"Coffee's there." I tilted my head at the mug by the door.

"Bless you." She crossed the kitchen and picked it up with both hands, the way old people hold coffee on a cold morning. Long sip. Eyes closed.

"Strong enough?"

"Right strength." She opened her eyes and went back to the fridge. "When did you take that."

"A few minutes ago."

"Mm." She walked over and stood in front of it. Reached up and touched the corner, gentle, the way she'd touched my ear the night before.

"You look like somebody who'd taken a picture of herself in a kitchen," she said.

"I was."

"You should do that more often." She turned, mug in hand. "I'll have to find a frame for it."

I didn't know what to say to that.

She went to the counter where the camera was. Set her mug down. Lifted the Polaroid to move it aside, and the little stack underneath came up against her hand and fanned out across the counter.

She made a small sound. Not surprised. Pleased.

I plated the eggs and buttered the toast and didn't look.

I heard her settle into a chair behind me. The soft sound of photographs being shuffled, examined, set down one at a time. A small laugh somewhere in there. The kind you make to yourself.

"Sweetheart."

"Yeah."

"This one is a crime."

"Which one."

"The teeth one. The big one. You look like the cover of a heavy metal album."

"That's the kind I figured."

"It's wonderful."

I brought both plates over and set hers down in front of her. She was still holding the bared-teeth picture between her thumb and forefinger like a tarot card. First one she picked up. Last one she put down.

"Eat first," I said.

She set it down carefully, face up. "Bossy."

* * *

We ate.

She asked things between bites. Did I cook often. Where had I learned. Did the eggs come out the way I liked them. Small questions. The kind you ask to keep somebody talking.

I answered. Not many words to most of it. Enough.

Then, not looking up from her plate: "You made a whole pot and you're not drinking any of it."

"It doesn't sit right."

"Mm." She let that be the end of it, which I hadn't expected. There was no follow-up. No *is that a wolf thing*. She ate another forkful and I watched her decide not to ask, and I understood that she'd file it and it would simply be true from now on - that in that house, going forward, there would be chamomile, and nobody would ever say why.

After a while she set her fork down, picked her mug up, and said, "What happened to you after that place came down."

I set my fork down too. "Someone from the people I work for now found me. They had paperwork on me. They offered me a job."

"Just like that."

"Just like that. I'm not really supposed to talk about who or how."

"Mm. I won't ask."

I took a sip. "He brought me a sandwich before he asked me anything else. That part stuck."

She smiled faintly. "Mm. They trained you, after."

"For a while, yeah."

"What was the hard part."

"Learning how to look human again. Don't flick your ears at every loud noise. Smile without showing your teeth. Don't sniff things." I shook my head a little. "Don't sniff things was the one that kept catching me out. I'd lean toward something without realizing."

"Did you ever get past it."

"Eventually."

She laughed once. Quietly.

Chapter 7 - The Letter

A few moments of silence. There was something I wanted to say.

I'd been rehearsing it since the photo went on the fridge. Two hours of it - the wording, the tone, how to make it land matter-of-fact, which is a thing I was trained to do and am good at. I had a version that came out clean. Professional. The kind of thank-you you give a colleague who covered your shift. I'd run it enough times that it was safe.

The silence stretched. I didn't fill it. Neither did she.

I looked at her.

The clean version dissolved.

"Thank you for accepting me for who I am."

It came out small. The last word cracked.

She didn't say anything. She got up. Came around the table. Put a hand on my shoulder.

And that was it. That was all it took, and I'll be honest about how little it was: a hand, on a shoulder, from a woman who'd known me for nineteen hours.

I have been braced for so long that bracing stopped registering as an activity. It's not something I do. It's the shape I am. I built the disguise, and the silence, and the whole catalogue of polite goodbyes for after people see what I am, and every piece of that was engineering - deliberate, tested, load-rated. It works. It has never failed.

Nothing in it was built for a hand on my shoulder that meant it.

I broke.

It was short and hard and I couldn't stop it, and I did try - I want that much down - that I did the thing I do, went for the tension, went to take hold of my own breathing the way I've done in worse rooms than this one, and there was nothing there to take hold of. The controls were not connected to anything. I have never once in my adult life not been able to do that.

She was worried. She asked if she'd done something wrong. She hadn't. I couldn't get my voice to work well enough to tell her, which meant for about forty seconds my grandmother sat there believing she'd hurt me, and I couldn't fix it, and that made it worse, which made it longer.

When it was done I was empty.

That's the only word for it. Something that had been carried was, briefly, not being carried. No responsibilities. No hiding. Not here, anyway. Not for a minute.

I apologized. I didn't know what else to say. It was the only sentence I had in the drawer that fit.

"What are you apologizing for, sweetheart."

I wiped my face with the back of my wrist. The words came out flat - the debrief voice, because it was the only one I trusted with this.

"I'm used to being told to leave. Every time. By the third meeting somebody starts looking for a reason to end it. I came in here expecting that. I didn't have a frame for the other thing."

"Mm."

"I'm not asking you to feel bad. It's just what's true. I came in ready to leave."

She didn't make a thing of it. She kept her hand where it was a long moment, then let it slide off in a way that didn't feel like leaving.

She sat back down across from me. Picked up her mug. Didn't fill the silence. I've noticed she does that - she leaves the room for you to walk into, and doesn't stand in the doorway while you decide.

I took a drink of mine. The room had gone brighter, the window letting in enough that the lamp wasn't pulling its weight anymore. Her eggs had gone cold. She didn't seem to notice.

"Can I ask you something."

"Anything, sweetheart."

I looked at the picture on the fridge a second. Then back at her.

"My mother. My father. The ones in the photo."

She nodded once.

"Are they - " I couldn't find the rest of it.

"Still living?"

"Yeah."

She took her time with the answer.

"As far as I know. Last word I had was a few years back. They settled in the end - bought a small patch of land up north and put a trailer on it. They grow most of what they eat. There's a kind of struggling that goes quiet once it stops moving."

I nodded. Didn't trust my voice yet.

"I might have something, though. Let me see."

She got up slow and went down the hall. Past the room I'd slept in. To a door at the end I hadn't noticed, which I'd like to flag, because I notice doors. That's not a boast, it's a condition. I'd catalogued that hallway on the way to bed and I had four doors and she opened a fifth, and it means the catalogue was already coming apart in that house, and had been since the chair.

Hinges complained. A drawer opened. Papers moved. Something heavier - a box - scraped across a wood floor. The sound a person makes when they're not sure where the thing is, only that it's in there.

I stayed at the table. Drank what was left of mine. Looked at the photo on the fridge so I wasn't looking at nothing.

After a while she came back. Slower than she went. An envelope in one hand and a small folded paper in the other.

"Here." She set them down. "Last letter I got from your mother. Few years old now. It's got a return address - a P.O. box for a small town up north. They'll be near it. They wouldn't have left that land." A pause. "She used to write me once a year. Christmas. Then it stopped. I figured she ran out of things to say. Could mean they're fine."

I picked up the envelope. The handwriting on the front was careful in the way handwriting gets when paper is a thing you don't waste. I know that hand. Not hers - the type. I've seen it on foster paperwork, on forms filled out by people who are being careful because being careless costs money.

"They're proud, mind you," she said. Quiet. "They wouldn't take money. Wouldn't take charity. They taught themselves how to do everything because they had to - how to grow, how to mend, how to fix what most people would throw out. If you go to them - and I'm not telling you to or not to - you bring something they can use, not something that makes them feel small."

"Like what."

She thought about it. "Things you can't pull out of a garden. Salt. Coffee. Spices. Good vinegar. The little things people stop having when there's nothing left at the end of the month." She looked at me. "You'd know better than me, once you'd seen them."

I turned the envelope over. The flap was still sealed at one corner where she'd opened it.

"You take it," she said. "It belongs to you more than it belongs to me."

I didn't answer.

I put the letter against my chest. Hadn't planned to. My hand did it, the same way it went across the kitchen when she held hers out.

She watched me do it and didn't say a word about it.

"Thank you," I said.

"Of course, sweetheart."

Chapter 8 - The Road North

Korval's car came down the road outside, slow on the gravel.

Rosalyn looked toward the window. Then back at me.

"Oh, sweetheart."

"Yeah."

"I don't have your number."

"I don't have yours."

We both moved at once.

She went for a drawer by the wall phone and pulled out a pad of grocery-list paper. I got my phone out. Korval honked once outside - polite.

"How fast can you write," I said.

"Faster than you'd think."

She called her number out from memory. Ten digits, slow and clear. I saved her as ROSALYN R, no embellishment. Then I called mine out, twice, because I didn't trust the first time. She wrote it down in handwriting that hadn't gotten any less careful since the envelope.

Korval honked again. Less polite.

"He doesn't normally do that twice."

"Then we'd better move."

I slung my bag. She pressed the envelope and the folded letter into my hands.

"Take care of yourself, sweetheart."

"I'll call you."

"You'd better." A small swat at my shoulder.

I want it noted that a woman I met yesterday hit me. Lightly. As a scolding. I have no record of a relative doing that at any point in my life, and I did not have a reaction ready, and so my face did nothing at all, which I think she read correctly anyway.

I nodded. Turned toward the door. Got to it. Stopped. Turned back.

"I'll come back when I can."

"I know, honey."

I walked to the car. Korval had the back door open and was looking pointedly somewhere that was not the porch. I got in. The door closed.

He pulled away.

She was on the porch when I turned to look. She raised a hand. I raised mine. The house got smaller.

"Good visit?" Korval asked.

"Good visit."

He didn't ask what was in the envelope. He never asks.

* * *

The road toward the highway ran straight a long while, fields on both sides going gold in the late light. I sat in the back with the envelope in my lap. I'd meant to put it in the bag. My hands hadn't done it.

I turned it over. The return address in the corner, careful handwriting, a P.O. box for a town I'd never heard of, somewhere up north. My mother's hand. A few years old, she'd said. *They wouldn't have left that land.*

"Korval."

"Mm."

"How far north can this car go before you start complaining."

He met my eyes in the mirror for the first time all day. Considered it. Looked back at the road.

"It is a good car," he said. "It does not complain. The driver, maybe, needs coffee."

"There's coffee on the way."

"Then the car goes as far as you want."

I looked at the address a moment longer.

I could have gone home. That was the whole shape of the thing: I'd come for a grandmother, I'd got one, the operation was complete and successful and nothing about it required a second act. Going north was not the assignment. Going north meant knocking on a trailer door to ask two

people why they'd kept me on nothing for six years and then let a nurse's form decide the rest of it, and I did not have a question prepared, and I have never once walked into a room without knowing what I was there to get.

I went anyway. I'd like to be able to tell you what I was going for. I couldn't have told Korval if he'd asked, which is possibly why he doesn't.

Then I clipped the comms pin to the base of my ear and keyed it.

"Chimera One to Wiki."

"Wiki receiving. That's twice in two days you've called when nobody made you."

"I'm extending. Few more days. Maybe a week."

A pause that was Vanity deciding how much to make of it, and deciding on nothing. "Extending where."

"North. Rosalyn gave me a letter. There's a return address on it." I turned the envelope face-up against my knee. "My mother. My father. They're up there. Or they were."

"And you're going to knock on that door too."

"I'm going to drive to the town and see if the box is still rented. After that I don't know."

"Then I don't either." Her voice didn't change, but the cadence did - the version of her that writes things down without being asked. "I'll move your leave to open-ended and keep the desk off you. Same arrangement. Call me once a day, just so I know you're alive."

"You keep saying that like it's a real risk."

"You keep going to places where it is." A half-beat. "Bring them something useful, Operator. Not money. Rosalyn's right about that."

I didn't ask how she knew what Rosalyn had said. She always knows more than she's been told; it's the whole of what she's for, and asking would only make her explain it, and then I'd have to know.

"Roger that."

"Drive safe. Let the man have his coffee."

The pin cooled a degree. Open, idle. I left it.

I slid the envelope into the inside pocket of my jacket, next to the photograph from 1985. The grandmother, and now the way to the rest of them, riding together over my heart.

"North," I told Korval.

"North," he agreed, and took the on-ramp the other way than home.

The fields gave out to trees. The trees got taller and closer to the road, and the light through them went the ordinary green of a long evening, and I watched the town where I'd found my grandmother fall away behind me, and let myself, for once, look forward to the next thing instead of bracing for it.

Chapter 9 - The People Up North

The drive took the better part of a day.

The highway thinned as it went, four lanes down to two, two down to a county road with grass coming up through the seams. The country changed with it. Fields gave out to woods, woods to low hills, and the towns got further apart and smaller in between, each one a gas station and a church and a handful of houses that had been good once and were holding on now.

I watched it go by from the back seat. I've seen poor. I've worked in it. But there's a difference between a city's poor - loud, crowded, fast, a thing happening *to* people at speed - and this. This is quiet. This is a place where the struggling stopped moving long enough to put down roots and grow a garden in it.

A kind of struggling that goes quiet once it stops moving. Rosalyn's words. They fit the window.

Korval didn't talk much on the long stretches. He drank his coffee from the gas station two towns back and let the road do the talking, and once, when a deer stepped out onto the shoulder and thought better of it, he slowed without a word and let it change its mind.

* * *

I called Vanity in the early afternoon, somewhere between a town with a name and a town without one.

"Chimera One to Wiki."

"Wiki receiving. Still got a world."

"Still got a world. Getting close."

"Mm." The sound of her setting it down somewhere only she can read. "The box is still rented, by the way. I checked. Same name on it as the letter. Renewed eight months ago, in cash, at the counter."

I closed my eyes a second. Eight months. Recent enough.

"You weren't going to tell me you checked."

"I just did tell you." A half-beat. "I didn't want you driving a day on a dead address. That's all. The rest is yours to find."

That's the arrangement with her, and it took me years to see the shape of it. She'll pull the thread that saves you a day. She won't pull the one that saves you the walk. She has never once explained the difference and she has never once gotten it wrong.

"Thanks, Vanity."

"Call me tonight." And she was gone.

* * *

The town was called Hadley's Fork, and it was a feed store, a diner, a post office the size of a shed, and a general store that sold a little of everything because there was nowhere else to sell it.

I went in disguised. Hat. Dress. The contacts already grinding by the time I pushed the door open. The man behind the counter looked up, took me in the way men in small stores take in a stranger, and went back to his crossword when I didn't turn out to be interesting.

I took my time.

Salt - the good coarse kind, two boxes. A bag of whole coffee beans and a second of ground, because I didn't know if they had a grinder. Black pepper. A jar of cinnamon and one of cardamom. A bottle of cider vinegar with some age on the label. A tin of good tea, on a guess about my mother. Matches. A coil of decent rope, because rope is rope and everyone up here uses it.

Nothing that looked like charity. Everything that looked like a person had thought about it.

I stood in that aisle longer than the shopping needed. It's the only problem I've been handed in years that I could actually work - a real one, with constraints, with a right answer. Two people I've never met, too proud for money, and a budget of what fits in a bag. That's a puzzle. I can do puzzles. I understood while I was doing it that I was hiding in the arithmetic, and I let myself, because it was the last thing between me and the road out of town.

At the counter I paid cash, like everyone does, and when the man rang it up he said, "Passing through?"

"Looking for family," I said. True enough to say flat.

"Mm. Lot of family up these roads." He bagged the salt. "Most of it likes to be left alone."

"I'll keep it polite."

He nodded like that was the right answer and didn't ask the name. I'd had a half-dozen ways ready to not answer. Didn't need any of them.

* * *

The land was four miles out, up a road that stopped being paved and then stopped being graded and was, by the end, two ruts and a strip of weeds down the middle that hissed along the underside of the car.

Korval took it slow. The trees pressed close. Then they opened.

A clearing. A trailer set back from the road on cinder blocks, its skirt patched with sheet metal in three different colors, every patch square and deliberate, done by someone who'd had to learn how. A garden beside it - bigger than a garden, near an acre, fenced against deer with posts that didn't match and wire that had been spliced and respliced until it was more splice than wire. Rain barrels at the corners of the roof. A woodpile, stacked tight and high and covered, that said somebody here takes winter seriously and meets it head-on every year. A clothesline. A dog run with no dog in it, the gate standing open.

Everything mended. Nothing new. The whole place a long argument with going without, and winning it, barely, one season at a time.

I read that clearing the way I read a site, because that's the instrument I have. Entry points. Sightlines. Where a person would come from. And what it gave me back, item by item, was competence. Every single thing in that clearing was a problem somebody had solved with their hands because nobody was coming to solve it for them.

I have been told my whole life that I came from nothing. I was looking at the nothing. It had a fence around it that had been repaired eleven times.

Korval stopped the car at the mouth of the clearing, well back from the trailer, the way he stops anywhere he doesn't yet understand. Put it in park. Did not turn the engine off.

"You want me closer."

"No. Here's good. Better they see the car than have it sneak up."

"Mm." He looked at the trailer through the windshield, then at me in the mirror. For once he didn't look away. "You are not going in as the soldier."

"No."

"As the other one. The salt and the coffee."

"As the granddaughter," I said. "If that's a thing I get to be twice."

He considered that, seemed to find it acceptable, and went back to watching the trees.

* * *

I got out.

I gathered the bags from the seat beside me - salt and coffee and the rest of it, the weight of a person who'd thought about you before she'd met you - and stood in the ruts a moment and let myself notice how loud my own heartbeat had gotten.

Smoke off the stovepipe. Thin and pale against the evening. Somebody was home. Somebody was inside, right now, doing the ordinary thing of keeping warm.

The contacts itched. The hat sat heavy. The dress was wrong for the road and wrong for the place and wrong, I understood standing there, for the whole of what I'd come to do.

Rosalyn's voice again. *You don't ever do that in this house.*

But this wasn't Rosalyn's house. This was a door I'd never knocked on, held shut by two people who gave me away because the world didn't leave them another choice, and I did not know - standing in the ruts with a bag of salt in each hand - whether they'd open it to the careful stranger, or to what was under the hat, or at all.

Here is what I had: no plan. Two days ago I'd have called that impossible. I don't move without a plan; the plan is the thing that keeps the room from happening to me. I had run every version of this on the drive and every version required knowing what I wanted, and I didn't, and I still don't, and I got out of the car anyway.

I made myself walk.

Past the garden. Past the woodpile. Up the two cinder-block steps to the door, where a coffee can of cigarette butts long gone to rust sat on the rail and a windchime made of bent spoons turned without ringing in the still air.

I set the bags down on the step. Freed my hands.

My fingers went to the brim of the hat. Stopped there. Held it.

I didn't decide. There wasn't time to decide. There was only the door, close enough now to see the grain in it, and the smoke overhead, and the small ordinary sound of someone moving around inside - a chair scraping, a cupboard, a voice I couldn't make out saying something to no one in particular.

I raised my hand, and knocked.

Mireheart

Mireheart - the premise so far

The Book of Brine - an anomalous artifact, contaminated with a chimera virus.

* * *

The book wants to be read. That is its only need. Its only purpose.

To achieve this, it changes reality. The room grows quiet. The light softens. Time slows just enough that nothing interrupts you. The world outside the pages stops mattering. The book makes sure of that.

It wants to be immersive. So it makes itself immersive. By force.

* * *

The Artifact

Waterlogged. Bound in something that used to be hide. The text shifts between readings - sentences rewriting themselves, margins growing new paragraphs, pages appearing that weren't there before. Not because the virus does this. The book does this. The book has always done this.

It surfaces every few generations. Pulled from a wreck. Washed up after a storm. Found in an estate the heirs didn't know belonged to them.

Open it and you don't stop. Not because you can't. Because the book has made the rest of the world feel like a dream you already left.

* * *

The Virus

Separate. A chimera. Stitched from sources that should not have met.

It contaminated the book at some point - no one knows when. No one knows how. The book picked it up like a dirty needle. Now they travel together.

The virus does not make you read. The book handles that. The virus waits. It transfers through skin contact - touching the pages, touching the binding, touching someone else who has touched it.

The virus changes the body. Scales. Gills. Eyes flattening to the sides of the head. Lungs that start to crave water. A slow migration from human to something else. Something the bog recognizes.

* * *

Together

The book makes you forget the outside world. The virus rebuilds you for a different one.

The reality warping is the book's doing. The bog creeping into the room - the peat smell, the standing water, the moss on the walls - that is the virus finding purchase in a world the book has already softened.

You cannot separate them anymore. The book is the door. The virus is what lives inside.

* * *

Reading aloud

The book wants to be heard. More listeners means more readers. More readers means more immersion. More immersion means the book gets to be real in more places at once.

The virus spreads through the sound of your voice. Through the moisture in your breath. Through the scales flaking off your hands as you turn the page.

Whoever hears you wants to come closer. That is the book's work. Whoever touches the book after you will carry the virus. That is something else.

* * *

The Agency

They have known about the artifact for generations. They have known about the chimera for less time - it wasn't always there. Someone contaminated the book. Or something. The files are incomplete.

The protocol contains the book. The book escapes anyway.

The protocol does not account for a virus that lives in the pages and transfers through skin. They are updating it constantly. They are always behind.

* * *

Inciting incident

A fisherman dredges up the Book of Brine. He doesn't read it - he can't. But he touches it. He carries it to a museum. He hands it to a curator.

The virus has its first new hosts before anyone opens the cover.

A kid sneaks off during a visit. Finds the Book in a back room. Opens it. The book does its work. The virus does its work.

The primary gets the case. He is good at it. That is why they sent him.

By the time Osyra is dispatched, the kid is not the only reader anymore, several people who never read at all are feeling scales under their sleeves, and the primary has stopped filing.

The last report he filed is clean, competent, and correct. She reads it on the way in. It tells her nothing, which is the first thing that is wrong.

* * *

POV - Osyra

First person, same as the rest. She is the one walking in.

The book opens with her geared up and approaching the zone. Not observing it from outside. Entering it. The whole story is the walk in and what it costs.

Her instrument is what makes this one work: she reads rooms, she reads sites, she catalogues. Mireheart is a place where reading is the injury. Every professional habit she has is a way of getting closer to a thing that only needs you to look at it a little longer.

She knows the protocol: do not read. Do not touch without gloves. Do not get close enough to hear someone reading aloud.

She has never had trouble not touching things. That is not where she is vulnerable, and she knows it, and she is right, and it does not help.

* * *

The primary

The Operator already on the case. Male, name TBD. Canon: on the watch list, has read the book deep, **has stopped filing.**

He is not the POV. He is what she finds. He is the man in the chair - the one who already made every decision she is walking toward, in order, and can explain each one, and would make them again.

His arc happened before she arrived. She reconstructs it from evidence, the way she reconstructs everything: the gloves on the table. The reports that stop. The peat.

He is not a warning. He is a demonstration. A competent Operator who took each step for a reason she can follow, and she can follow it, and that is the horror.

* * *

The question

Whether she can pull him out - and whether she can do it without becoming part of the story herself.

Her defense is control. Mireheart doesn't attack control. It rewards it. The book does not need her to break; it needs her to keep looking, carefully, professionally, for just a little longer than she should.

Not a cage that contains her. A cage she inspects her way into.

* * *

Stakes

If no one stops the spread, the world becomes the bog. Peat. Standing water. Dark glassy pools. No horizon. No dry land.

The book will have what it wants. Total immersion. A reality that is nothing but the story.

The virus will have what it wants. Hosts forever.

* * *

Chapter cadence

Short. Fragmented. The prose drifts as she does.

Her voice is the instrument the story plays. She narrates analytically - that is how she thinks, that is her whole defense - so the drift shows up as **analysis that stops arriving anywhere**. The observations stay sharp. The conclusions stop coming. She keeps cataloguing, correctly, for longer and longer, about less and less.

She does not notice. The reader does. That is the gap the horror lives in.

Late chapters: she is still describing peat with total precision and has not asked why in six pages.

The last one is written from inside the bog. There is no return.

* * *

Chapters coming.

Red Light

Red Light District

A thought experiment: what a Chimera partner would even look like. Different variant, so the math doesn't work - that's the point of running it. First person. Unpublished seed for the romance mini-book.

The bar didn't have a name on the outside, which was the point. Inside, the lights were low and red, and that was the point too - under red light, red eyes don't show. It's the only room in the city where I don't wear the contacts. I found it the way I find everything: by following the smell of people hiding the same thing I am.

He was already at the back when I came in. I knew before I saw him, because the place went quiet in the particular way a room goes quiet around a predator the other predators respect. A cup of something untouched in front of him. A stillness I recognized, because it was mine.

When he looked up his eyes were the same impossible red, and slit down the middle like a cat's.

"Chimera-Four," he said. Not a question. "I can smell the wolf on you from here."

"Nine." I sat without being asked.

Neither of us pretended not to look. He didn't flinch at my size. He didn't measure himself against it either, which is the other thing men do, and the one I've never found a way to answer. He registered me and went back to being still, and something in my chest I'd kept clamped for a decade came loose a quarter-turn.

We didn't talk about the labs. That's the etiquette. You don't ask which facility, which guardian sold you, how many of your cohort came out the other side. You talk around it, in the shorthand of people who already know the shape of the hole.

"You hide the eyes," he said eventually. "Out there."

"Contacts."

"I wear sunglasses. People think I'm an asshole." A flicker at the corner of his mouth - not quite a smile, but the place one would go. "Better than the alternative."

I found, to my own irritation, that I'd leaned in.

Up close he smelled of nothing I had to be afraid of. No fear-sweat. No adrenaline. Nobody bracing to run from me or to win against me. Just a tired person who'd survived the same machine and come out still able to make a joke about sunglasses.

It was the absence of a thing. That's what got me - not what he was doing, what he wasn't. No performance. I have spent my whole life in rooms where everybody is performing at me, and I've gotten so good at reading the performance that I forgot there was a version without one underneath.

"You're staring," he said.

"You're not running," I said.

"No," he agreed. "Why would I."

That was the whole of it.

Not a confession. Not a promise. I'm not built for those and I don't think he is either, though I want to be careful there - I don't know that. I know I'm not, and I know he didn't reach for one, and I have spent an hour deciding those are the same fact and they aren't.

The math I do know. Red eyes met red eyes, and a cat and a wolf make nothing between them but company. The rewrite made us different species twice over. There's no future here of the kind the world keeps score by, and I did that arithmetic before I sat down, the way I do all of it, and I sat down anyway.

Just this. A red room. Two survivors. The rare and ordinary relief of being a person somebody looked at and didn't look away from.

I slid the contacts case across the table and let him see me do it. Let him watch me decide, in front of him, not to hide.

That was the only thing I did all night that I'd call a choice. Everything else I could explain - the bar, the sitting, the leaning in. Not that. That one I made on purpose and I still couldn't tell you what I was buying.

He picked up his cup.

Outside, the city kept insisting on its rules, on its breeding and its belonging and its lists of what counts. In here, under the red light, none of it could reach us, and for one held breath that was enough.

I'd leave first, later. I always do.

But not yet.

For the Next Operator

Preface - For the Next Operator

You've done two years of aftermath by now. Boxes to the vault, verification runs on towns where nothing happened, statements off people who'd already decided what they saw. You've stood in sites the Janitors were erasing and written the report they told you to write. So you've seen a lot of cleaned floors and you have opinions.

Keep them. You'll need something to be wrong with.

This isn't the binder. The binder has the containment grids and the number to call and it will keep you alive, so read it. The binder will never tell you what the people you save are like.

I should say plainly that I don't know why I'm writing this down. I've started it four times in nine years. The first three had no one's name on them and I burned two.

What I can tell you is that these stay in me whether I write them or not, and putting them on paper does not get them out - I've tested that, it doesn't work, I still have every one. So the writing isn't for me. And it can't be for them, because most of them would rather I didn't exist and the rest are dead.

That leaves you. You're not the reason. You're just who was standing there when I finally finished it, and a stack of paper with nobody's name on the front is the kind of thing a person burns.

So: for the next operator. It's a better reason than no reason, and I've been through the alternatives.

Here is the only thing I'll tell you flat, before the rest.

You arrive after. That's the shape of the work. Something has already happened by the time the plane is on the ground, and your job is to walk into a room where people made decisions for two days without you and determine what they did. Not what they say they did. What they did.

So you look first. You do not come through the door with a verdict. Some of the time these people have been doing something sensible and nobody has told them so. I met a woman who tracked a den for three weeks off brownouts and which nights the dogs wouldn't cross the yard. She handed me the notebook apologizing for it. Every entry was correct. Somebody should have said so years earlier.

I said so. That is rare, and I want you to understand how rare before you go looking for it. Once a year, maybe twice, somebody makes four decisions in a row and all four are efficient and intelligent under pressure. The rest of the time you will find a man who went back into a burning house for a photo album. A barricade that worked out who to feed through the fire door. A boy fishing past the buoys because nobody enforced the buoys.

When that's what you find, say so. Out loud, to their face, while there is still something to be done about it.

It won't land. I've never once watched it land. Say it anyway, because the alternative is standing in the room agreeing that nothing could have been done, and something could always have been done, and I'm not going to be one more person telling them otherwise.

They will hate you for it. That is the cost and I'm not going to dress it up. You will pull people out of a hole and they will tell the inquest you were the thing in the hole. You'll have to carry both of those at once.

One more.

Stay in control. Of the mission, of the pack, of yourself. Everything that has ever been done to me happened in a moment when somebody else had the reins. Keep them. Nobody goes out ahead of you and nobody leaves.

- Chimera One, retiring

Chapter 1 - Nothing to Blame

A brood-thing had gotten into a shelter. Not a monster from the woods - one of the wet, patient ones that gets into a crawlspace and lays and waits, and by the time anyone smells it there are already too many. Forty-some people had barricaded themselves in the gymnasium. When I came through the doors the smell told me most of what I'd find and I was still not ready for the sound, which was a room of people who had decided, collectively, in the dark, that the barricade held only as long as it was fed.

They'd been pushing people out. Through a fire door, into the corridor where the thing was working, a few at a time, whenever the noise on the other side of the barricade started up again - because it went quiet for a while after. They'd worked out the exchange. They'd picked. Old ones first, then the ones nobody in the room would speak up for. There was a man running it, a big calm man with a clipboard from the front office, and he had a *list*, and he was keeping order, and the room was letting him because he'd turned the worst thing a person can do into a procedure and procedures let you not be the one deciding.

There was a boy still in the room he'd written down for the next quiet spell. Fourteen, maybe. His mother was holding the door-side of him and the man was explaining to her, gently, reasonably, why it had to be fair, why her boy's number had come up, and she was *listening*, she was starting to nod, that's the part I need you to understand - the barricade had been up two days and she was starting to nod.

Every word in me wanted to go at that man. Wanted to tell the room exactly what they were and put it in the air where they'd have to breathe it. If I had, they'd have closed around it - forty people who needed the list to be fair, deciding the animal in the doorway was the actual threat. And they'd have been right that I was dangerous. I'd have lost the room and the boy both while I was busy being correct.

So I didn't. I gave the man his procedure back and stepped inside it. Told him I was the relief, that the exchange was over because the count outside was handled, that he'd kept order and now he could stand down and I needed his help getting people to the buses. I let him be the calm man with the clipboard who'd held it together instead of the calm man who'd sorted his neighbors by who'd scream least. I watched him take it - watched relief go across his face, actual relief, that someone had come to tell him he'd done well. He set the boy's paper down on the stack like it was nothing. Like it had always been paper.

We got them out. All of the ones still living, the boy included. It worked. The mercy I didn't spend on that man is the reason a fourteen-year-old walked onto a bus.

I found what was in the corridor after. I made myself look, because someone in that building owed them a witness and the room had already voted not to be one. There were eleven. The thing ate slow and it ate low, started at the soft parts and worked out, so most of them had been alive and aware for the front half of it - you could read which ones had tried to crawl back to the barricade by how far they'd gotten with what they had left, and one had gotten a surprising distance, a woman, on her elbows, because from the knees down there was no longer anything to use and she had kept going anyway on the parts of her that still answered. They'd died in the order the list gave them and you could see the order on the floor, oldest nearest the door where they'd been pushed first, and the quiet the room had learned to time the exchange by was the thing pausing between them, unhurried, because a barricade that feeds itself is in no rush and neither was what it fed. That's not the monster I want you to remember. The monster was the arithmetic. The monster was the nodding. The thing in the corridor was just hungry; it had no idea it was the least guilty animal in the building.

The man gave a statement. Of course he did. He described the operator that arrived - the animal, he called me - and how it "removed him from a leadership role during the crisis" and he wasn't sure it had followed protocol. He was building his defense already, in case anyone ever asked about a list, and the first brick of it was me.

He never mentioned the corridor. Neither did the room. Forty people, and it simply hadn't happened. There'd been a monster, and an animal the Agency sent, and everyone in the gym had been survivors together.

That's the part I didn't expect. Not the list - I understand the list. Two days behind a barricade and a man with a clipboard offering to be the one who decides, I know exactly how that happens and so will you. What I couldn't get past is how fast forty people agreed on a version. Nobody organized it. There was no meeting. They just walked out into the daylight and were, all of them at once, people who had survived a thing that was done to them. It took less than a day.

They needed the eleven not to have been pushed. So the eleven weren't pushed. And they needed the pushing to have been something's fault, and I was standing right there being the wrong shape.

I called that man steady. Out loud, in front of his neighbors, while eleven people cooled twenty feet away, because the boy was in the room and blame would have cost me the boy.

I'd do it again. I want to be honest that I'd do it again, and that I have, four or five times since, and that it gets easier, and that I don't know what to do with how easy it's gotten.

Chapter 2 - Worth Saying

The town was small and it had been wrong about which of its neighbors was the monster.

There was a woman there who'd figured out where a pack was denning. Weeks before anyone. She kept a notebook - brownouts, which nights the dogs wouldn't cross the yard, a smell off the old cannery. Nobody listened to her; she was the kind nobody listens to, worn down to apologizing for the space she stood in. She gave me the notebook with her hands shaking and I read it and it was *good*, good enough that two people walked out of a building that night who wouldn't have, and I told her so. Not "thanks, this helps." I told her the specific thing - that it was better fieldwork than what I get from people who are paid for it, that lives were leaving that town tonight on the strength of her paying attention when no one asked her to. I watched her sit up under it. It was true. That's why it landed.

But the notebook had a name in it. She'd written down, weeks back, that the smell was strongest near the old cannery and that a man named Delph came and went from it at odd hours - not an accusation, just a woman noting a thing near another thing. And a town that had spent a month frightened and looking for somewhere to put the fear had gotten hold of a version of her notebook. And they'd decided Delph.

He wasn't. I'd already put the pack down; I knew exactly what had been living in the cannery and it hadn't been a man. Delph was just a sour old bachelor who kept strange hours because strange hours are what you keep when no one's waiting on you. None of that mattered. By the time I understood what the town had decided, they'd already gone to his house.

I got there and there was a crowd in the yard and there was already not much they hadn't done.

They'd started before they were sure. That's the part. They didn't wait to be right. They'd pulled him out through his own front window - the glass was still in him, in his back and one cheek, when I got there - and they'd used a length of chain from someone's truck, and they had done to his hands the thing a frightened crowd always does to the hands, because a crowd hates hands, hands are what a witch curses you with, so his were broken back on themselves and would not have held a spoon again even if the rest of him had been let live. Someone had gone at his mouth with a boot - to stop the talking, I think, because he'd been telling them the truth and the truth is unbearable when you've already decided - and the teeth were on the ground in front of him like something spilled. He was still alive when they set him going. I need you to hold that. The fire was near the end for them but it was the long middle for him; they lit a man who was still trying to say his own name through a mouth that couldn't shape it anymore, and the sound a person makes then is not screaming, screaming is from before, this was lower and wetter and it came in time with the

breathing and it is a sound I did not have a slot for and now do. He cooked from the legs up and the crowd's faces in the firelight were not the faces of monsters. That was the horror of it. They looked *relieved*. They looked like people who had finally been allowed to put something down.

And when I came through the fence, the thing that made them scatter and scream *monster* was me. The animal. Arriving too late to a thing they'd done with their own hands and their own good sense of justice, and being, to them, the only horror in the yard.

The pack in the cannery killed cleanly compared to what those people did to Delph. It killed to eat. It was quick because quick is efficient, and nothing in it wanted him to suffer, because nothing in it wanted anything but food.

The town wanted him to suffer. That's the difference and I want it to sit wrong with you. Suffering wasn't a byproduct of what they needed done, it was the thing they needed done. A man who dies fast doesn't discharge anything. They'd been carrying a month of being frightened in their own houses with nowhere to put it, and fear that can't find its object turns into something that has to be worked out of the body, and it gets worked out slow, on hands and teeth and the parts that make a person recognizable. That's not an excess of what they were doing. That's the function.

They were not monsters and I'm not going to call them monsters. Monsters would have been quicker.

And the woman. Her notebook did it - her careful, ignored, finally-appreciated notebook, the fieldwork I'd praised her for, was the document the town read Delph's death out of. She knew. She came to me after, not the town, *me*, because I was the only one who'd told her the work was good, and she asked me - she needed me to tell her - whether it was her fault. Whether if she'd never written it down. And I stood there with her looking up at me the way she had when I'd praised her, wanting the same key turned the other direction, wanting me to un-say the true thing.

I couldn't. I don't lie to people about the weight they carry; it's the one dignity I've got left to give. So I told her the truth, which was that she'd done nothing but see clearly, and that seeing clearly is not a crime, and that a town of decent people had taken her clear seeing and made it into a murder, and that the fault was theirs, every ounce. And I watched it not help. Because "it's not your fault" doesn't reach a person who is going to hear a man screaming in a yard for the rest of her life. I'd given her one warm hour with the notebook. The same notebook gave her that. The appreciation was real and the ruin was real and they came out of the exact same pages.

She wrote down a smell and a man's name in the same notebook because both were true. Forty of her neighbors read it and did what they had already been wanting to do, and then they needed it to have been the notebook that did it.

I told her the truth twice. Once about the fieldwork, which was good, and once about the fault, which was theirs. The first one she believed. It sat her up straight and it was the best hour of her year and I don't regret it.

The second one she nodded at and did not take in at all. I've thought about why. I think being at fault was the only version where she'd had any part in it - if the town did it on its own, then she was just another person in that yard, and she'd rather have done something monstrous than have been nobody in a crowd that burned a man.

She'd have taken the guilt. She was reaching for it. I wouldn't give it to her, so she's got neither.

Chapter 3 - What They Want

This is the one I'd cut out of myself if I could do it and keep the rest.

A stalker had moved into the treeline outside a farm road - the slow kind, works a family for weeks before it takes anyone. The whole road cleared but one house. A man in the doorway, shotgun that would've annoyed the thing and nothing more, telling me he wouldn't leave his land. Land wasn't it; his eyes kept cutting back into the house while his mouth said land. So I did the thing this chapter is about. I asked who was inside. His daughter, he said, and something in how he said it should have stopped me and didn't - grown, but *delicate*, that was his word, didn't go out, hadn't in years, couldn't be moved easy. He wasn't defending acreage. He was refusing to leave her. I read a father who loved his child too much to run, and I built my whole approach on it. Told him I'd carry her out myself, he'd be beside her the entire way, that leaving was the only way he got to keep her. Gun down inside a minute. Both of them out before midnight. I felt the clean thing you'll learn to chase, the feeling of a door opened exactly right.

Here's what I hadn't read. There was a bolt on her door. On the outside. I saw it going in and my mind filed it under *she wanders, he worries* because that was the story I'd already decided to be true, and you will do this, you will fit every detail to the story you picked in the first thirty seconds unless you fight yourself, and I didn't fight myself, and there was a bolt on the outside of a grown woman's door.

She told me in the staging area, once there were lights and other bodies and walls that weren't his. First walls that weren't his she'd stood inside since she was twelve. She told me flat, no shake in it, because the size of a thing wears the inflection off it after enough years - the way you'd report a road closure. She said her father had been coming into that room at night since she was a girl. That "delicate" meant he'd told her since she was small that she was too fragile for the world so she'd never think to try the door, and that the door had a bolt for the nights she stopped believing him. She said there had been a baby once, early, and that it had not been born in a hospital and was not spoken of again, and she said the word she used for what he did to her body was the plain clinical word, said it evenly, and then said the part that I still carry: that when she'd heard there was a monster in the trees, she had gotten down on the floor of that bolted room and prayed - really prayed, hands and everything - that it would come to the house. That it would come through her window first. She had wanted the thing in the treeline to reach her before he did one more time, because the thing in the treeline would at least be finished with her when it was done.

And I had carried her out of that. Personally. Gently. I had put my body between her and the only thing on that property that might have ended it, and I had spoken so beautifully to her father's *want* that he'd walked wherever I pointed, and the want I'd found and used as my handle - the

love, the won't-leave-my-child - was the machinery of the exact thing she'd been on her knees begging a monster to interrupt. The stalker never touched her. It circled for weeks and the worst thing on that farm had a key to her door and my full, competent, well-spoken cooperation.

I put it right after. As right as it goes, which with a thing like that is not much and is not fast, and "right" mostly means he does not get to be anywhere near her again and she gets people whose job is to help her carry it. I made sure of that part with my own hands. It doesn't unbolt the years. Nothing does.

The handle worked. That's what I can't get out from under. Want is the truest thing in a person and I found his on the first try and moved him like water, and I was *good* at it, I was so good at it that he put the gun down inside a minute.

Here's the thing about that man I keep going back to. He wasn't lying to me. That's what I expected to find when I finally understood, some cold thing that had been performing a father. There wasn't one. He loved her. Whatever was happening in his head when he said *delicate* was the real feeling, running at full strength, and it had been running that way for twenty years while he bolted her door from the outside. He wasn't defending a lie about himself. He was defending the truth, and the truth was that he loved her and kept her and used her and had never once had to hold those in the same hand, because nobody had ever made him.

Love isn't a safe word. Love is just a want that learned to call itself something noble, and it will pass every test you know how to give it. I gave him the test. He passed. I built my whole approach on him passing.

I saw the bolt. I want that on the record, because the convenient version is that he hid it from me and he did not hide anything. It was on the outside of her door at eye height and I looked directly at it and filed it as *she wanders, he worries*, because I'd picked my story in the first thirty seconds and after that every fact in the house got bent to fit.

And she was on the floor of that room praying for the thing in the trees to come through her window. It circled the house for three weeks and never came in. I did. I came in and I was competent and gentle and I put my body between her and the only mercy that had been offered to her in nine years, and I carried her past the bolt, and I was proud of it in the truck on the way out.

Chapter 4 - Her Name Was

Her name was Ellie.

A burrower came up through the floor of a daycare. Four minutes, start to finish, before I put it down - four minutes is nothing, four minutes is a held breath, and in four minutes it had killed three of the adults and opened up the morning like a can. You'll learn the smell of a room where that's happened. Under the blood there's crayon and juice and the powder they put on the little ones, and your brain refuses to file those two categories in the same room, and it has to, and something in you goes quiet that doesn't come back.

I found her under the reading table, folded into the corner where they kept the beanbags, not making a sound. That's the wrong quiet. A screaming child is a body still arguing for itself; you can work with screaming. This was a child who had already started to agree with the thing that hurt her. I've told you I'm six-four and armored and I'd just fired, I know exactly what I am to a small person in a corner, so I did the thing this chapter is about. I got low. I put every edge I had away. I made my voice into something with nothing left on it that could cut.

She had a name tag. A paper cloud, glitter glue gone stiff. *ELLIE*. Somebody had drawn a star next to it that morning, back when the morning was still the kind that got stars.

"Ellie," I said.

Her eyes came up. That's all it ever takes, and it never stopped being the one small miracle this job still handed me - that a person will surface from the deepest water in themselves just to answer their own name. It's the oldest trick and it isn't a trick. To say a person's name is to tell them *you are still someone; there is still a someone here to be*. She heard it and she chose, for one more minute, to be someone.

"That's a good name," I said. "Ellie. I'm going to get you out of here. You and me."

Her hand found my glove and held on with everything her body had, which was not much, and it was not much for a reason I could already see and was pretending with the front of my mind not to. The thing had caught her before it went for the door. Low, across the belly - they go for the belly on the small ones, the belly is soft and it's what's in reach when you're their size. It had opened her and most of what should stay inside a person was no longer being kept in by anything but the way she was folded around herself in that corner, and children don't understand that part, that's the mercy and the horror of it both, she didn't understand that holding herself the way she was holding herself was the only thing still in the argument. She wasn't in pain the way you'd

think. That kind of wound goes into shock warm and talkative and *lucid*, it gives you a bright calm window, and the window is exactly as long as it takes for a child to make you love her, and then it closes and it collects. I have never hated the design of a living thing the way I hate that window.

So I had a few minutes of a little girl who could talk, and I knew to the number of them what they were.

"When we get outside," I said - because you give them a *later*, you build a small door into the next hour and you ask them to want to walk through it - "when we get outside, I'm getting you something. Anything you want. You like toys?" A nod, barely. "Legos," she said, just the one word, quiet.

"Legos," I said. "I'll get you Legos. That's a promise, and I don't break promises."

I don't. In my whole ruined life that's the one ledger I've kept honest. I had it now - the exact thing, one word, Legos - and I would have driven to whatever store was still standing and bought the biggest set on the shelf and carried it out under my arm past every person who crossed the street to get away from me, and knelt, and put it in her hands, and for the length of that one exchange the arithmetic of my existence would have come out even.

She believed me. That was the connection, whole and real - the name, the softness, the promised later, every piece landing exactly the way it's supposed to. She believed there'd be a toy, and believing it she let me lift her, and she pressed her face into the cold plate of my chest rig where there was nothing warm to press into, and she trusted the monster because the monster had used her name. I carried her out holding her together with one hand, literally, that is not a figure of speech, and I talked to her the whole way about the toy.

She asked, once, near the doors, what the toy would be.

"Anything you want," I told her, and meant it, and it was the cruelest true thing I have ever said to a living soul, because wanting needs a tomorrow to spend the want in, and I had just handed a dying child a tomorrow the way you hand someone counterfeit money - not to cheat her, but because it was the only currency I had and I could not stand to send her out of the world with empty hands.

She was gone before the parking lot. It's quiet when it happens, after all that; the holding-on just stops, the small grip opens, and you're carrying weight that isn't arguing anymore.

Flat is the only way this survives being said, so: I did everything right. I remembered the name and the name worked. I built the later and the later worked. Everything I know how to do performed to specification and not one bit of it reached far enough to matter.

None of it was out there to begin with. The worth, the comfort, the someone-is-here - I carried all of it in myself and pressed it into a child, and the world did not keep the smallest part of the bargain, because the world was never in the bargain. Only I was.

Her name was Ellie. I kept it. Nobody else would; the parents, when they came, did not want it in my mouth, wanted me and my kind erased from the worst morning of their lives, and I understand that, and I kept the name anyway, one more entry in the long private ledger of the ones I said softly and correctly and to no ultimate end.

At debrief Vanity asked, in the clean flat language of the record, whether the objective was met. The objective had been the monster. The monster was dead.

"Objective met," I said.

And I thought the thing I always think and never say - that if I'd just let it keep coming, the whole screaming town would have stood in that parking lot together, strangers holding strangers, decent to each other in the pure clean way people only manage with something worse in the room. I could give them that. I could hand them their own humanity back, whole, for the price of a few of them.

But that's not the job. The job is not to save humanity. The job is to save the humans - the actual bodies, one town at a time, every one I can reach - and those two things are not the same thing and never will be, and most nights they're opposites. I save the humans. I am not allowed to save humanity, because saving humanity means letting the monster take some of them, and I don't let it take any. That's the whole trap of what we are. We keep them alive and we keep them small, and there is no version of the job that does one without the other.

So I bought the Legos. The biggest set they had, the one with a little race car on the box, because if she'd been given the run of the shelf that's the one she'd have carried to the register. I sat at my own kitchen table in civilian clothes with the contacts still in and I built the whole thing myself, every bag, followed the little book step by step because I wanted it right, wanted it to be the one she'd have made, and it took me most of a night and my hands are not made for pieces that small. Then I drove out to where they'd put her and I set it on the stone. A finished Lego race car on a child's grave, built by the thing her parents wanted erased from the story. Nobody saw me do it. Nobody was ever going to. That's the part you have to understand about all of this - I keep the promises, I build the sets, I carry the names, and it is done for no one, witnessed by no one, credited to no one. I am the only one who will ever know that Ellie got her Legos.

Her parents wanted me out of the story. They said so, to the Agency, in writing - that the operator's involvement was not to be part of any account given to the family's community. I understand it. I have never held it against them. They needed the morning to have been a monster

and a daycare and their daughter, and a second monster carrying her across the parking lot is one too many for a person to hold.

So there's no version of that day anywhere that has the name in it. Except this one. Her mother doesn't know I know it.

Chapter 5 - Glad to See You

A shifter had been wearing people in a suburb - one of the ones that takes a face and the memories that come with the face, so by the time you find it, it's been three neighbors and a mailman and it knows everyone's kids' names. Nasty work, the kind where the town's real horror isn't the thing, it's that they can no longer trust a single face on the street. I cleared it. Ugly, but I cleared it, and the last body it had been wearing came apart when it died the way they do, so there was a thing on the lawn that had been a man that morning and was now mostly not shaped like one, and a street full of people who'd watched their neighbor's face slough off a thing I'd shot.

There was a woman on that street, older, who had gone somewhere behind her eyes - shock, the flat kind, the kind that doesn't come back on its own. She was standing in the open with the sprinklers still going, soaked, not feeling it. You don't grab a person like that; grabbing tips them the wrong way. You warm them out. So I went to her slow and I put everything I had into my face, the whole glad-to-see-you, *there you are, I've got you, we're okay now*, and I kept my voice like something you'd use on a spooked horse, and I reached out easy.

And she looked up into the open, warm, glad face of the six-and-a-half-foot thing that had just torn her neighbor into wet pieces on the grass, and what my warmth did to her was confirm it. Because here is what warmth is, if you're built like me: it's a predator that isn't hungry right now. That's all a frightened primate can read on a face like mine when the ground is covered in what I'm capable of. The soft voice didn't say *safe* to her. It said *this one plays with its food*. She started screaming in a way she hadn't managed for the actual monster, screaming and scrambling backward through the sprinklers and she went down on the wet concrete of her own driveway and cracked her head doing it, trying to get away from the warmest thing I know how to be.

They trusted the other operator that came in behind me. He was human-shaped and armed and he never softened his face once, all business, barking orders, and they *loved* him for it, they did everything he said, because a hard human face in a crisis reads as competence and a soft inhuman one reads as appetite. I stood at the edge of that and did the math I'm giving you now: the warmth works. It works on everyone. It just doesn't work coming from me, not when they can see what I am, and there is no version of my face soft enough to outrun what they know my hands do.

For a long time I thought it was the teeth. It isn't the teeth.

A hard human face in a crisis reads as competence. He's angry, angry means in control, somebody has this. A soft face on a thing that just took a man apart on a lawn doesn't read as reassurance - it reads as *this one is choosing not to, right now*. Gentleness from something they've watched kill

isn't the absence of the threat. It's the threat demonstrating that the restraint is a decision, and a decision can be revised. She wasn't stupid to scream. She was doing arithmetic and she got the answer her body had.

Her name was in the report because I put it there. She went to the hospital on the same run as two people I'd pulled out of the house on Aldercrest. The other operator rode with them. They asked for him by name at the door.

I still do it. Every time. I go in with my face open and I get the same result and I have never once altered the approach, which I notice is not the behavior of somebody who's learned anything.

Chapter 6 - I Know Your Names

Nine days in Saltmarrow, which is long for me. You don't interrogate a frightened town. You ask them about themselves and they hand you everything. I asked the harbormaster, Toll, about his rope-burned hands and let him talk for an hour. I learned the widow Serafine's drowned boy was named Eddan. I learned the innkeeper's wife was pregnant and hiding it from a husband who drank. I keep things - the lab tested my memory the way you test a rope, with load, until they knew what it held, and now it holds whether I want it to or not.

It worked. It always works. They gave me the docks and the tide tables and the honest count of the missing, and I took the eel-thing they called the Drownfather in the shallows and held its jaw open until the charge in its throat went.

They didn't turn on me. Saltmarrow was grateful, they waved me off the dock, and this is not that kind of story. It's smaller and it's worse.

You cannot learn a person for the length of a mission and then set them down. I have tried. The interest is a tool when you pick it up and it is not a tool you get to put back, because to learn someone is to decide they matter, and that decision doesn't have an off. I meant to learn Toll's hands the way you learn a lock - functionally, to get the door open. But you can't spend an hour inside a man's forty years and come out with only the parts you needed. I came out with Toll. I came out with Eddan, a boy I never met, drowned before I got there, whose name I will have until I die because I learned it to comfort his mother for one afternoon and there is no procedure for giving a name back. I have a dead child in my head that I picked up as a lever and cannot put down.

Every town, nine days, a lock's worth of people learned and not one of them returnable. I am carrying hundreds. The baker's girl afraid of the church. The innkeeper's wife's secret, which was never mine and is mine forever now. A man in a valley three years ago who fed stray cats and is certainly dead and lives in me because I asked him one kind question to get a map. I did not keep these people because I loved them. I kept them because the job made me learn them and learning is a door that only opens.

Saltmarrow was grateful. I want that on the record, because this isn't a chapter about people turning on me. They waved me off the dock. Toll shook my hand with those ruined fingers and meant it.

And I went back four years later on another contract, and I asked him how the hands were in the cold, and I watched him not remember telling me. Worse than not remember - I watched him work out that I must have read it somewhere. A file. Something the Agency keeps. He got polite very fast. Because a man tells a stranger about his hands and it's an hour of his life, and finding

out the stranger *kept* it, exactly, four years, is not warm. It's surveillance wearing a friendly face, and he wasn't wrong, that's the thing, that is precisely what it was when I picked it up. I learned his hands the way you learn a lock.

Nobody wants to be in a wolf's head. Serafine would be sick to know I still have Eddan. She gave him to me on a bench for one afternoon because she needed to say his name to something that would sit still for it, and she went home and got on with a life that has room in it for other things, and I drove out with her son and he is still in here and he was six.

There's nobody to be angry at for it. It works perfectly. It saves the town every time. And every time it works it puts another handful of people into a house that only I live in, room after room of the saved and the incidental and the already-dead, all of them learned on purpose, none of them coming to visit.

Eddan. Six years old, drowned in Saltmarrow before I ever got there. I never saw his face. I'll have him until I die.

Nobody did that to me. I reached for a lever and the lever was a person.

Chapter 7 - Talk Yourself Calm

Cinderslope was a mining strip on a dead mountain, and the thing coming down the shafts folded its jaw outward like a hand opening and took nine men off the lower galleries before we got the call. I went down to seal the last one and found a survivor at the bottom, a shift foreman named Harl, wedged in a supply nook behind the blasting mats, and my lamp found the rest of the gallery in the same sweep that found him.

It hadn't finished. It had been interrupted mine after mine, so the gallery was a half-eaten meal held in the cold - a man still in his harness with everything below the ribs drawn out down the incline in a long wet rope, another folded backward over an ore cart the wrong way, a third who'd crawled a distance on what still worked and wrote the distance on the floor behind him. Harl had been down there with that for eleven hours. Lamp for the first three, then the dark, then just the sounds, because a mountain won't let a body cool quietly.

He was past screaming, into the flat low shaking. You can't pull a man out of that - pull and they lock. So I sat down in the muck at his level and put the rifle on the ground where he could watch me do it, and shut up, and let the silence get heavy enough that he filled it.

He filled it. A person doesn't talk himself calm by reciting facts; he calms by confessing, by finding the one thing he can't hold alone and handing it to another mind so he isn't the only one carrying it. The steadying and the unburdening are the same motion. There's no version of the first without the second.

So what came out of Harl was the heaviest thing, because the heaviest thing is what has to come out for a heart rate to drop. When the jaw opened the first time he had put his hand flat on the back of a young miner named Ost and shoved, and bought the nook with him. He watched Ost go into the opening hand of that mouth. He told me because he had to tell someone or stay a held breath forever, and I was the someone, and it worked. Hundred-ten, ninety, seventy. He walked out of that mountain on his own feet.

I did that. The listening did that. It was kind and it was competent and it saved him.

And it damned me, and it was never going to go any other way.

Harl walked out of that mountain with the hand-on-Ost's-back outside of himself now. That's what the calming is. But a man can't go home and build a life on top of a murder that's sitting fully known in the head of something the county already calls a monster.

He didn't calm down and then decide to betray me. Follow the order of it, because the order is the whole thing. The confession came out of him and went into me and his pulse dropped, and that same night he had a new unbearable thing, which was that his guilt was now in a witness. One way

to survive that. Make the witness unbelievable.

At the inquest he described the thing in the dark. He built me out of the same pictures he'd handed me in the nook - the wet rope down the incline, the man folded over the cart - arranged so the jury couldn't tell what ate the gallery from what sat in it with him. Not malice. The identical instinct that brought his heart rate down: take the unbearable thing out of yourself and put it into a shape the world throws away. He'd already done it once that week and it had worked.

I was the second place he put it.

The kindness built the knife and then required its use. Every good thing I did in that nook was load-bearing for what he did on that stand.

There's no clean version of that night. If I'd stayed quiet and let him lock up he'd have died down there and taken Ost with him, and eleven hours of a man screaming in the dark would have been all the account Ost ever got. I chose to save Harl. Saving him meant receiving it. Receiving it meant I had to be made unbelievable, because a confessor with my face cannot be left standing anywhere near a man's new life.

He was not ungrateful. I want to be exact about this, because ungrateful is the easy word and it's wrong. He was grateful the whole time he was doing it. Both of those were running in him at once on that stand and I don't think he could have told you which was which.

Ost is in me now too. Harl handed him over and went home.

Chapter 8 - Made to Matter

There was a man in Ostwick named Ezren who swept the floor of the meeting hall. That was all anyone let him do. He was slow in the way that made people impatient - words came to him late, and his hands shook, and the town had decided a long time ago that he was furniture. When we rolled in on the Ostwick contract they didn't even mention him in the briefing. He was standing in the corner with his broom while the councilmen talked over each other about the thing in the mine.

The thing was a burrower. A blind, wet, segmented cryptid the length of a bus that had come up under the eastern grazing land and was pulling livestock and, by then, three people down into the dark. It hunted by vibration. Sound and footfall. You did not want to be the loudest thing standing on that ground.

I needed the mine layout and none of the councilmen had been down it in twenty years. Ezren had. He'd swept it, back when it still ran. He knew every drift and every collapsed shaft and where the old vent adits let out. Nobody asked him. So I asked him.

I crouched to his eye line - you learn to do that, to stop being six-foot-four at a person you need - and I told him I couldn't do this without him. I meant it as fact, not flattery. He was the only living map. I told him the whole town's safety was going to run through what he remembered, and that made him the most important man in Ostwick that night. I watched it land. I watched twenty years of being furniture come off him like a coat.

He was extraordinary. His words came clean when they mattered. He drew the mine in the dirt from memory, every branch, and he marked the one adit where the burrower's tunnel intersected the old works, and he was right about all of it. We staged the kill there. Drew the thing with a rigged thumper hammering the deck plate, let it come at the noise, and put four charges into the soft segment behind its head when it breached. It died screaming a sound no throat should make and the ground stopped moving under Ostwick for the first time in a week.

They cheered Ezren. For one night the town that had made him furniture carried him on their shoulders. I thought - and this is the part I am setting down for you, so read it slow - I thought I had done a good thing. I thought I had put worth into a man who'd had it starved out of him and that worth would stay good because he had suffered enough to know what it was for. That is the mistake. That is the whole mistake.

I came back through Ostwick eleven months later on another job. Ezren was on the council now. They'd given him a title and a room and a say. And there was a new man in the corner with the broom - a drifter, simple, slower even than Ezren had been - and Ezren had found him, and Ezren was standing over him.

He'd worked out that the drifter would do anything to be allowed to stay. So he made him do things. He made him kneel in front of the council for their laughter. He made him eat off the floor he swept, and when the man was slow to, Ezren put a boot on the back of his neck and held it there and told the room this was how you taught the worthless their place. He'd learned the exact shape of what it was to be made small, and instead of being the one man alive who'd never do it to another, he'd become the best there was at it. He knew precisely where it hurt because he'd been hurt there. The dignity I gave him he'd spent buying himself someone to stand on.

I broke it up. I put Ezren against the wall by his collar and I let him see the ears and the teeth, let him remember what I am, and for a second he was furniture again. Then I let go, because that's not the job, and the job doesn't have a line item for a man's soul.

I had it backwards, and it cost me a year of thinking I understood people.

I assumed a man who'd been ground down would be gentle with the next one down. He *knows*. He's got the map of it, he knows exactly where it hurts. And that's true - Ezren did know exactly where it hurt, and that turned out to be the problem, because knowing where it hurts is not a reason to avoid the spot. It's an instruction.

Twenty years of being furniture didn't teach Ezren that humiliation is wrong. It taught him that there are two positions in a room and he'd been in the wrong one. That was the entire content of the lesson. When I crouched to his eye line and told him the town's safety ran through what he remembered, I didn't hand him dignity - I have never once managed to hand anybody dignity, it doesn't move between people. I moved him to the other position. And a man who has spent twenty years underneath does not experience the top as *relief*, he experiences it as *unsteady*, because he has seen from underneath exactly how fast you can be put back. So he nailed it down. He found the slowest man in Ostwick and put a boot on his neck in front of the council, and every time that drifter ate off the floor, Ezren was a little more certain the floor was somewhere he no longer lived.

He was not being cruel for its own sake. He was making himself safe. That's the part I can't get around, because it means he'll never stop, because it never works - you can't get certain that way, you can only get another night of it.

I gave him a floor and he needed somebody under it to be sure it was there.

The drifter had no name in the file. I asked. Nobody in Ostwick had thought to get one, including Ezren, who had been furniture with a name for twenty years and did not think to ask the next one what his was.

Chapter 9 - The Buoys

Gullcliff is a fishing shelf on the northern coast, forty minutes up a switchback road that a truck can take at nine miles an hour and nothing faster. By the time I got to the square there were maybe forty of them standing between the cannery lights and the seawall, and they had the drake cornered.

Juvenile. Wing-lame. Off a containment barge two counties east that had lost it eleven days earlier and filed the loss as equipment. Somebody had put a harpoon under its jaw and left it there, and it was making the noise they make at the end.

They didn't need me. That was the situation. They had it pinned and they had gaff hooks and filleting knives and a man at the front with a nail gun, and they had decided they were going to do it themselves and take their time.

Three days before, it had taken a boy off the pier.

Here is what I did, and I want it in order, because the order is the whole thing.

I looked first. That took about four minutes and it is the only part of this I'd do the same way again. Four minutes standing at the mouth of the square with my hands where they could see them, listening to what they said to each other, because a crowd tells you everything in the first four minutes if you let it. What I got was this: nobody had organized them. They had not posted a watch, they had not moved the children off the shelf, they had not called it in. They found the drake on their own, they cornered it on their own, and they had done a genuinely competent job of it - the seawall at its back, three lines of approach, the lame wing to the open side. That's a good box. Nobody taught them that. They know how to corner a thing that swims because they corner things that swim for a living.

I said so. Before anything else, and I meant it. I told them the box was correct and that a trained team would have set it the same way and that it was the reason nobody in the square was dead. It landed the way a true thing does when the person hearing it wasn't expecting one. Two of them stood up straighter. The man with the nail gun looked at me for the first time.

Then I took the drake off them, and I did it by agreeing with them out loud - that it deserved worse, that I could make it last longer than they could, that I knew where the pain sits in a thing like this. All of which bought me the kill, and none of which was true, and I put a bolt through its skull the second they gave me the space. It stopped rasping. Forty people let out the same breath at once.

No knives went into anything with a heartbeat. That was the objective and I met it.

And then I asked about the boy.

I asked because it was in the report I had to file and because the barge was going to want to know whether the drake had been hunting the shelf or scavenging it, and those are different animals with different containment tiers, and the answer was in where he'd been standing when it took him.

He'd been past the buoys.

I want you to understand what the buoys are at Gullcliff. They are not decoration. There is a line of them across the mouth of the inlet where the shelf drops and the current turns, and every child on that coast learns before they can read that you do not fish past the buoys. Two of the men in the square told me that within a minute of each other, in the same words, like a thing recited. His mother knew he went out there. She had known for a year. She let him, because he was thirteen and it was where the fish were, and she had decided that a rule everyone breaks is not a rule.

So I said it. In the square, in front of them, with the drake still cooling twenty feet away and his mother eight feet from me.

I said the drake was scavenging, not hunting, and it had been in the inlet eleven days without touching anyone inside the line. I said that the line existed for exactly this and that it had worked for everyone who stayed behind it. I said that a rule nobody enforces is a rule you have decided not to have, and that they had decided, collectively, over about a year, not to have this one, and that this is what it cost.

I was right. Every part of it is in the file and every part of it is correct and the barge tiered the animal off my read.

His mother was standing right there.

I have gone over this more times than is useful. Not whether I was right - I was right, that's not the open question. The open question is what I thought was going to happen. I think I believed that if somebody finally said the thing plainly, the buoys would mean something again, and the next thirteen-year-old on that shelf would stay inside the line, and that would be worth one bad night for one woman.

That's not what a square full of people three days into grief is for. I know that now in the way you know a thing you can't use.

What I actually did was hand them a sentence.

I got the call from Vanity two weeks later, because the county had flagged it and she pulls anything with the callsign on it. Gullcliff had come apart. The nail-gun man's cousin had repeated it in the tavern - *past the buoys, and she knew* - except by then it wasn't a finding out of a federal report, it

was a thing to say about a woman. There was no drake left in the square to be angry at. So they used what I gave them. Her boat was cut loose in the night and lost on the rocks. The cousin was beaten in the cannery lot and lost the eye. By the time the county came up the switchback there were two factions, a fire in the net shed, and a man in the water they didn't get to in time.

Vanity read it flat and did not editorialize. I asked her to read the part about the boat twice.

A square three days into grief is not a room for findings. What I put into it was true and what came out of it two weeks later was a woman's boat on the rocks, and those are the same sentence; it just passed through forty people on the way.

And they didn't use it on themselves. That's the part I'd underline if I underlined things. Not one of them turned it inward, not the men who recited the buoy rule at me like scripture and had watched that boy go out past it for a year without once walking down to the pier. It went straight to the mother. It always goes to whoever is already closest to the floor, because a sentence like that has to land somewhere, and grief picks the target that can't hit back.

I'd have filed the same read. It was true and the barge needed it.

I'd have filed it. Not said it. Not there.

Chapter 10 - Keep Your Face

The town was called Mill Junction, and the thing in the culvert under the highway had already taken four before we got the call. A silt-crawler. Blind, boneless where it needed to be, a wet grey mass that folded itself flat to slide through drain pipe and came up through storm grates in the night. It took people by the ankle and pulled them down into standing water and drowned them slow, the way an otter drowns a dog, patient, holding. It liked the flooded low ground on the east side. Ninety people had crowded into the Baptist church on the hill because the hill was dry.

Running the church was a man named Pruitt. Deacon, insurance broker, the kind of soft-handed authority a town reaches for when the elected men have already run. He had a plan. He had everyone bailing the church basement with buckets and stacking hymnals against the doors, because he had decided the thing came for dry ground and wanted inside. He was wrong in every particular. The crawler could not climb the hill. It needed water to move and there was none between the culvert and the church but the low road, and the low road was exactly where he was about to march sixty people down at dawn to reach the evacuation trucks.

Frightened, loud, certain, holding the room together with a story that would get the room killed. There's one in every town.

I did not tell him he was wrong. I wanted to - everything in me wanted to put it flat on the table, *your plan drowns forty people, sit down*. The correction comes out of me like a reflex and it lands like a slap, and a slapped man in front of his flock will double down to keep his footing. I've done it that way. I have watched a man choose the wrong door out of pure spite because I made him small in front of people who needed him big.

So I let him keep his face. I told the room the Deacon was right that the water was the enemy - true enough - and that his instinct to hold the high ground was exactly correct, and that the smartest thing a leader could do was hold here one more hour while I confirmed the low road. I handed him the credit for the caution and I let him nod like he'd thought of it. He stood taller. The buckets slowed. The children stopped crying because the adults stopped vibrating. I bought the hour on his authority, not mine, because they trusted his face and flinched from mine.

I used the hour. I went down to the culvert alone and I found the crawler where it had gorged itself stupid, folded into a drain the width of my forearm, its grey bulk pulsing. I do the work close. I got a hand into the pipe and found the ring of muscle it breathes through and I opened it with my knife, sawing, and it came apart in the water in loose grey sheets that clung to my arms like wet paper, and the standing water went black and then went clear. It made a sound like a drain unclogging. Then it was meat. The low road was safe. Nobody had to walk anywhere. I came back up the hill wearing it.

Panic averted. People followed. Forty people who would have drowned at dawn instead loaded onto trucks at noon, dry, alive, complaining about the wait.

By the time the trucks rolled, the story had already set. Pruitt stood at the church doors and told the arriving relief officers how he had held the high ground against my recklessness. How the monster - and he meant me, not the thing in the pipe - had wanted to march everyone down the low road into the water, and how his steady leadership had kept them up on the hill until the threat was cleared. He had taken the hour I bought him and rewritten himself as the man who bought it. Every calming word I'd handed him, he'd swallowed and burped back up as his own. And the caution I invented to save his face was now the plan I had tried to override.

They looked at him, clean and dry and human. They looked at me, forearms grey to the elbow with the thing I'd gutted so they could keep breathing. And they believed him. Of course they believed him. He had a face they wanted to be true.

I did not correct him. There was no point. You cannot claw back a story once you've handed a frightened man the pen, and I had handed it to him myself, deliberately, to save the room. That was the price and I paid it knowing.

Here's what I've worked out about the hour afterward. When the fear drains out, people don't go back to who they were. They have to account for two days of what they did while frightened - the bailing, the hymnals against the door, sixty adults doing nothing useful in a church while somebody else went down into the pipe. Nobody can hold that and be a person at the same time. So the story gets written, fast, before anyone's dry, and in every version of it the people telling it held the line.

Which means the danger has to have been somewhere else. It can't have been in the culvert, because the thing in the culvert was killed by somebody, and admitting who does the whole account no good. So the danger has to have been a decision, and the decision has to have been somebody's, and I am standing right there being the wrong shape with grey up to my elbows.

Pruitt didn't invent a lie about me. He needed a version of that hour where he was the one who bought it, and my face was the only surface in the room that story fits on.

They got on the trucks at noon, dry, alive, complaining about the wait. Forty of them who'd have been in the low road at dawn.

That's the whole return and I'd take it again, which is either the correct answer or a thing I've told myself enough times that it comes up automatically now. I've stopped being able to tell those apart.

Chapter 11 - My Fault First

Coldwater was a strip of fishing shacks on a dead river, and the thing living under the ice house had taken six people before we got the call. A brood-thing. Chimeran, but old, feral, no design left in it - just appetite and a nest of tunnels it had chewed under the freezer floor. We pulled four of the missing out of that nest. Two we pulled out in pieces. The fifth was a boy, maybe nine, still breathing when I found him, and I got him halfway up the tunnel before the floor above us came down and pinned my leg and I had to choose between digging my own leg free and holding onto his wrist.

I let go of the wrist. I want you to understand I made that choice with a clear head. The ceiling was coming and one of us was walking out and I ran the arithmetic and I let go. He went back down into the dark still saying a word that might have been a name. I killed the brood-thing forty minutes later. I did not get the boy back.

When you come up out of a hole with somebody's child still in it, the town does not want a report. They want a throat.

So I gave them mine. I stood in front of them in the mud outside the ice house before anyone else could speak and I said it: I had him, I had his hand in mine, and I let go to save myself, and there is nobody to blame for that but me. Plain. No ceiling, no arithmetic, no seconds. I built the worst version of myself out loud, the one they were going to assemble anyway, and I handed it over finished.

It defused them. I have watched a mob's whole weight go out of the air because I got to the accusation first. A father came at me with a gaff hook and stopped with the point at my sternum because there was nothing left for him to say. I'd said it. They don't know what to do with a weapon that's already been fired. Some of them soften. One woman touched my arm.

Because I filed it the same way. I sat across from Vanity in the debrief and she had her recorder and I gave her the true account. I told her I let go of the wrist to free my leg. I told her a faster Operator, a less heavy one, might have dug out and kept the grip both. I owned it. I put my own fault down first, in my own words, because that is the honest thing and because I did not want it to reach her twisted by someone else's mouth.

They read that line back at the review. Only that line.

Not the four I pulled out alive. Not the brood-thing's skull I put my fist through. Not the tunnel geometry or the collapse or the forty minutes. They took the one sentence I had volunteered - *I let go of the wrist* - and they made it the entire shape of me. The board didn't have to prove I'd failed

the boy. I'd proved it for them, signed, on record, in my voice. My confession did the prosecution's whole job. They just had to read it out and let it sit.

Honesty is not a currency. It's ammunition, and the only thing anybody does with ammunition is load it.

The difference between the father and the board is that the father was going to have to keep living in Coldwater with whatever he did to me, and the board was not. That's it. That's the whole mechanism. A man with a gaff hook at my sternum is standing inside the consequence - he can see the four I pulled out alive standing behind him, he has to eat in the same room as them next week. Confession works on him because he's a person in a place.

Nobody at that review was in a place. They had a transcript and a mandate and a question in front of them - is this asset a liability - and my sentence was the only piece of evidence in the folder that spoke to it. Not because they were cruel. Because it was *usable* and nothing else in there was. Four people alive is not a finding. A fist through a skull is not a finding. *I let go of the wrist* is a finding, and it was already in my voice, so nobody had to be the one who said it about me.

I made it free. That's what I did wrong. Everything that costs a person something to say about you gets weighed - they have to want it enough to spend their name on it. I spent mine for them.

Admitting fault is letting go of the wheel and trusting the truth to land where you aimed it, and I have never once let go of anything and had it land where I aimed. Every wound I carry landed in the half second I'd lost the grip. The lab. The buyers. The table with the straps. I knew that about myself and I opened my mouth anyway, in a room with a recorder, because I thought honest was a thing you could be at people.

The father with the gaff hook still lives in Coldwater. He has to eat in the same room as the four I brought up. That's the only reason my confession worked on him and not on them - he was standing inside the consequence and they were reading a transcript.

The boy said a word going down that might have been a name. I put that in the file too, the first time. It's not in anything I've filed since.

Chapter 12 - From Where You Stand

The town was called Fenwick, a fishing settlement folded into a cold inlet where the fog never fully lifted. Something had been taking people off the docks at night. By the time HQ routed me in, they'd lost nine, and the ones who found the bodies wished they hadn't. I found the tenth myself, at low tide, tangled in the pilings under the pier - what was left of a man peeled open from sternum to hip, the ribs bent outward like a chest of drawers left hanging, everything inside taken and the cavity packed with wet sand and kelp the way a fisherman packs a cooler. The thing was a marrow-drinker. A Chimeran. It ate the soft insides and used the shells to line its nest so the next meal would smell like home when it dragged them under.

The monster was the simple part of Fenwick.

There was a woman keeping watch over the survivors in the chapel - Merrin, a net-mender, hands scarred to leather. When I came through the door she put her body between me and the children behind her and did not move. I was in full kit, six foot four, hood down, ears back, the muzzle-line of my face catching the lamplight wrong. She looked at me the way you look at the thing that already killed nine.

Nine of her neighbors gone. A predator that wears the smell of the dead to get close enough. And then the door opens and in comes another predator - bigger, quieter, wolf's face, rifle, sent by an organization she has never heard of and claiming to help.

I was not the rescue. From where she was standing I was the second one, and every instinct telling her that was the same machine that had kept her and those children alive through nine deaths, working correctly, pointed at me.

So I did not make her wrong for it. I went down. Six-four folds small if you let it - I sat on the floor by the door, put the rifle flat where she could see both my hands, and let her keep the children behind her. I let her fear be the true thing in the room and I moved around it slow, the way you move around a hurt animal, not because it's beneath you but because from where it lies, you are the danger. It worked. It always works. Within the hour she was telling me which dock, which tide, which of the missing had gone quiet before they vanished. She stopped shaking. She started helping. Because I had understood her, and understanding is the only currency that spends when a person is that afraid.

I found the nest by dawn. I killed it in the water where it was strong and it still lost, because I do not lose, and I carried the shell-lined thing out into the light so Fenwick could see the shape of what had been eating them. Merrin came to the shore. She looked at the dead marrow-drinker. Then she looked at me, and I watched her do the arithmetic every one of them does, and I watched

her decide I was only the smaller monster after all. She didn't thank me. She gathered her children and put her body between them and me one more time, and walked back up the shingle, and that was that.

I understood Merrin completely, and she walked up the shingle without a word, and I have spent a while working out why that's not the injustice it feels like at three in the morning.

Standing where somebody else stands costs nothing when they're frightened and small and you're the one holding the rifle. It's free. I could afford Merrin's whole point of view because taking it didn't ask me to give up anything - I did it from inside full kit with the situation in hand.

For her to stand where I stood, she'd have had to hold two things at the same time: that the thing on the shore with a dead marrow-drinker over its shoulder is a person, and that she had been right to be terrified of it. Nobody does that on the same day. You cannot be that scared of something and also grant it an interior; the fear won't permit it. It would have to stop being fear first, and hers had nine bodies holding it up.

So she gathered her children and did the correct thing with the information she had.

I stood on that shingle a while after she'd gone. Long enough that Vanity asked about the delay. I told her I was confirming the kill.

Chapter 13 - Braver Than You Are

Emberthroat was a mining strip built into the throat of a dead volcano. The thing living in its vent shafts was a burrower - a Chimera the file called a Delving Maw, four meters of segmented muscle with a mouth that opened in four directions like a flower and teeth set in rings all the way down. It came up through the floors. It took a man out of his bed on the third night and left the wife screaming into a hole in her own bedroom, and by the time I arrived the town had done what frightened towns do. They had stopped being a town. They were three hundred people in a cannery, packed shoulder to shoulder, and they had already started sorting themselves into who ate and who watched others eat.

You don't tell frightened people to behave. You tell them they already are, and you give them a name too big for them, and you make them ashamed to be smaller than it. I stood on a crate in that cannery and I looked at three hundred faces that had decided they were animals, and I told them they were the bravest town on the ridge. I told them I had seen barricades break and I had never seen a barricade like theirs. I told them the man the Maw took had held the line so the rest could run, and that his neighbors would not dishonor that by clawing each other over water rations. None of it was true. He had died in his sleep. There was no line. I authored it standing on that crate, out loud, in front of all of them, and I watched it take.

And it took. A woman gave her ration to a child that was not hers. Two men who had been at each other's throats an hour before carried the wounded together, gently, competing now to be seen being gentle. An old miner stood at the shaft mouth with a pry bar he could barely lift and told me he would hold it so the doctor could work. They rose. I called them brave and they climbed up into the word to meet me, and for six hours Emberthroat was the town I had invented for it. I have made buildings burn and I have never made anything as fast or as clean as I made those people good with a lie.

I killed the Maw at dawn. Drew it up the main vent with a heat lure and put forty rounds down its ringed throat as the mouth bloomed open for me, and it came apart in wet segments across the cannery floor, each ring still chewing at the air on its own for a minute after, teeth grinding on nothing. It reeked. The old miner cheered with his pry bar over his head. The woman with the borrowed child wept. I stood in the gore of the thing I had killed and I let myself, for one hour, believe the crowd was what I had called it.

Then the relief convoy was two days out and the radio went quiet and the eyes came off them.

Here is what happened when nobody was watching. The gentle men went into the dead man's house in the dark and stripped it, and when the widow tried to stop them one of them broke her jaw with the flat of a shovel and left her in the same room with the same hole in the floor. The

woman who gave away her ration took it back that night and three more with it, from a family too sick to hold them, and the child she had fed watched her do it. The old miner with the pry bar - the one I would have died beside - I found him behind the cannery holding it over a girl who had said no to him, and he was not brave anymore because there was no one left to see him be it, and bravery had only ever been the thing he wore in front of me.

I broke his arm at the elbow and took the bar.

He looked up at me like I'd betrayed him. Like I had changed the rules on him partway through. And from inside his skull I had, and that's the part I want you to sit with rather than the arm.

He wasn't lying on the crate. That's what I got wrong for about a year afterward - I thought I'd been fooled by three hundred people performing. Nobody was performing. He meant it at the shaft mouth with the pry bar he could barely hold, meant it all the way down, and six hours later he meant the other thing just as much. Both were real. The bravery wasn't a mask over the man behind the cannery; there is no man behind, there's just whatever the room is asking for, and I had made the room ask for heroes and then I'd gone and killed the thing that was holding the room together.

I built him out loud on a crate because I needed him for an hour. I never once asked whether there was anything underneath to keep the shape after I stopped looking. There wasn't. There isn't, in most of them, and I don't think that makes them liars. It makes them weather.

Vanity logged it as a clean extraction. Monster killed, town saved, casualties acceptable. I did not correct her.

The girl behind the cannery was seventeen. She thanked me. Then she asked me not to put it in the report, because the relief convoy was two days out and she had to live in Emberthroat afterward and he had a family in it.

I put it in the report. She was right about what it cost her and I did it anyway, and I have never been able to decide whether that was integrity or just me taking one thing in that town I could still control.

Chapter 14 - Quietly

His name was Petrun. Nineteen, maybe. Local, one of six volunteers the town of Threshfield threw at me when I came for the thing living under their grain silos - a burrower, Vanity's file called it a marrow-hound, though the word does no work explaining it. Long as a truck. No eyes worth the name. It hunted by the drum of feet on soil and it had already taken four field hands, pulled straight down through the dirt so fast the men beside them said the ground just swallowed a person mid-sentence.

Fast, brave, useless. The kind who thinks courage is a substitute for doing what he's told. You get one in every town that sends volunteers. On the first sweep he broke my line. I had them spaced, silent, moving heel-to-toe the way you move when the thing under you listens for weight. Petrun ran ahead. Wanted the first sight of it. Wanted to be the one. He stamped forty meters of open field like he was putting out a grass fire, and the marrow-hound came up under a man named Coll who had done everything right.

It came up as a wet unfolding. The soil heaved and split and the hound's mouth was already open when it cleared, a ring of hooked plates rotating the wrong way, and it took Coll from the hips down in the first bite. He stayed talking. That is the part they never believe when I write it plain, so I will write it plain: the lower half of him was gone into that grinding ring and he was still upright from the waist, hands out, asking us what happened, asking it in a normal voice, until the blood pressure dropped out of him and he folded sideways into the hole his own legs had gone down. The hound pulled the rest after. The field closed over it like water.

Petrun stood there with Coll's death on his boots and I watched the recruit's instinct arrive too late in his eyes.

When a man has done something reckless that got somebody killed, you don't correct him in front of the others. You don't make the group watch you break him. You take him aside, and before you cut, you find the true thing you can praise, because there is always one, and you lead with it. That's the method and it is a good method.

I walked Petrun behind the silo where no one could hear. I told him his speed was real and rare, that I had seen trained men slower, that on the right day that speed saves a line instead of ending one. All true. Then I told him, low, that the ground listens, that his feet had spoken for all of us, that Coll died of Petrun's courage and not his cowardice - and that this was fixable. That I needed him behind me on the next sweep, heel-to-toe, and that if he gave me that I would not say a word to the others about what happened in the field.

He took it. That is the thing. He did not get loud, did not get proud, did not have to save face because I had left him his face. He nodded and his throat worked and he said yes, Operator. The next sweep he moved like a man walking on his own held breath. We put the hound down that night - I opened the ground with charges and took its head with the line spacing Petrun kept perfectly, no one in front of me, no one behind me leaving. Six volunteers went home. Threshfield kept its silos.

I did it right. I did it so right that not one person besides Petrun and me knew there had ever been a correction at all.

That's worth holding next to the rest of it.

Two weeks later Vanity pulled the local accounts for the debrief, the way she does, and read one back to me flat because she knew I would want it flat. Petrun had talked. Not about his running. Not about Coll. In his telling the monster had cornered him alone behind the silo, in the dark, out of everyone's sight, and put its voice down low against his ear and told him what it would do to him if he stepped wrong again. He showed people how close I had stood. He was believed instantly, because of course he was. A six-foot-four thing with a wolf's jaw takes a boy behind a building and speaks low - there is exactly one story the human mind wants to make out of that, and it is never the true one.

The privacy was the mercy. It's also the only thing his version needed, and those are not two facts. They're one fact.

There's no third door. I've looked. Correct him in front of the others and you humiliate him and he hates you and the hate has forty witnesses. Correct him alone and you spare him and you have just built an unwitnessed room, and an unwitnessed room will hold any story a frightened nineteen-year-old needs to put in it. What he needed was for Coll's death to have come from somewhere other than his own feet, and there I was, the correct shape, standing close enough to have whispered.

I don't think he set out to lie. I think he walked out from behind that silo with something he could not carry and found, over about a week, that the story got easier every time he told it, and the easier version had the monster in it. He probably believes it now. It would be strange if he didn't.

Six volunteers went home. Threshfield kept its silos. Coll's widow got a pension off the report I filed, which named the marrow-hound and the ground conditions and did not name Petrun, because I'd given him my word behind that silo and I keep those.

So there's a boy in that town who tells a story about the night a wolf got him alone in the dark, and the only part of it that's true is that I told him his speed was real and that I meant it.

Chapter 15 - He Held the Line

The town was called Deepgallery, a mining settlement at the bottom of a valley that funneled cold air down like water. Something had come up out of the old shafts. We called it a delver in the debrief because it had no proper name yet - a blind, boneless thing the length of a train car, skin like wet paper stretched over cartilage, and a mouth that ran a third of its body. It fed on heat. It found you by the warmth coming off your skin and it opened you up to get to the warmer parts inside.

I had a support element assigned that night. Local militia, twelve men, folded under my command for the duration. Their sergeant was named Halloran. Broad, loud, the kind of man who fills a room with his voice so no one notices he is standing at the back of it.

When the delver came through the eastern barricade, Halloran ran.

I saw it. Clearly, from thirty feet, with the lamps still up - I say that because a lot of this job is deciding later what you actually saw, and this is one of the few I've never had to argue with myself about. He dropped his weapon and he ran, and two of his men who were watching him for their cue almost ran with him. I put myself between them and the dark. The delver took a miner named Oster who had not run - lifted him, folded him, and I heard the sound a rib cage makes when it is turned inside out, a wet unbuttoning, and then Oster stopped making any sound at all while the thing was still eating the warm parts of him. I put four incendiary rounds into the soft length of it and it came apart in the cold and burned.

We held. Barely. We held because the two men who almost ran did not run, and they did not run because I was in front of them.

Afterward Halloran came back. He had a story ready by then. He said he had circled to flank it, that he had been the one to draw it off the western wall so I could get my shot. His men looked at me. They knew. He knew I knew.

I let him have it.

I let a frightened man keep the version where he held the line, and I'd defend the reasoning to anyone. A unit that watches its sergeant get shamed in the cold stops being a unit. Halloran's men needed him to be the man he was pretending to be, and I could give them that for free. I said, in the debrief, in front of them, that Sergeant Halloran's flank maneuver had bought me the shot. Vanity recorded it exactly as I said it. His shoulders came down from around his ears. His men stood a little straighter. Morale is not a soft thing. Morale is the difference between the two men who stayed and the corpse of the one who was too slow.

It worked. It always works. What it turns into afterward is the part nobody warns you about.

The report I signed went up the chain. It named Halloran. It used my callsign as the corroborating witness, which meant it carried weight, because whatever else they think of us, they do not think we lie about the field. My mercy had a signature on it and the signature was mine.

They promoted him.

Not once. The story I gave him was good, and a good story climbs. Two years later Sergeant Halloran was Director Halloran, running Containment for the whole northern district, and Containment is the office that decides which Chimerans get a leash and which get a bullet. The office that decides whether a thing like me is an asset or a specimen. I read his name at the top of a directive that reclassified three of my own kind - operators, people who had bled for the same chain of command - as unacceptable retention risks. Two of them I had trained. He signed it with the same hand he used to drop his rifle in the dark at Deepgallery.

I built that man. I took a coward and gave him a spine made out of my own credibility, and he used the reach to sign away three of my own kind.

The face you let a man save doesn't stay a face. It becomes standing, and standing becomes a room and a title, and there is no mechanism anywhere in the chain for the truth to catch up with it, because the only witness who could correct the record is the one who put the lie in it. I can't unsay it. The moment I try, every word I've ever filed goes soft, including the ones that got people tiered and contained correctly, and he knows that, and he has known it since the night I said it.

Here's the part that keeps me up. I know precisely why he did it. A man who ran in the dark and got given a medal for it spends the rest of his life around people who might remember the running. There were twelve of them at Deepgallery, and eleven went home to a mining town, and one of them was a Chimeran with a perfect memory and a callsign on the report. He didn't reclassify my kind because he hates us. He did it because we're the last people alive who know what he is, and he finally got the office where you can do something about that.

I could have let him drown in the cold. One true sentence in the debrief and Halloran ends as a discharged militiaman, harmless, small. I was decent instead. I remembered being sixteen and sold in front of people who could have said something and stayed quiet, and I would not do that to a man, not even that man, not even once.

Mercy doesn't know who deserves it. It goes where you point it and you point it at whoever is bleeding in front of you, and Halloran was bleeding in front of me in a cold valley at four in the morning, and that was all the qualification the thing required.

Two of the three he reclassified I trained myself. One of them is alive. I'm not going to write down where.

I let him keep the line he never held.

He held it against me.

Chapter 16 - A Little Softer

Blackvein was a mining settlement wedged in a dead-end valley, and it hated me before I cleared the tree line. That's normal. A crowd goes quiet when six feet four inches of wolf walks into their square, mothers pull children in behind their hips, and the word monster gets said not loud but loud enough. It passes over like weather.

The thing killing them was a deepvein Chimeran - one of the old mine-adapted ones, blind, long-limbed, jaw split into four hinged plates that it used to strip a body the way you'd strip bark. It had taken nine of them down in the shafts. It came up at night through the vent grates and dragged people out of their beds by the ankle. They'd find the beds empty and a smear leading to a grate too small for a man to fit through and too wide to seal.

So they needed me. Need is the only reason a town ever opens its gate to something like us.

When a hostile room gives you an inch, you name the inch out loud. Not flattery - recognition. People move toward the place they're told they're already moving.

There was a woman there, Edda, who ran the boarding house and had appointed herself the town's spine. First night she wouldn't look at me. Second night she left a bowl of stew on the sill of the room they'd put me in - the tool shed, really, but a roof. I found her the next morning and I said, plainly, "You fed me. Thank you. That was more than the others managed." Small thing. I named it.

She flushed. She said it was just stew. But that afternoon she called me Operator instead of it, and by the third day she was walking the perimeter with me pointing out which grates the men had welded and which they'd been too scared to. Every time she gave me something - a map of the vents, a name, a look that wasn't fear - I named it. Good. That helps. You saw something they missed. She stood a little straighter each time. The whole house took its cue from her. By the fourth night there were three bowls on the sill and a boy who wanted to see my hands, the claws, and I let him, and his mother let him, and she said soft, "He's not scared of you," like it was a gift she was giving me.

It felt like being a person. I'm not going to pretend otherwise. After enough years of weather, a town going a little soft toward you feels like sun, and I wanted it to be about me. That they'd finally seen past the shape of me to the thing that assigns itself to save them.

It had a shelf life. The date was printed on the danger, not on me.

I went into the shafts on the fifth night. I put it down in a flooded gallery a half mile in, the four-plate jaw working on empty air while I held its skull under the black water with my whole weight until the limbs stopped. It took the plate off my forearm doing it - you can see the scar, it runs to

the elbow, it opened when I lost my grip in the wet and it got one hinge into me before I got both hands back on it. Every wound I carry landed the same way. In the half-second I wasn't in control. Remember that. It is the only through-line in my body.

I came up bleeding and carrying its head so they'd believe it. Dawn in the square. Edda was there. The boy was there.

And it was already gone.

Not slowly. There was no window. The head hit the dirt and the danger died with it and I watched the softness drain out of every face in that valley in real time, like water off slate. Edda looked at my open arm, at the black blood, at the thing I was, and her mouth did what mouths do when they remember what you are. The boy's mother pulled him back behind her hip. The word came again from somewhere in the crowd, monster, at full volume now, because they were allowed to again. No bowl on the sill that night. They gave me the head-price in coin left on the shed step so no one had to hand it to me, and a man with a rifle stood at the tree line until I was past it, in case the thing that had saved them decided to stay.

The improvement was real. I did not imagine the warmth. Every inch of softening happened exactly as I named it. But I was praising a change in their character, and there was no change in their character. There was a change in their need. Edda didn't warm toward me. Edda's fear of the thing in the mine got bigger than her fear of me, and I mistook the gap for affection. Gratitude is not a feeling people have. It is a debt they carry only as long as the danger stands over the table pointing at it. Kill the danger and you cancel the debt in the same stroke.

Nothing grew toward me in Blackvein. It was need, leaning my way in the storm, standing back up straight the second the sky cleared.

I thought about it walking out past that rifleman. If I'd left one grate open. If I'd let it keep coming, slow, a body every few weeks - they'd have needed me forever and been kind forever, and Edda would have kept putting the bowl on the sill, and the boy would have kept wanting to see my hands. I could have lived in that valley in the sun of their fear for as long as I wanted.

I got a half mile down the road before I stopped thinking about it.

Chapter 17 - The People You Could Be

Hand a person the better version of themselves and some will reach for it. Most will look at it, and set it down, and pick up the knife instead.

The town was called Tidegate, a river crossing gone to rust, and the thing killing its people came up out of the water at night. A gillheart - long, pale, hooked jaw, eyes gone milk-white from living under the ice. It took four before we got there. It dragged them under and it fed slow. We found the fourth still tangled in the reeds with most of her ribs opened out like a book. That is the plain fact of it. Her name was Ada Voss and she had been a schoolteacher and she was thirty-one and there was not enough of her chest left to close her coat over.

The town had a foreman by then. Man named Coll. He had organized them, and I want you to understand I was glad of it when I walked in, because organization is rare and it is the thing that keeps people alive. He had them rationed and watched and he had a plan for the crossing. He was frightened and mean with it, and he had started deciding which of them were worth the food.

When you want a person to be better than they are, you tell them they already are. Not flattery. You name the finer self out loud, hand it over like it was always theirs, and make them ashamed to be less than the thing you just called them. It works on the worst nights on the worst people. I told Coll he was the reason this town still had a count to take. I told him a lesser man would have already run the ferry and left the slow ones on the bank, and that everyone here could see he was not that man. I said it flat. I said it like it was already true.

And he reached for it. I watched him do it. He straightened. He put the two he had written off back on the ration list. He waded out with me to the reeds and helped me carry Ada Voss up the bank in a tarp when his own people would not touch her, and his hands shook the whole way and he did not stop. That is what the principle buys you. For one night I gave a mean, scared man a better man to be, and he stood in it.

That's real. I want to be careful here, because everything after this is going to sound like I'm saying it wasn't.

Because the gillheart came back the second night, and it came up under the ferry where the children slept warm, and there was a moment - one - where the plan needed a body in the water to hold the winch line while the rest hauled. Cold black water, the milk-eyed thing somewhere in it. I told Coll to hold the line. I told him the man I had met would hold it.

He looked at me. He looked at the water. And he took a girl - a foster girl, no people to raise a noise, twelve maybe, the kind nobody counts - and he put the line in her hands and he pushed her off the boards himself.

I got her out. I got the gillheart too, both barrels through that pale hooked skull, and it thrashed and voided black in the shallows and went still and the town was saved. The girl lived. She has a scar around both wrists now like she wore the rope forever.

And Coll - I did not touch him. I want you to know that. I stood over him dripping and I gave him the last clean chance. I said, *that is not who you are*. One more time. I held out the better man.

He said, *she was nobody. You'd have done the same*.

Hand a person the better version of themselves and some will reach for it. Most set it down and pick up the knife, because the knife asks nothing of them but somebody else's blood.

Two sentences and both of them are load-bearing. The first one is the arithmetic - he had run the count on every person on that ferry long before I got there, and a foster girl with nobody to raise a noise came out lowest, and he did not have to think about it when the moment came because the thinking was already done. That's what a ration list is. He'd been doing it in his head for a week and calling it management.

The second sentence is the one I keep. *You'd have done the same*. He needed that. Not as an excuse - he wasn't asking me to forgive him, he was informing me. Because if I'd have done the same, then there's no better man, there never was one, the thing I held out to him on the bank was a thing nobody actually is, and he hasn't fallen short of anything. He'd rather live in a world with no finer self in it at all than live in one where there is and he didn't reach it.

That's it. That's the whole of what I've learned about people and it took me nine years. It isn't that they can't be better. Better costs, and it costs most exactly when it counts, and cruelty is free and fast and it's *warm* - and the worst part, the part I did not expect at sixteen or at twenty-five, is that afterward they will rebuild the world in their heads into one where nobody could have done otherwise. They don't carry it. They edit it. Coll went to bed that night in a town he'd saved.

I was sold to a lab at sixteen by a guardian with every chance to be better who found it too expensive. So I know the arithmetic from the inside. I was the lowest count in that house too, and I'd bet the money that she has a version now where there wasn't any other choice, and that she sleeps.

So. Nine years, and here is everything I've got.

I've read back through these and they're a catalogue of people at their worst, and I know what that reads like. It reads like somebody building a case. So let me put the other column down, because I've been keeping both and it isn't as one-sided as the pages make it look.

The woman with the notebook stayed up nights for a town that never listened to her once. Nobody made her. Coll waded into the reeds and carried Ada Voss up the bank when his own people wouldn't touch her, and his hands shook the whole way, and he didn't stop. Ezren drew that mine in the dirt from memory and got every branch right. Petrun walked the next sweep heel-to-toe on his own held breath. Serafine sat on a bench and gave me her drowned son's name because she thought I might need it. That is also nine years. Those are also the same people.

Here's the closest I've come to squaring it.

I keep expecting them to be one thing. That's my error, not theirs. I show up after the worst night of their lives and I take a reading and I write down what I find, and I have been treating that reading as the answer to *what are people*, when what it actually measures is what a person does at hour fifty of being terrified with no one coming. Nobody is at their weight class then. I've watched what fear does to a body and I have never once seen it improve one.

They aren't cruel. Cruel is a decision and most of them never got as far as deciding. They're frightened, and frightened wants two things - it wants the fear to have a shape it can hold, and it wants that shape to be somewhere other than inside itself. So it goes into a list, or a notebook, or a neighbor with odd hours, or a mother who let her boy fish past the buoys. And when I take the monster away, the fear doesn't leave with it. It has nowhere to go and it finds the nearest object, and about half the time the nearest object is me, and I would like to record that this is not personal even though it has never once felt that way.

Then the sun comes up and they have to be people again, with the things they did still in the room. Nobody can carry that. So they put it down. They edit. By the second day there's a version where the list was fair, or the Deacon held the high ground, or a wolf got a boy alone behind a silo - and they're not lying to me, they've genuinely got the new one now, and the old one is gone in a way I don't think can be undone from outside.

That's the whole of it. Not evil. Frightened animals, briefly, and then embarrassed animals forever, and the embarrassment is the part that turns and bites, because I'm the only one still standing there who remembers.

Knowing all that changes nothing about what it's like. I want to be honest with you about that too. I understand exactly why Pruitt did it and I still had to drive four hours with it.

There's one thing that would work, and I've thought about it on every job I've ever run. If I stood aside. If I let the gillheart come, let the milk-eyed things rise in every town, one shared horror with teeth for all of them - they'd hold each other's lines. They'd be decent. Nothing on this earth unites the small and the frightened like something worse at the door. I could hand them each other, whole, and all it would cost is me stepping back and some number of them I'd never have to count.

I've had the arithmetic ready for years. It's good arithmetic.

I won't.

Not because it wouldn't work. Because it's the same sentence Coll used on the boards - *she was nobody, you'd have done the same* - and I would be saying it about a whole town instead of one girl, and the only difference between us would be the size of the number.

So I go in front. It doesn't mean anything; there's no meaning out there waiting to be found, only what a person picks up and declines to set down. Everyone else at that table put theirs down because it was heavy. This is mine: nobody goes past me into the dark. Not the town that calls me a monster, not the girl with rope scars around both wrists, not the foreman who'd drown her twice.

They will not be better. I go anyway. That's the only thing in nine years that was ever mine to assign.

I don't know why I wrote this down. I've said that already. But I notice I finished it, and I notice I put a name on the front, and you're the one standing there.

Hold the line. It's yours now.

- Osyra